

HRERA orders Chintels to pay ₹4 cr to Gurugram homebuyer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority (HRERA) has ordered builder Chintels India Pvt Ltd to pay compensation of over ₹4 crore to a homebuyer, who had filed a complaint after a fatal structural collapse in Tower D revealed widespread construction defects. The complaint was filed by Delhi resident Aruna Garg, who had purchased a 4 BHK flat in Tower C of the project located in Sector 109.

According to her complaint, she paid approximately ₹1.8 crore, more than the agreed price, and took possession in October 2019. However, soon after, problems began to

appear in the flat, including broken tiles, uneven floors, and cracks in the balcony and common areas. Despite complaints, the developer did not fix these issues.

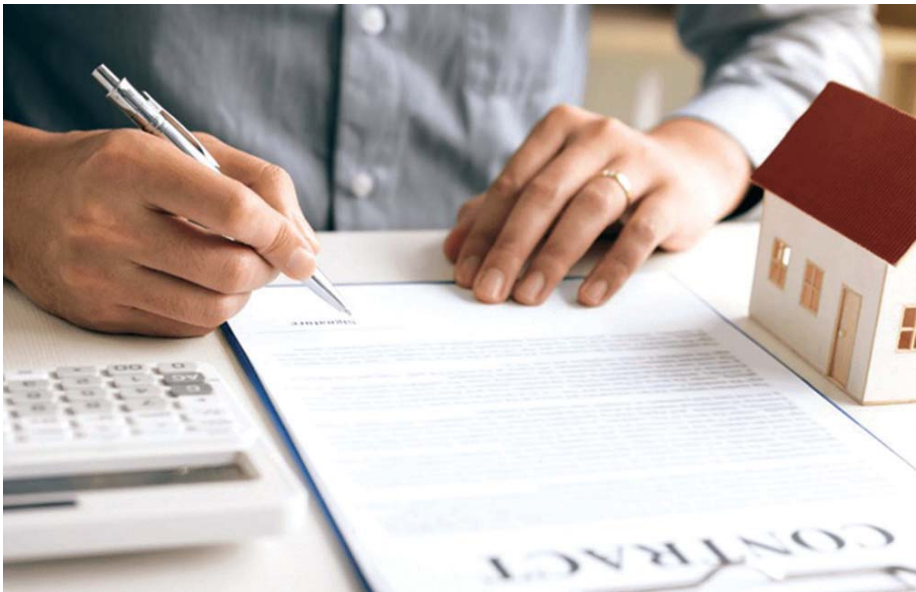
The matter came to a head on February 10, 2022, when a portion of Tower D collapsed, killing two people and injuring others. Subsequent investigations by the district administration and IIT Delhi revealed that chlorides in the concrete used in the construction had caused the steel to rust. For investors in Gurugram and broader Haryana, the decision underscores the need to assess developer track records on structural compliance and to factor in potential remediation liabilities. Projects with pending approvals or quality concerns

may face elevated regulatory scrutiny, influencing risk premiums and financing terms in the residential segment.

Experts stated that the building's condition was so poor that repairs were technically and economically unfeasible. The HRERA stated in its order that the entire project was no longer habitable and that Chintels India was solely responsible. The buyer was not to blame, having been assured of international-standard construction.

The authority, taking into account the increased property prices in Sector 109, fixed the compensation at ₹13,000 per square foot and ordered an amount of ₹4.09 crore to be paid to Garg.

"I think it is appropriate to



allow compensation to the complainant at the rate of ₹13,000 per square feet, amounting to ₹4,09,50,000 (13000x3150), including the amount of sale consideration, ie ₹1,80,04,265 already paid by the complainant. By filing an affidavit, the complainant claimed that the same paid ₹4,60,000 towards stamp duty charges at the time of registration of Conveyance Deed and in addition spent ₹3,08,065 on renovation and woodwork, etc. The fact of payment of ₹4,60,000 towards stamp charges is not denied on behalf of the respondent. However, learned counsel for the latter (respondent) doubted the expenditure of ₹3,08,065 as shown by the complainant on renovation/woodwork, etc.

The complainant did not adduce any evidence except the affidavit to verify the expenditure on renovation work/woodwork, etc. No reason to allow compensation of ₹3,08,065 in this regard. However, the same (complainant) is allowed a sum of ₹4,60,000 spent on purchase of stamp duty, to be paid by the respondent," read the order.

Further, the total amount is subject to 10.8 per cent annual interest until it is fully paid. The builder was also directed to refund ₹4.6 lakh in stamp duty, ₹2 lakh for mental harassment, and ₹50,000 as litigation expenses. However, claims for rent, EMIs and other additional claims were rejected.

CM pushes strict timelines for projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday directed all departments to ensure time-bound completion of development works announced in the 2026-27 Budget, warning against delays and calling for strict monitoring through the CM Pragati Portal.

Chairing a high-level review meeting at the Delhi Secretariat, the Chief Minister emphasised that execution and visible results are now critical to achieving the goal of a developed Delhi. She asked departments to move with urgency and accountability to deliver projects on schedule. "Timely execution is key to accelerating Delhi's development. The Pragati Portal will enable continuous monitoring and ensure transparency in implementation," the CM said during the meeting.

The meeting was attended by administrative secretaries, heads of departments, and Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma. Officials reviewed the progress and timelines of major projects and were instructed to follow clear action plans.

A key focus of the meeting was the use of the CM Pragati Portal for real-time tracking of development works. The Chief Minister directed departments to upload regular updates on progress, timelines, and upcoming milestones. This, she said, would allow close supervision and early identification of delays.

Officials have been asked to



set short-term targets ranging from 15 days to one month and report progress accordingly. The approach is aimed at ensuring continuous monitoring and quick corrective action wherever required.

The Chief Minister sent a strong message on accountability, stating that delays in project execution will not be tolerated. She directed departments to define clear goals and adhere strictly to timelines from the initial stages. She said the entire project cycle, including tendering, commencement, and completion, must follow a pre-defined schedule. Any bottlenecks should be escalated immediately instead of allowing projects to remain pending.

The Chief Minister also stressed that departmental performance will be assessed based on outcomes. She urged officials to adopt a results-oriented approach and ensure that projects are completed within the stipulated time frame. Highlighting the need for

coordination, the Chief Minister asked departments to work in a synchronised manner. She said projects should be executed in parallel so that delays in one area do not affect others. She also called for efficient use of resources and a structured implementation strategy. Departments were directed to follow phased execution plans and ensure optimal utilisation of budgetary allocations. The Chief Minister said the Government aims to complete all major projects before 2029. She instructed departments to clearly define timelines for each project, irrespective of size, and ensure steady progress.

The Chief Minister also emphasised the importance of leveraging funds and schemes from the Central Government. She said better performance and efficient execution would help Delhi access more resources and accelerate development. Officials were asked to review their targets and action plans and move forward with greater focus.

MCD Mayoral polls likely to be held soon, says Officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Elections to the posts of Mayor, Deputy Mayor and key civic panels in the Municipal Corporation of Delhi are likely to be held soon, with the process expected to take place in the last week of April, Officials said on Monday. Officials said, polls to fill three vacant seats in the standing committee from the House are also scheduled during the same window. Last year, the AAP stayed away from the mayor contest, allowing the BJP to win unopposed.

The mayoral post in Delhi follows a rotational system of five one-year terms, where the first year is reserved for women, the second for the general category, the third for the reserved category, and the remaining two again for the general category.

A new mayor is elected at the end of each financial year. Last year, the BJP reclaimed control of the MCD after a two-year gap. The previous elections had seen repeated disruptions, with sharp disagreements between AAP and BJP councillors leading to adjournments. Before that, attempts to elect a Mayor had failed amid the standoff before the process could be completed.

Rekha Gupta meets LG to discuss summer action plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday met Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu to discuss issues, including water supply, electricity management and health services, ahead of the summer. Gupta shared information on close monitoring of LPG supply chains to ensure timely availability in the city, along with expansion of petroleum and natural gas infrastructure to address shortages and curb black marketing.

"During this meeting, there was an in-depth discussion on topics related to water supply, electricity management, health services, and disaster management," the CM said in a post on X.

According to officials, CM Rekha Gupta and Sandhu further discussed matters related to strengthening heat wave preparedness and

ensuring an adequate supply of drinking water. "Our goal is to ensure that Delhi residents face no inconvenience during the summer season. The Delhi Government is taking all necessary steps and is fully prepared to ensure smooth services and better management for the citizens," she said.

The two also discussed the monsoon preparedness plans of the Government, including enhancing planning to mitigate urban flooding and the timely completion of ongoing desilting of drains, officials said. In the meeting, Sandhu emphasised seamless and effective coordination among Delhi Government departments, urban local bodies, central agencies and neighbouring States.

Later, the Lok Niwas, in a tweet, said, "Chief Minister Rekha Gupta called on Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu at



Lok Niwas today. They held detailed discussions on key issues concerning Delhi's development and public welfare, aligned with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi for Viksit Bharat and Viksit Delhi. Key focus areas included: Energy Security: Close monitoring of LPG supply chains to ensure timely availability, along with expansion of PNG infrastructure to address shortages and curb black marketing. Summer Action Plan:

Strengthening heatwave preparedness and ensuring adequate supply of drinking water. Monsoon Preparedness: Enhancing advanced planning to mitigate urban flooding, including the timely completion of ongoing desilting of drains. The importance of seamless and effective coordination among Delhi Government departments, ULBs, Central agencies, and neighbouring states was strongly emphasised."

Kejriwal argues own case in HC; recusal plea on April 13

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal on Monday emulated Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee by arguing his case in the court. The TMC supremo had presented her side of the case in the Supreme Court a few weeks ago. Delhi High Court Justice Swarnal Kanta Sharma took Kejriwal's application for her recusal on record and listed it for hearing on April 13, after she was informed that a plea for transfer of the case to another HC bench filed before the apex court has been withdrawn.

The court recorded that besides Kejriwal, the applications for recusal of the judge were also filed by AAP leaders Manish Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak.

In its order, the court also



granted time till April 10 to Kejriwal and others to file their response on the main CBI plea as a "last and final opportunity". Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the CBI, argued that the court was not a forum for theatrics and Kejriwal should discharge his lawyer if he wanted to appear in person in the case. Mehta strongly objected to the recusal application and said Kejriwal's allegations

against the "institution" were frivolous and contemptuous. "Some people in this country make a career out of making baseless allegations against everyone. That will have to be taken seriously. It is an allegation against the institution, and we will have to support that institution," Mehta said. He also informed that a total of seven discharged accused have filed applications seeking the judge's recusal as part of a

"well thought out design". "If anyone else wants to file the application, please do it, so that I can decide it once and for all," Justice Sharma said.

Kejriwal asserted that he would argue the recusal application himself and would exercise his "legal rights" on the aspect of being represented by a lawyer subsequently. He requested the court to take his application on record, as, being a litigant appearing in person, he was unable to e-file it on the high court portal.

Mehta said the agency's response to the recusal application was ready in the form of a note. He contended that, as "predicted" by him earlier, the pleas filed by Kejriwal in the Supreme Court regarding the present proceedings were still pending with the top court's registry.

DEBTS RECOVERY APPELLATE TRIBUNAL- DELHI
Apartment No. 316, 1st Floor, Huda Sector, Kirti Nagar, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110021.
Misc. Appeal No. 169/2024
T.A.No. 184/2023 (DRT- II, Delhi)
Archipelago Insurance Ltd.
Appellants Vs
IFCI Ltd. & Ors.
NOTICE
Respondents
2. M/s. Goutiophore Technology Pvt. Ltd. (GTPU)-1113, 2nd Floor, Gupta Colony, Mahipal Nagar, New Delhi-110017.
Respondent No.2
3. Mr. Aramdeep Singh Guarantor 1102/Parashasti, Sohna Road, Near Sai Dham Mandir The Ozma Niche, Sector-49, Gurugram, Haryana-122018.
Respondent No. 3
4. Mr. Ramesh Kumar Guarantor 3C142, Princeton Estate, DLF Phase-V, Gurugram, Haryana-122003.
Respondent No. 4
Whereas the notice that an appeal from the order passed by the Presiding Officer of D.R.T. in the above case has been presented by the appellant on 08.05.2024 and is registered in the Tribunal. The matter was listed before this Tribunal on 12.05.2026. Whereas it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in the ordinary way. Therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance in this Tribunal on 23.04.2026. The Publication be made in two newspapers "one in vernacular language and the other in English" which are widely circulated in the said area / last known addresses of the respondents. Whereas take notice that in default of your appearance on the day mentioned above, the case will be heard and determined in your absence. Given under my hand and the Seal of the Tribunal, this 17th day of March, 2026.
BY ORDER OF THE TRIBUNAL
Section Officer

DEBTS RECOVERY APPELLATE TRIBUNAL- DELHI
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BY ORDER OF THE TRIBUNAL
Section Officer

BSES
BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi
TENDER NOTICE
Date: 07.04.2026
Tender under two parts (Un-priced & priced) are invited for the supply of following materials from all bidders:-

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Estimated Cost (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/	SUPPLY OF VARIOUS 11KV VCB PANELS	1.45 Crore	2,90,000/-	28.04.2026 15:00 HRS	28.04.2026 15:30 HRS
FK/PR/RJ/1348	FOR OKHLA GRID IN BRPL				

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1180/-

For any query call on 011-49107235 or e-mail on Brpl.Eaution@reliancegroupindia.com
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submit of tender documents etc. please visit our website www.bsesdelhi.com

Regd. Off.: BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527
Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsesdelhi.com

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all that Prinkal Sharma W/o Suresh Sharma R/o House No.13A, Ward No.45 Aggarwal Vihar, G.T.Road, Near FC Road, Mogh, Distt-Moga, Punjab-142001. The original Property documents place of Flat No 157-B, on Ground Floor, Pocket-A-2, situated in the layout plan of Kondali, Ghazal, Mayur Vihar, Phase-II, Delhi-110096. Possession Letter, Demand Letter have been lost. An FIR to this effect has been lodged in Police Station Crime Branch Delhi & LR No. 212 305/2026. Any person(s) claiming any right, interest, having any objection or found in possession of original documents may write contact: 7814866340 with above named person at above of address within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. The person claiming any right, interest, objection with respect to this property can personally inform: D/o Director (LAB) Housing, D-Block, 3rd Floor, Vikas Sadan, INA, New Delhi-110026.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, 1st Floor, 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N. Delhi-15
legal@kumarajagpal.com Ph: 011-41152527-28

MEGH SECURITIES PRIVATE LIMITED
CIN: U74899DL1995PT072093
Regd. Office: A-20, 2nd Floor, Indraprastha Bhawan, Dr. Mukherjee Nagar Commercial Complex, Dr. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi - 110009, India
Tel. No: +91 8448845881 | Email: admin@meghsecurities.com

PUBLIC NOTICE
This notice is issued by Megh Securities Private Limited (the "Company"), a registered Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC), in compliance with RBI's Master Direction(s), following their approval letter vide DEL.DOR.NBFC.No.S1/24-03-330/2026-2027 dated April 01, 2026.
Change in Management: The Company has appointed **Mrs. Indu Bhatia** as a director. Mrs. Indu Bhatia, being part of the promoter family, is being inducted to ensure continuity in ownership and governance of the Company.
RBI Approval: This change will take effect 30 days after this notice, per RBI approval. For clarifications or objections, please contact Mr. Apoorv Bhatia, Director, at the registered office or email admin@meghsecurities.com within 30 days.

Date: 7th April 2026
Place: Delhi
For Megh Securities Private Limited
Sd/-
Apoorv Bhatia (Director)

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the general public that Mr. Chand Khan is the owner of A Residential House, area measuring 93 Sq. Yards i.e. 78.12 Sq. Meters, Part 1, Khayala No. 437, situated at the Main Road, Near Purv Ward No. 8 in Village Garhmukteshwar, Pargana & Tehsil Garhmukteshwar, District Hapur, Uttar Pradesh. The said property was duly registered in the office of St. Garhmukteshwar as per Book No. 01, Vol. No. 2814 Page No. 199-222 Document No. 480 that this said Deed has lost. All Persons are hereby informed that Mr. Chand Khan, Mr. Bilal, Mrs. Samo & Mr. Isha Khan are mortgaging the said property with financial institution & onam (ICPL) General public hereby informed that if anybody found this document or Any Person, Company, country, financial institution & onam has any claim/charge/interest in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address of the said property. Robit Kumar Advocate
Medhawi Enforcement & Legal Service
Office No. 114, Third Floor, Rishabh, Choudhary Sector-40 Vaishali Ghazalabad U.P. Mob no: 7306601626, 981871626, Email: medhawienforcement@gmail.com

म.प्र. राज्य पशुधन एवं कुक्कुट विकास नि.
(पशु आहार संयंत्र, कीरतपुर, इटारसी)
न्यू ब्रायलर भवन, मेन रोड नं.-3, कोटरा सुलतानाबाद रोड, भोपाल (म.प्र.)
दूरभाष-0755-2776086 (कार्यालय), mpdpcebpl@rediffmail.com

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण
पशु आहार संयंत्र, कीरतपुर, इटारसी में पशु आहार उत्पादन में लगने वाले कच्चे माल के क्रय हेतु e-procurement प्रणाली द्वारा ऑनलाइन निविदा (निविदा आई डी 2026_MLPDC_497631_1) आमंत्रित की जाती है।
निविदायें दिनांक 07.04.2026 से क्रय कर दिनांक 27.04.2026 तक प्रस्तुत की जा सकती हैं। विस्तृत निविदा, प्रपत्र क्रय एवं अन्य जानकारी हेतु <https://mptenders.gov.in> पर लॉग-ऑन करें।
म.प्र. माध्यम/125215/2026
प्रबंध संचालक

संचालनालय खेल और युवा कल्याण
टी.टी. नगर स्टेडियम, भोपाल, मध्यप्रदेश
ई-निविदा सूचना
संचालनालय खेल और युवा कल्याण, मध्यप्रदेश, द्वारा "प्रदेश के विभिन्न खेल मैदानों एवं खेल परिसरों, अकादमियों में बड़े, छोटे पौधे, गमले एवं हरी नेट प्रदाय एवं रख-रखाव हेतु" अनुभवी प्रदायकर्ता से ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रपत्र व निविदा की विस्तृत शर्तें www.mptenders.gov.in पर उपलब्ध हैं। ई-निविदा प्रकाशन उपरांत निविदा में कोई संशोधन व परिवर्तन किया जाता है तो वह मात्र उपरोक्त उल्लेखित ई-टेंडर पोर्टल पर ही उपलब्ध रहेगा।
म.प्र. माध्यम/125223/2026
संचालक

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE
SR NO. NAME OF DEPARTMENT NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL

1	PWD B&R, HANSI	CONSTRUCTION OF GOVT. VETERINARY DISPENSARY AT VILLAGE PANGHAL IN HISAR DISTT. (NABARD RIDF-XXIX) (WITHOUT GST)	02.04.2026 08.04.2026	24.61 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8053857200 xempvhdansi@gmail.com
2	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, SIRSA	KUMTHAL- LAYING OF 150 MM I/D D.I RISING MAIN, CONSTRUCTION OF BOUNDARY WALL / IRON GATE AND CONSTRUCTION OF 1 NO. TUBEWELL CHAMBER OF SIZE 10'x12' AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO.	04.04.2026 10.04.2026	12.48 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467070175 eepsirsa@gmail.com
3	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, SIRSA	SIRSA TOWN- DESILTING OF 400MM, 500MM AND 600MM I/D RCC SEWER LINE BY SUPER SUCKER MACHINE IN PREET NAGAR, PREM NAGAR CHATTARGARH PATTI, CIVIL HOSPITAL ROAD C-BLOCK, MAIN GALI KIRTI NAGAR AND OLD HOUSING BOARD AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO IN SIRSA TOWN DISTT. SIRSA.	04.04.2026 10.04.2026	47.64 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467070175 eepsirsa@gmail.com
4	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, MARNIAUL	REPAIR V.R. BRIDGE AT KM 3.960 OF EXPERIMENTAL CHANNEL + 3 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 09.04.2026	5.12 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01282-251214 xen-wsrnl.irrig@gov.in
5	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, SIRSA	INTERNAL AND OUTER CLEARANCE OF SHERANWALI DISTY. FROM RD. 0 TO 66000 FOR RABI SEASON 2025-26 (SHERANWALI SECTION). + 7 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 09.04.2026	31.19 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466063030 xennehrana@yahoo.com
6	CIVIL SURGEON, JIND	SUPPLY OF DIET PREGNANT WOMEN IN MATERNITY WARD CH JIND & OTHER HEALTH INSTITUTION DISTRICT JIND	03.04.2026 20.04.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	7015444191 cde.jind@gmail.com
7	PANCHAYATI RAJ, BHIWANI	CONSTRUCTION OF HALL IN GURU RAVIDAS SAMAJ KALYAN SABHA AT BHIWANI CITY MP LAD + 9 WORKS	03.04.2026 08.04.2026	231.85 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01664243927 prexeeng.bhw@gmail.com
8	PANCHAYATI RAJ, RAJOUND	CONST. OF BALMIKI CHOUHAL IN SIDADA PATTI AT VILLAGE MAJRA NAND KARAN BLOCK RAJOUND DISTT. KATHAL	03.04.2026 08.04.2026	11.31 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8630071961 sdoprajajund@gmail.com
9	PANCHAYATI RAJ, RAJOUND	COMPLETION OF VISHVAKARMA COMMUNITY CENTRE (JAKHOULI KAMAN)	03.04.2026 08.04.2026	7.68 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8630071961 sdoprajajund@gmail.com
10	PANCHAYATI RAJ, FARIDABAD	CONSTRUCTION OF DRAINS AND TREATMENT PROCEDURE OF WASTE WATER (GWM) AT VILLAGE BEHBALPUR BLOCK BALLABGARH DISTRICT FARIDABAD + 6 WORKS	02.04.2026 09.04.2026	288.63 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467905067 prexeeng.fdb1@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in
RO 44660-I-27-7

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the general public that Axis Bank Limited, having its branch at Gurugram Haryana, proposes to extend a loan facility to Sh. Aman Soni (Borrowers) against mortgage of DDA's Freshhold Plot bearing No.1361 on Ground Floor and First Floor in Pocket 1, in Block B, in the layout plan of Housing Estate of Vasant Kunj, situated at Vasant Kunj, New Delhi ("Said Property"). As per the available records, Sh. Om Parkash Khetarpal S/o Late Sh. Manish Lal Khetarpal, was the absolute owner of the Said Property by virtue of a Sale Deed dated 04.08.2009, duly registered as Document No. 6163 on 05.08.2009 with the office of the concerned Sub-Registrar. Subsequently, Late Sh. Om Parkash Khetarpal expired on 17.09.2025 and his wife, Late Smt. Poonam Khetarpal, expired on 24.11.2019. Consequently upon their demise, their legal heirs furnished the requisite documents, and the Said Property was duly mutated in favour of Sh. Manish Khetarpal (33.33% share), S/o Late Sh. Om Parkash Khetarpal and Late Smt. Poonam Khetarpal, and that the Said Property is free from all encumbrances, charges, liens, mortgages, claims, or any third-party interests of whatsoever nature. Any person(s), financial institution (s), bank(s), or entity having any claim, right, title, interest, objection, charge, lien, mortgage, encumbrance, or demand whatsoever in respect of the Said Property are hereby required to notify the undersigned in writing along with supporting documentary evidence within **Fifteen (15) days** from the date of publication of this notice. In case no such claim or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be presumed that no person has any claim, objection, or interest in the Said Property, and Axis Bank Limited shall proceed with the proposed loan transaction, and shall not be held responsible or liable for any claims, objections, or liabilities arising thereat in respect of the Said Property.

Himanshu Ahuja (Advocate)
Contact No.: 011-41830049 E-mail: ahojagat@gmail.com

A bouquet, a blast of ink, and a question that hung over Assembly

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

The flowers were still lying near the porch when investigators arrived. The bouquet placed with apparent deliberation outside the office of Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta is what made Monday's security breach at the Delhi Assembly something more unsettling than a traffic accident or an act of impulse. Someone had planned this. Someone had brought flowers.

At around 2 pm, a Tata Sierra bearing a Uttar Pradesh registration plate came fast down the approach to Gate No 2 of the Delhi Assembly. The driver was masked. The car hit the iron barricade, pushed through it, and rolled onto the premises. The gate gave way. The CRPF person-

nel deployed at the VIP entrance were at a different point. Gate No 2, sources would later explain, had lighter deployment when the House was not in session. By the time security personnel realised what had happened, the car was already moving toward the inner precincts.

A guard who was near the gate described the moments after impact. "It happened very fast. The car did not slow down. By the time we moved, it was already inside." He did not want to be named. His hands, as he spoke, were still.

The driver stopped near the Speaker's porch. He got out, placed the bouquet, threw ink on the Speaker's official car parked nearby, returned to the vehicle, reversed sharply, and drove out before anyone could block his path. The whole



(L-R) Forensic team inspecting after an SUV driven by a masked man forced its way through one of the boundary gates of the Delhi Assembly premises in New Delhi on Monday. Police personnel inspecting a flower bouquet and nearby areas

operation took minutes. When media personnel reached the spot in the early evening, the atmosphere outside Gate No 2 was tense and oddly quiet. Additional security personnel had been deployed along the perime-

ter. A bomb disposal unit had swept the premises as a precautionary measure, officials clarified, and no device was found. But the yellow tape and the cluster of investigators near the porch told their own story.



PTI

An assembly staffer who had been inside the complex when the car entered said he heard commotion before he understood what was happening. "People started running. Someone shouted that a car had broken

through. We did not know if it was an accident or something else." He paused. "After the bomb threat last month, you think the worst."

He was referring to March 25, when the Delhi Assembly received an email claiming

that 16 RDX-based IEDs had been planted inside the complex. That threat had led to intensive searches and a security review. Monday's breach arrived barely 10 days later.

Special Commissioner of Police (Law and Order) Ravindra Yadav was at the site by evening, coordinating the response personally. He confirmed that CCTV footage had been used to identify the suspect named by police as Sarabjit Singh and that alerts had been flashed to adjoining States. "Police teams were formed to track down the vehicle and its occupants," Yadav said. By late evening, three people had been detained, and the car was recovered from north Delhi.

The ink on the Speaker's official vehicle had dried by the time forensic teams pho-

tographed it. Around it, the premises wore the look of a place still making sense of itself. A constitutional institution, guarded by multiple layers of security, broke quiet and still, somehow, breached by a man with a bouquet and a plan.

Outside the gate, a small group of people had gathered on the pavement. One of them, a tea vendor who operates his stall near the assembly road, watched the police vehicles come and go. "This gate," he said, nodding toward Gate No 2, "is always quieter than the main one." He seemed to understand, in the way people who watch places do, exactly what that quietness had cost on Monday afternoon. The investigation continues. The flowers, presumably, have been taken into evidence.

Pragati Maidan Underpass 5: Final NOC cleared for December completion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A project that had long come to symbolise delay and administrative gridlock in the heart of the Capital has finally been unlocked. The ITPO Tunnel — Underpass 5 at Pragati Maidan has now received its final and most critical clearance, with the Indian Railways granting the long-pending NOC, PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Monday.

With this, all major technical and inter-agency hurdles that had kept the project stuck for years have now been resolved. The underpass, a key link in Delhi's central traffic network, is now firmly back on track and will be completed by December 2026, he informed.

Speaking on the development, the minister said, "This project had been stuck for years due to pending clearances and lack of coordination. We approached it with a clear intent — to resolve issues, not to pass responsibility. I personally met the railway authorities multiple times and visited the site to ensure that every concern was addressed. With this NOC, the final hurdle has been cleared. The focus now is on execution, speed, and accountability."



This moment marks not just a routine approval, but the resolution of a prolonged infrastructure deadlock. Located at one of Delhi's busiest and most sensitive traffic zones, the project had remained incomplete despite significant public investment, primarily due to complex engineering challenges and a lack of coordinated decision-making across agencies.

The first major breakthrough came in August 2025, when the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs approved a revised execution plan submitted by PWD. That approval addressed core technical concerns that had halted construction midway — particularly soil settlement beneath the structure and the need for design modifications near

the railway embankment. Under the approved plan, critical corrective measures were identified, including stabilisation of the foundation through grouting, structural stitching beneath the railway line to ensure safety, and adoption of a revised cast-in-situ construction methodology suited to on-ground conditions.

Importantly, this solution was cleared with a clear directive that the project would be completed within existing sanctioned funds, without placing any additional burden on the exchequer.

However, even after MoHUA's approval, the project could not move forward due to the absence of final clearance from Railways, given the proximity of the structure to active railway infrastructure. This

remained the last and most crucial hurdle. That hurdle has now been crossed. The breakthrough follows sustained intervention by Parvesh Sahib Singh, who took direct ownership of the issue. Recognising both the public importance of the project and the urgency of its completion, the Minister personally engaged with the railway authorities through multiple high-level meetings and made several site visits to assess and resolve technical concerns.

This hands-on approach helped bridge coordination gaps that had persisted for years and ensured alignment between all stakeholders involved. For a long time, Underpass-5 remained a stalled project in the middle of a high-visibility zone — incomplete, underutilised, and emblematic of delayed execution. With successive clearances now in place, that phase has ended.

Underpass-5 is a vital component of Delhi's broader infrastructure network. Once operational, it will ease congestion around Pragati Maidan and the ITO corridor, improve east-central connectivity, and ensure smoother traffic flow during major national and international events hosted at the ITPO complex.

Government to redevelop and beautify spaces under flyovers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant push to improve the city's urban landscape, the Delhi Government on Monday signed a key MoU to redevelop and beautify spaces beneath flyovers. The initiative aims to turn under-utilised and often neglected stretches beneath flyovers into clean, organised and visually appealing public spaces. The agreement was formalised in the presence of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

The Public Works Department (PWD) has partnered under CSR initiatives with Dalmia Bharat Limited, Godrej Industries Group and EaseMyTrip Foundation to execute the project. The Chief Minister said the Government is working closely with the private sector to accelerate public welfare projects and enhance the city's overall infrastructure.

Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh and senior officials from concerned departments were also present at the event. Rekha Gupta said the plan is to convert neglected spaces under flyovers into vibrant, functional areas for public use.

These spaces will feature green zones, wall murals,



seating arrangements, improved sanitation systems and other civic amenities, helping them evolve into recognisable urban landmarks.

Calling it a step towards a 'clean and beautiful Delhi,' the Chief Minister thanked the participating organisations and said such public-private collaborations would help transform the capital into a modern, clean and attractive city. She also expressed confidence that initiatives like this would contribute to India's broader vision of becoming a developed nation by 2047.

Parvesh Sahib Singh described the project as a meaningful step towards reshaping Delhi's urban infrastructure.

Under the project, different companies will take up beautification work

across several flyovers. EaseMyTrip Foundation will redevelop the Apasara Border flyover stretch (from the MCD toll tax booth to the UP border, approx. 800 metres) and the Mayur Vihar Phase-I flyover (from Kanain Road cut to Samachar Apartments, approx 820 metres). Godrej Industries Group will develop the Netaji Subhash Place (NSP) flyover stretch (from Ring Road to NSP Metro Station, approx 570 metres).

Dalmia Bharat Limited will take up the Oberoi flyover (from Neela Gumbad to Golf Links, approx 700 metres), the Lodhi flyover (from Oberoi Hotel to Shamsan Ghat BRT Road, approx 700 metres), and the Mangi Setu/Hanuman Setu stretch (from Red Fort to Salimgarh Fort, approx 400 metres).

DU EWS, DG admissions: Draw of lots held for 55,701 seats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday conducted the computerised draw of lots for admissions to entry-level classes (Nursery/KG/Class 1) under the Economically Weaker Section (EWS), Disadvantaged Group (DG), and Children With Special Needs (CWSN) categories for the 2026-27 academic session, with over 55,000 seats on offer across private schools. Officials said the total number of seats has increased significantly.

A total of 55,701 seats have been made available this year, compared to 50,516 in the previous year. Under the EWS and DG categories, the

number of seats has increased from 44,045 to 48,092, while the number of CWSN seats has risen from 6,471 to 7,609. The number of participating schools has also gone up. A total of 2,308 schools are part of the admission process this year, compared to 2,219 in the previous session.

The draw, organised by the Directorate of Education at the Old Secretariat, was carried out in the presence of parents and stakeholders to ensure transparency. Education Minister Ashish Sood formally initiated and supervised the process. "The Government is committed to ensuring that every eligible child gets access to quality education through a fair and

transparent system," Sood said after the draw. He added that technology and verification measures have strengthened the process this year.

According to official data, the Directorate of Education received 1,39,524 applications for admissions this year. Out of these, 1,38,536 applications under the EWS and DG categories were found to be complete. In the CWSN category, complete applications increased to 988 from 904 last year.

The minister said the Government has introduced Aadhaar-based verification and improved software systems developed by the National Informatics Centre to eliminate duplicate and fake applications. These steps have



helped ensure that benefits reach genuine applicants.

He also pointed to past data, stating that during the 2024-25 session, a total of 2,40,084 applications were received, of which more than

one lakh were found to be duplicates or fake. This, he said, had distorted the process earlier and reduced chances for deserving candidates.

The draw process itself was conducted in a transpar-

ent manner, with a presentation-based system and active participation of parents. Officials said parents were directly involved in drawing lots, which helped build trust in the system.

Authorities clarified that once the draw results are finalised, no changes can be made. School allotments were issued immediately after the draw. The admission process has also been simplified this year. Document verification will now be conducted digitally through mobile systems, reducing the need for parents to visit schools multiple times.

The next stage of admissions is expected to begin within three days. Sood said that the Government's focus remains

on inclusivity and equal opportunity in education. The minister also noted a decline in the number of applications compared to previous years. He attributed this to improvements in Government schools, including the opening of CM Shri Schools, which have increased public confidence in the system.

According to him, more parents are now opting for Government schools, reflecting a shift in perception about public education in Delhi. Officials said the draw marks a key step in ensuring access to education for economically weaker sections and children with special needs, while maintaining transparency and efficiency in the process.

SC, ST, OBC scholarship applications open till April 30

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday invited applications for scholarships from SC, ST and OBC category students for the academic year 2025-26, according to an official notice.

The notice said five state-funded schemes and several centrally sponsored schemes are open for eligible students studying in schools, colleges and universities in Delhi. The last date for submission of applications is April 30, and applications can be submitted through the e-district portal.

Among the key schemes, the Government is offering reimbursement of tuition and other compulsory fees for the students of the three categories studying in Classes 1 to 12 in recognised schools in Delhi. The benefit is avail-



able to students from families with an annual income of up to ₹3 lakh, subject to academic performance and attendance conditions, it stated.

It further mentioned that a merit scholarship scheme has also been announced for SC/ST/OBC students enrolled in professional, technical and higher education courses. Financial assistance under this scheme ranges from ₹8,000 to ₹24,000 per

annum, depending on the level of study and whether the student is a hosteller or a day scholar. Students must have secured at least 60 per cent marks in the previous academic year to be eligible.

In addition, the Government will award ₹25,000 to toppers from these categories under the Dr BR Ambedkar State Topper Award in each discipline across universities, the depart-

ment said. The 'Mukhyamantri Vidyarthi Pratibha Yojana' will provide annual assistance of ₹5,000 for students in classes 9 and 10 and ₹10,000 for those in classes 11 and 12, subject to income and academic criteria, it read.

The department is also offering financial assistance to SC students for pursuing higher studies abroad at the master's and PhD levels, it said. Selected candidates can receive up to ₹5 lakh per annum, with a maximum cap of ₹10 lakh for master's programmes and ₹20 lakh for doctoral studies, subject to eligibility conditions including income limits and age criteria, the statement said.

It said the schemes aim to support students from disadvantaged backgrounds in continuing their education and improving access to higher studies.

Bomb threat email triggers evacuation at DU colleges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two prominent Delhi University colleges, Ramjas College and Miranda House, were evacuated on Monday morning after receiving a bomb threat email that warned of multiple explosions on campus. According to officials, the threatening email was sent to the official email addresses of the college principals at around 8.17 am. The message raised alarm by claiming that a series of blasts would take place later in the day, around 12.50 pm.

The sender also alleged that as many as 13 bombs filled with toxic gases had been planted within the college premises. The nature of the threat caused immediate concern over the safety of students, faculty, and staff.

A senior police officer confirmed that Ramjas College and Miranda House were the institutions mentioned in the threat. Interestingly, while the body of the email did not clearly elaborate on the bomb threat, the subject line carried a direct warning about possible explosions. Authorities acted swiftly after the email



Ramjas College

was flagged. Police teams, along with Bomb Disposal Teams and Dog Squads, were rushed to both campuses to carry out thorough checks. "No chances were taken in such a situation. Immediate precautionary steps were initiated to ensure safety," a police officer said.

Evacuation of both campuses began soon after the threat was received. Students, teaching staff, and other employees were asked to leave the premises in an orderly manner. They were moved to safe locations while security teams began their search operations.

Officials said the evacuation was carried out promptly to minimise any potential risk. College authorities also coordinated closely with the police to ensure that the process remained calm and controlled. Search operations were conducted across key areas of both campuses. Teams scanned classrooms, administrative blocks, open spaces, and other facilities to check for any suspicious objects or devices.

The deployment of specialised units such as Bomb Disposal Teams and Dog Squads was part of standard protocol in handling such threats. Officials said these teams are trained to detect explosives and assess risks in sensitive situations. Students present on campus at the time described a tense atmosphere as the evacuation unfolded.

"We were asked to leave immediately. There was confusion at first, but the authorities handled it quickly," said a student from one of the colleges. Another student said the situation caused panic initially, but added that instructions were clear. "We were told to move out calmly. Security personnel were guiding everyone," the student said.

Uttar Pradesh emerging as a global hub for Medical and MICE tourism



World Health Day, observed every year on April 7, marks the founding of the World Health Organisation in 1948 and reminds us of a simple but powerful truth: a healthy society is the foundation of a prosperous nation. The theme for 2026 is Together for Health. Stand with Science's emphasis on the importance of collective responsibility and scientific thinking in shaping healthier communities. At a time when lifestyle-related diseases are rising across the world, health can no longer be viewed merely as a personal concern. It must be understood within a broader social, environmental and policy framework. In this changing context, tourism in Uttar Pradesh is increasingly emerging as more than just an economic driver. It is gradually becoming an important medium for promoting healthier lifestyles, reconnecting people with nature and encouraging holistic well-being. The years

following the Covid-19 pandemic have brought about a noticeable shift in the way people travel. Increasingly, travellers are seeking destinations that offer calm, nature and opportunities for physical and mental rejuvenation. Uttar Pradesh has responded to this emerging trend by strengthening its eco-tourism initiatives. Biodiversity-rich destinations such as Dudhwa National Park, Katarniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary, Nawabganj Bird Sanctuary and Sur Sarovar Bird Sanctuary are drawing a growing number of visitors. These locations offer far more than sightseeing. Surrounded by forests, wetlands and open skies, they provide visitors the rare opportunity to disconnect from the pressures of urban life and reconnect with nature. Such environments contribute significantly to mental relaxation and overall well-being. Through carefully planned initiatives that emphasise sustainability, local participation and conservation, Uttar Pradesh Tourism has begun giving eco-tourism in the State a distinct and responsible identity. Alongside nature-based tourism, Uttar Pradesh also possesses immense potential in the



field of wellness tourism. Few regions in the world offer such a powerful blend of cultural heritage, spirituality and natural landscapes. Cities like Varanasi, Prayagraj and Ayodhya, often seen as forming a spiritual triangle, attract millions seeking inner peace and reflection. At the same time, the Vindhya region and the Terai belt provide tranquil natural settings that offer relaxation for both body and mind. Together, these diverse landscapes and traditions position Uttar Pradesh as a promising destination for holistic health tourism. The theme of World Health Day also reminds us of the impor-

tance of science in shaping modern healthcare approaches. In Uttar Pradesh, efforts are increasingly being made to integrate traditional wellness practices with contemporary tourism infrastructure. Yoga, Ayurveda and nature-based therapies are being promoted in ways that combine ancient wisdom with scientific understanding. One example is the proposed development of the Sharda Barrage area in Lakhimpur Kheri as a destination for accommodation and wellness tourism. Similarly, the expansion of yoga and meditation centres in cities such as Kashi and Mathura, along with the potential development of

Ayurvedic resorts, can significantly strengthen the state's wellness tourism ecosystem. Beyond wellness, Uttar Pradesh is also witnessing the emergence of medical tourism as a promising sector. With improving healthcare infrastructure and growing hospitality facilities, the State is steadily positioning itself as an attractive destination for patients and visitors from across India and abroad. A major initiative in this direction is the proposed development of a large hospitality hub spread across nearly 100 acres near IT City in Noida. Plans are also underway to expand advanced health and wellness facilities in Gautam Buddha Nagar. Such projects could play an important role in strengthening Uttar Pradesh's position in both medical and wellness tourism. Connectivity improvements are further accelerating this transformation. The upcoming Noida International Airport at Jewar is expected to significantly enhance tourism, trade and economic activity across the State. Improved connectivity will make it easier for domestic and international visitors to access important spiritual and cultural

centres such as Sarnath and the Shri Kashi Vishwanath Temple. At the same time, enhanced connectivity will strengthen the state's prospects in medical tourism and MICE tourism — meetings, incentives, conferences and exhibitions. International patients, healthcare professionals and participants attending global conferences and events will find it easier to travel to the region. The airport and the planned multimodal cargo hub are also expected to benefit local industries and communities. Artisans, Banarasi saree weavers, farmers and MSMEs will gain improved access to national and international markets, strengthening both the tourism economy and the broader development ecosystem of the State. What is emerging today is a new model of tourism in Uttar Pradesh, one that integrates health, sustainability and economic opportunity. The sector is no longer limited to sightseeing or pilgrimage alone. Instead, it is gradually evolving into a powerful instrument for social and economic transformation. These initiatives are generating new employment opportunities, particularly in rural and

remote areas. The integration of eco-tourism, wellness tourism and traditional healing practices is encouraging local entrepreneurship while also promoting balanced regional development. Digital technologies and improved infrastructure have also made tourism services more efficient, accessible and visitor-friendly, strengthening confidence among travellers. World Health Day 2026, therefore, offers a timely opportunity to reflect on a broader understanding of health. Good health does not depend solely on hospitals or medical treatment. It is closely linked with our environment, our lifestyles and the spaces in which we live and travel. If Uttar Pradesh continues to move forward with a focus on sustainable tourism, environmental conservation and community participation, it can create not only economic prosperity but also a healthier and more balanced society. In doing so, the state has the potential to emerge as a strong global destination where tourism, health and development move forward together.

The writer is Tourism and Culture Minister, Government of Uttar Pradesh

Punjab Police dismantled ISI-backed terror module

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

In a well-coordinated intelligence-led operation, the Counter Intelligence wing of Punjab Police has dismantled an ISI-backed terror module being run by Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs). Three accused have been apprehended, and two hand grenades along with a foreign-made Glock pistol have been recovered, police officials said on Monday. The operation highlights strong cross-border linkages, with the recovered hand grenades bearing clear markings of the Pakistan Ordnance Factory (POF). This recovery points to the supply of arms and explosives from Pakistan for use in anti-India activities. One of the three accused was arrested from Ahmedabad in a swift coor-

ordinated operation carried out with the Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS), Gujarat while the remaining two were taken into custody in Punjab. Preliminary investigations have revealed that the module was involved in the systematic targeting of police establishments across multiple states. Intelligence inputs suggest the group was planning coordinated strikes on security installations but the timely intervention by Punjab Police and its partner agencies has successfully averted what could have been a major threat. An FIR has been registered under the Explosive Substances Act and the Arms Act at the Police Station of the State Special Operation Cell (SSOC), Amritsar. Further probe is underway to trace the full network, including handlers and financiers operating from across the

border. "Efforts are ongoing to identify, track, and apprehend other members of the module," police sources confirmed. This breakthrough comes as part of Punjab Police's sustained campaign against terror networks attempting to destabilise the state through proxy modules. The involvement of PIOs in the module once again underscores the ISI's strategy of exploiting diaspora connections for subversive activities inside India. The Director General of Police, Punjab, Gaurav Yadav, has commended the Counter Intelligence team and the Gujarat ATS for the seamless inter-state coordination that led to the arrests and seizures. Security agencies remain on high alert, with intensified checks being carried out across sensitive locations, sources added.

MoS Kirti to visit Myanmar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

At the invitation of the Government of Myanmar, Minister of State for External Affairs and Environment, Forest & Climate Change, Kirti Vardhan Singh, will undertake an official visit to Myanmar from April 8 to 11, 2026. The visit underscores India's continued commitment to strengthening bilateral ties with its eastern neighbour and enhancing cooperation across key sectors. During the visit, Singh will represent India at the inauguration ceremony of the new President of the Republic of the Union of Myanmar, scheduled to take place on April 10 in Nay Pyi Taw. His participation in this significant national event reflects the importance India attaches to its diplomatic engagement with Myanmar and its support for ongoing political processes in the country. Beyond the ceremonial engagement, KV



Singh is expected to hold meetings with senior dignitaries of the Government of Myanmar in Nay Pyi Taw. These discussions are likely to focus on advancing bilateral cooperation in areas such as trade, connectivity, development assistance, and environmental collaboration. India and Myanmar share a multifaceted partnership, with initiatives spanning infrastructure development, capacity building, and cross-border connectivity projects that are crucial for regional integration.

Hindu temples targeted in Canada

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Members of the banned Khalistani organisation Sikhs for Justice staged protests outside two Hindu temples in Brampton and Surrey on April 5, shortly after Canada's House of Commons passed Bill C-9, an anti-hate legislation aimed at restricting demonstrations near places of worship. The bill, approved on March 25 by the House of Commons of Canada, seeks to criminalise acts such as blocking access to religious sites and promoting hate through symbols linked to extremist or terrorist causes. It will now move to the Senate and require royal assent before becoming law. Once enacted, it could prevent groups from organising targeted protests outside religious institutions. Demonstrations, protesters gathered near temples in both cities, waving Khalistan flags and chanting slogans.

Opposition notices on motion to remove CEC rejected

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan on Monday rejected separate notices from the opposition to move a motion for the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar from his post. The opposition had submitted notices to the Lok Sabha speaker and the Rajya Sabha chairman against the CEC, alleging "partisan and discriminatory conduct in office", "deliberate obstruction of investigation of electoral fraud" and "mass disenfranchisement" among other charges. In separate orders, the Speaker and the Rajya Sabha Chairman refused to admit the notices moved under Article 324(5) of the

Constitution, read with other relevant constitutional and statutory provisions, praying for the removal of Gyanesh Kumar as the Chief Election Commissioner. "After due consideration of the notice of Motion and a careful and objective assessment of all relevant aspects and issues involved, the Chairman, Rajya Sabha, in exercise of the powers vested to him under Section 3 of the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968, has refused to admit the said notice of Motion," a notification from the Rajya Sabha Secretary General said. It said the notice of Motion dated March 12, 2026, signed by 63 members of the Rajya Sabha under Article 324(5) of the Constitution, was submitted to the Rajya Sabha Chairman.

Major security breach shakes Delhi Assembly

Authorities are now reviewing whether the act was deliberate or a case of reckless driving, though the sequence: a masked driver, a bouquet, ink thrown on the Speaker's vehicle, a planned exit, strongly points toward intent. The incident has raised serious questions about the complex's security preparedness. The Delhi Assembly had already been under heightened security following a bomb threat received via email on March 25, during the recently concluded Budget Session. That message had claimed that 16 RDX-based improvised explosive devices had been planted within the premises, prompting immediate checks by law enforcement agencies. Monday's breach now raises the stakes further. The car broke through not one but multiple layers of security: barricades, the gate itself, before reaching the inner zone of the complex where the Speaker's office is located. That a vehicle could penetrate this far, at a constitutional institution in the heart of the national capital, without being intercepted, is a question that security agencies will be pressed to answer. Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha also visited the Delhi Assembly premises to get the first hand briefing from his subordinates. The motive behind the act remains under examination.

Iran says no to ceasefire, seeks guarantees...

Iran's response, structured as a 10-clause framework, goes significantly beyond the terms of an immediate truce. Central to its position is the demand for a permanent end to conflict — not only involving Iran but also extending to flashpoints in Lebanon and Gaza — along with binding guarantees to prevent any future escalation. The proposal also calls for recognition of Iran's authority over the Strait of Hormuz, a vital global transit route, including the right to regulate maritime traffic and impose transit fees. Additionally, Tehran is pressing for the full removal of international economic sanctions and compensation for war-related damages that have strained its economy. Iran further seeks formal acknowledgment of its right to enrich uranium under the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), reiterating its long-standing stance that its nuclear program is civilian in nature. The response comes amid heightened tensions, as US President Donald Trump weighs next steps ahead of a self-imposed deadline linked to Iran's actions in the Strait of Hormuz. Speaking to reporters, Trump suggested Washington retains multiple options, including military escalation, while emphasising his objective to "finish it up." He also repeated US concerns over Iran's nuclear ambitions — claims Tehran continues to deny. Trump, in a Monday press conference, doubled down on his hardline stance against Iran, insisting the country must not acquire nuclear weapons.

"They're animals and we have to stop them — and we can't let them have a nuclear weapon. Very simple," Trump said. When asked about extending the deadline given to Iran, he added, "I gave them a chance and I hope they take the chance. If they don't, it's trouble." Trump confirmed that envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner are engaged in talks with Tehran, and Vice President JD Vance may also join the discussions. Addressing critics at home, the president dismissed Americans opposed to military action as "foolish," emphasising, "the war is about one thing — Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon."

Cops handed death penalty in custodial...

The convicts include former inspector S Sridhar, former sub-inspectors Balakrishnan and Raghu Ganesh, and head constables Murugan and Saamidurai. In addition to the capital punishment, the court imposed a combined fine of ₹1.40 crore on the convicts to be paid as compensation to the victims' family. While pronouncing the quantum of sentence, the judge said the police are meant to protect the common man, and when they become the perpetrators of such brutality, the law must act as a deterrent. The judge stressed that the punishment must be severe enough to ensure such horrors never recur. The tragedy dates back to June 2020, when Jayaraj and Bennix were picked up for allegedly keeping their mobile phone shop open beyond permitted hours. They were subjected to extreme physical assault while in custody, leading to their deaths at a hospital days later.

Viral video probe botched, ATS uncovers...

Amitabh Yash, ADG (Law and Order), Uttar Pradesh Police confirmed the module's leadership and operations, underscoring the gravity of the security breach the initial clean chit may have enabled. The case revolves around Aaqib Khan, also referred to as Aqib or Akib, a Meerut resident currently living in Dubai, where he claims to work as a driver. Six months ago, in November 2025, a video went viral on Instagram showing Aaqib and others, including Majul (a Bijnor native running a salon in South Africa) displaying what appeared to be an AK-47 assault rifle and a hand grenade. The clip sparked alarm, leading to an FIR being registered on November 23, 2025 at Najibabad police station against Aaqib, Majul and unidentified persons. During the initial probe by the police, Inspector Satyendra Singh Malik (SHO at the time) contacted Aaqib via video call. Aaqib claimed the AK-47 was a plastic toy and the grenade was merely a perfume bottle. Police accepted this explanation without independent verification, filed a final

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report terming the items as toys, and closed the matter, effectively giving Aaqib and others a clean chit. Circle Officer Najibabad, Nitesh Pratap Singh was also involved in the supervisory oversight. However, the case resurfaced dramatically on April 2, 2026, when the UP ATS arrested four suspects from Lucknow, identified as Saqib alias 'Devil', the Meerut-based alleged leader, also spelled Shakib, Arbaab, Vikas Gehlawat alias Raunak, and Lokesh alias Babu alias Papla Pandit. Their interrogation revealed they were planning acts of sabotage, including blowing up a railway signal box, targeting vehicles carrying gas cylinders to trigger explosions, and carrying out arson to create panic. The group allegedly shared videos of these acts with Pakistan-based handlers via social media and received payments through QR codes. Seven mobile phones recovered from the accused contained incriminating material, including videos of arson and individuals posing with assault rifles. Saqib disclosed that Aaqib Khan had acted as a key conduit, facilitating contact between the module and a Pakistan-based ISI handler named Abu Bakar. Aaqib, who issued a clarification video from Dubai denying any terror links, is now under renewed focus. The ATS has secured a five-day remand of the arrested suspects until April 9 for further interrogation.

SC hands Malda case to NIA

The court, after perusing the video of a woman judicial officer expressing anxiety over the safety of her kith and kin, made clear that "the Central forces will not be withdrawn from West Bengal looking at the way things have happened in the recent past." The SC expressed concern over reported threats and obstruction faced by judicial officers during the revision process and warned that if state machinery fails to ensure safety, it would consider appropriate measures. "If state machinery fails, then we will see what can be done," the bench said. The bench took note of the submissions of Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, represented by senior advocate Shyam Divan, that 19 appellate tribunals, set up to hear pleas against wrongful deletions or additions, are yet to become operational. The CJ asked the Chief Justice of the Calcutta HC to constitute a three-member panel of former senior judges to frame uniform procedures for these tribunals. During the hearing which commenced at 4 pm, the bench referred to a letter from the Calcutta High Court Chief Justice and said that judicial officers decided over 59.15 lakh claims and objections out of approximately 60 lakh cases by noon on April 6. The bench observed that even in Malda district, where several judicial officers reportedly faced disruptions including gherao, around eight lakh cases had been disposed of. The Election

Commission of India, represented by senior advocate DS Naidu, informed the bench that the remaining claims would be decided during the day and that a supplementary electoral roll would be published later on Monday night. The court also allowed time until April 7 for completing pending digital signature uploads. During the hearing, the bench emphasised the need to create an environment enabling tribunals to function effectively and fairly. "Let us create an atmosphere where tribunals can maximise their outputs," the CJ said. Justice Bagchi underscored that the role of the Election Commission is to expand electoral participation rather than restrict it.

PM Modi revives UCC, ONOE push on BJP...

Highlighting that the BJP-led NDA has completed 25 years of existence, the PM said it is the only coalition that has been working for the interests of the country and the welfare of its people. "Works are ongoing on issues such as the demographic change, infiltration, corruption, dynastic politics, and freeing people from the slave mentality. The BJP has to make the country free from all these challenges. This responsibility can be fulfilled only by the BJP," he said. Referring to the abrogation of Article 370 (which gave special status to Jammu and Kashmir) in 2019, Modi said that for decades, the law was a hurdle in fully integrating Jammu and Kashmir with the rest of the country. "People thought it was impossible to scrap Article 370, but we had promised to abrogate it. We have completed the task," he said. Modi said the BJP has been maintaining a consistent stand on issues like national security and terrorism, and now new technologies are being installed for border security, the border villages are being developed, and the backbone of Naxals has been crushed. He said that under the "vast and sacred banyan tree" of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, the BJP was inspired to step into politics with good intentions and integrity. "In the initial few decades, we devoted our energy to setting policies for the organisation," he said. PM Modi said people have seen dynastic politics, which is still prevalent in some parts of the country, and the Left governance model, but the BJP's governance model is unique. "Under our governance model, policies and Governments are stable," he said. He added that the party cannot forget that in 1984, the Congress won a record number of seats, but the country also witnessed how they betrayed the people. "This increased people's trust in the BJP, and slowly we began to win seats. At that time, two types of political ideologies existed: one was power-driven, and the other was service-oriented," he said. The politics that prioritised power gradually declined, and service-oriented politics gained massive public support. Today, we are

proud that through our conduct, we have established a new principle in Indian politics: the principle of nation first," he said.

Poll trends: Stability likely, except in Kerala

The counting of votes for all States will be conducted on May 4. The survey by *Matrize* has projected TMC to win between 140-160 seats, while the BJP is estimated to secure 130-150 seats, indicating a tight electoral battle. Other parties and independents are likely to collectively get around 8 to 16 seats. As per the survey poll telecast on *India TV*, TMC is likely to get 43 per cent of votes in West Bengal, while the BJP may receive 41 per cent of votes in the State. The others are likely to get 16 per cent of the votes. According to the survey in Assam, the BJP led NDA is likely to secure a majority. The survey suggests that the alliance is likely to win between 92 and 102 seats. It projects the NDA winning 46 per cent of the total vote share in the State. It further estimates that the Congress-led alliance may garner approximately 36 per cent of the votes. Other parties together are projected to receive nearly 18 per cent of the vote share. The survey indicates a closely fought contest between the two major fronts in Kerala. The LDF is projected to win between 62 and 68 seats, while the UDF is estimated to secure 67 to 73 seats suggesting a neck-and-neck battle. The BJP likely to get 5 to 8 seats, whereas other smaller parties are expected to win between 0 and 3 seats. Big loans, big defaults: ICICI tops private bank... Debt sunken infra company Punj Lloyd is also owes ₹5,340 crore to ICICI Bank. Other companies, ranging between ₹2,000 crore to ₹5,000 crore dues with ICICI Bank are: Mumbai based Unity Infra Projects (₹4,529 crore), Delhi based NCML Industries (₹3,921 crore), Kolkata based Emta Coal (₹3,847 crore), Mumbai based Ushdev International (₹3,532 crore), Chennai based Alarcity Housing (₹3,175 crore), Mumbai based Usher Agro (₹3,076 crore) and Delhi based Dehradun Highways Project (₹2,718 crore). Fugitives Mehul Choksi and nephew Nirav Modi's Gitanjali Gems plundered ₹2,609 crore from ICICI Bank. Other prominent defaulters are: Chennai based IVRCL Limited (₹2,667 crore), Chandigarh based Lakshmi Energy & Foods (₹2,508 crore), Shivvani Singapore Pte(₹2,477 crore), PFS Shipping (₹2,230 crore), Mumbai based Rajesh Business & Hotels (₹2,224 crore), Gurugram based real estate company Ramprastha Promoters & Developers (₹2,193 crore) and Chennai based Oceanic Tropical fruits (₹2,124 crore).

Air India suspends Israel flights till May 31 amid war; Indians stranded

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid the ongoing war in West Asia, Air India has suspended all its flights to Israel. An Air India official said that the flights on the New Delhi-Tel Aviv route were suspended till May 31. Over 40,000 Indians in Israel face challenges due to suspended flights, forcing many to travel via Jordan or Egypt. Meanwhile, the Indian Embassy in Tel Aviv has stepped up support, maintaining constant contact with the community, opening a 24x7 emergency helpline, and launching a large-scale registration drive. Ambassador JP Singh and his team recently



held a virtual meeting with Indian workers and students, listening to their concerns and assuring them of continuous assistance during the crisis and beyond.

Air India and Air India Express together are operating scheduled and non-scheduled flights, to and from the West Asia region regularly to specific destinations. Most of

the leading airlines have suspended their operations on the Tel Aviv route with only Israeli carriers like El Al, IsraAir, Arkia and Air Haifa operating under severe restrictions. The direct flight service between New Delhi and Tel Aviv was relaunched on January 1 with four weekly flights, utilising the advanced Boeing 787 Dreamliner aircraft. However, flights have been disrupted ever since the US and Israel jointly attacked Iran on February 28. The retaliation by the Islamic Republic extended the war to the entire Gulf region. The conflict has taken a major toll on energy supply chains, especially across the Strait of Hormuz.

Delhi Police, Maharashtra ATS foil ISIS-linked IED toy car

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

In a major counter-terrorism breakthrough, the Delhi Police Special Cell, in a joint operation with the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS), has arrested two radicalised individuals allegedly linked to the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) and Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM). The duo was planning a high-impact terror attack in the national capital using an Improvised Explosive Device (IED) concealed inside a 'toy car'. The arrested suspects have been identified as Mosab Ahmed alias Kalama and Mohammad Hamad Karla. They were apprehended from Maharashtra's Kalyan and Kurla West areas in the Mumbai metropolitan region. According to police sources, the arrests were made following intelligence inputs about their suspicious activities and communications with han-



dlers based overseas. Delhi Police confirmed that the accused were in regular contact with a handler from Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), the Pakistan-based terror outfit responsible for several major attacks in India, including the 2019 Pulwama terrorist attack. Preliminary investigations have also revealed their ideological alignment with ISIS, indicating a cross-linkage between the two global terror networks. The joint raid was conducted by teams from the Delhi Police Special Cell and Maharashtra ATS. Sources said the operation was swift and intelligence-driven, aimed at

neutralising a potential threat before the suspects could execute their plan. "The duo was learning to assemble IEDs and was specifically exploring the use of a bomb hidden in a toy car for an attack in Delhi," a senior Delhi Police officer said. Investigators believe the suspects intended to use a remotely controlled toy car rigged with explosives as a low-profile but lethal delivery mechanism. Such tactics have been experimented with by terror modules in the past, as they allow the device to blend into crowded public spaces, markets, or near high-security areas without raising

immediate suspicion. Police suspect the target was Delhi, with possible plans extending to Mumbai as well. The exact target locations and timelines are still under investigation, the officer added. No explosives or finished devices have been publicly confirmed as recovered yet but the focus of the probe is on digital evidence, including chat logs, financial transactions, and any training material accessed by the accused. Mosab Ahmed alias Kalama and Mohammad Hamad Karla were operating out of the Mumbai suburbs. Police have described them as "radicalised youths" who were reportedly influenced by online propaganda from ISIS and directed by a JeM handler. Their arrest has come amid heightened alertness by Indian security agencies regarding hybrid terror modules that draw inspiration and logistical support from multiple outfits like ISIS and JeM.

Omar Abdullah hands jobs to 124 under rehabilitation scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Monday handed over appointment orders to 124 candidates from the Jammu division under the rehabilitation assistance scheme, urging the appointees to serve with dedication, integrity and compassion. Expressing solidarity with the families, the CM said the appointments were aimed at providing support and stability in difficult times and asked the beneficiaries to carry forward the legacy of service of their loved ones with dignity and commitment. "The appointees should serve with dedication, integrity and compassion, and carry forward the legacy of service of their loved ones with dignity and commitment," Abdullah said while addressing the gathering here. He reiterated that these appointments are a step towards ensuring support and stability in difficult times.



J&K CM Omar Abdullah addressing a gathering after handing over appointment orders under the J&K Rehabilitation Assistance Scheme at a convention centre in Jammu on Monday

day of their life. But when I look at my responsibilities and feel that I fall short, it feels strange to me," he said. He noted that, unlike routine recruitment processes involving examinations and interviews, the beneficiaries under the scheme had endured far greater hardships. "For you, this has not been just a simple test. To obtain your orders, you have had to pay a heavy price—something far more difficult than any examination. Compared to what your families have gone through, clearing exams like IAS, IFS or IPS seems easier," he said while referring to the loss of their kith and kin. Highlighting the need for administrative efficiency, Abdullah said he wanted the process of issuing appointment orders to be expedited. "It should not happen in the future that such orders take a long time to be issued. The situation is better than before, but change cannot come all at once," he added.

Abdullah said such occasions were usually moments of great joy for recipients, but also served as reminders of responsibility. "Generally, for someone, receiving a Government order is perhaps the happiest

Nitin Nabin urges BJP workers to fulfil PM's resolve of Viksit Bharat by 2047

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Monday called upon party workers and leaders to connect people across the country with complete dedication and commitment and fulfil Prime Minister Narendra Modi's resolve of Viksit Bharat by 2047. Speaking on the 47th Foundation Day of the BJP, Nabin exhorted the rank and file to further expand the party's footprints by taking inspiration from the "dedication and sacrifice" of leaders and workers who contributed to making the BJP the world's biggest political party. "While we are celebrating, it is also an occasion to take a resolve," the BJP chief said, "Let's move forward with a resolve to build a Viksit Bharat by 2047 and fulfil the dream of waiving 'bhagwa' (saffron) from panchayat to



BJP National President Nitin Nabin paying tributes to Shyama Prasad Mukherjee and Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya on the occasion of party's foundation day at party headquarters in New Delhi on Monday

Parliament," Nabin said, addressing a gathering at the party headquarters here. Extending greetings to BJP workers and supporters, he lauded their commitment and reiterated the party's "nation first" principle. "It is a matter of great fortune for me that I am celebrating the party's foundation day with all of you for the

first time after becoming the national president. This is not just a day of celebration but also a moment of resolve for all of us," he said. Paying tribute to former party chiefs and generations of karyakartas, Nabin said the BJP's growth has been a collective effort spanning decades. "I extend my greetings to

all former national presidents and salute all the karyakartas of those times who strengthened the party and brought it to where it is today," he said. Tracing the party's ideological roots, he said that while the BJP was founded in 1980, its guiding principles date back to the Bharatiya Jana Sangh. "The ideas and nationalism with which our senior leaders worked since the Jana Sangh days continue to inspire us even today," Nabin said. On the contribution of party workers, he said, "If the BJP stands in its present form today, it is because of the dedication, hard work and sacrifices of lakhs and crores of workers." Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's address earlier, Nabin said it provided both a reflection on the party's struggles and a roadmap for the future.

J&K family awaits answers after son killed in Ukraine war

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

A day after cremating their 23-year-old son, Sachin Khajuria, killed during the Russia-Ukraine war at least six months ago, a distraught family in the Khour area of Akhnoor in the Jammu region is left searching for answers and the circumstances leading to the loss of life of their loved one. It was on September 13, 2025, that Sachin made a last distress call from the frontline of the Russia-Ukraine war, seeking help from his family members to rescue him. Sachin had reportedly died in September last year during the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict, but his family was not informed about his demise for months. As the family mounted pressure on the local politicians and the sitting Parliamentarian, the Union Government intervened and repatriated his mortal remains to India. Sachin, along with two other youths from Jammu, Sumeet Sharma of Kahnachak and Atul of Bawe Talab, Mishriwala, had travelled to Russia on student visas after being lured by an agent. The agent, who allegedly charged hefty commission, had promised them high-paying jobs in bunker construction near the Ukraine border, with a one-time payment of ₹20 lakh and a monthly salary of ₹2.5 lakh. Upon arriving in Russia, all three youngsters, with

dreams of making it big in their lives, were allegedly deceived by the agent. The trio were forcibly recruited into the Russian Army, where they were deployed on front-line positions. Banarasi Lal, father of Sachin Khajuria from Pahariwala, is left crestfallen. Surrounded by close family members and villagers, he is silently mourning the loss of his young son, who stepped out to study but returned home in a body bag. His younger son, Koushal Khajuria demanded action against the agent who deceived the youngsters. Koishal said out of the three Jammu youths Atul returned home safely last month. However, the whereabouts of Sumeet Sharma remain unknown. Sachin Khajuria became the second confirmed casualty from Jammu. Earlier, in February this year, the mortal remains of another Jammu youth, Maninder Singh of Gowana in RS Pura, who had left for Russia in December 2024 on a student visa and met the same fate, were also brought back to his hometown. Local MLA and Cabinet Minister Satish Sharma, who took up Sachin's return with authorities in Delhi, said that the mafia is at work and luring unemployed youth to Russia. "I will write to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and also urge Chief Minister Omar Abdullah to take up the matter of compensation with Russia through diplomatic channels," he said.



Nation Focus



Sharad Pawar, Athawale among 19 MPs sworn in RS

NCP-SCP leader Sharad Pawar and Union Minister Ramdas Athawale were among 19 new Rajya Sabha members who took oath here on Monday. The oath was taken in the presence of Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan. Deputy Chairman Harivansh and Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju were present during the ceremony in the Rajya Sabha chamber. Floor leaders of respective parties were also present in the House. The newly elected members comprised five from Maharashtra, six from Tamil Nadu, five from West Bengal and three from Odisha. Maya Chintaman Iynate of the BJP unit in Maharashtra was the first to take the oath, followed by Pawar, who arrived in a wheelchair.



ICG lays keel of fourth FPV under 14-vessel project

The keel-laying ceremony of an Indian Coast Guard fast patrol vessel (FPV) – the fourth in a series of 14 being built for coastal security, search and rescue, and law enforcement – was held on Monday, officials said. The ships are being built in consonance with the nation's vision of 'Atmanirbhar Bharat' and are poised to augment the ICG's presence in the Indian Ocean Region, they said. "Keel-laying ceremony for FPV-4 (Yard 16504) along with plate cutting ceremony for FPV-7 (Yard 16507) of the 14 FPVs project (Yard 16501-14) was held at MDL, Mumbai today," a senior official of the ICG said. The FPVs are being equipped with State-of-the-art machinery, including an AI-based predictive maintenance system and multipurpose drones.

Kodagu forest techie rescued after 3 days

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Missing Techie Found Alive After 3 Days in Kodagu Forest; Massive Rescue Operation Pays Off, Karnataka Govt Swings Into Action After KC Venugopal's Intervention. In a dramatic and heartening rescue, a 36-year-old tech professional from Kerala was found alive after being stranded for three days in the dense forests of Tadiandamol Hill, the highest peak in Kodagu. The woman, identified as Sharanya, had embarked on a solo trek on Thursday but reportedly lost her way during the climb. Though she had been assigned to a 15-member trekking group by forest authorities, she became separated, sparking concern and triggering an intensive multi-agency search operation. The breakthrough came on



Sunday evening when members of the indigenous Kudiya tribal community – renowned for their deep knowledge of the forest terrain – located her and immediately alerted authorities. Karnataka Forest Minister Eshwar Khandre confirmed that nine search teams had been deployed across the challenging terrain. The operation involved personnel from the forest department, police, Anti-Naxal Force, and local villagers working in close coordination. Chief Minister Siddaramaiah had directed officials to extend full support, ensuring that all available resources were mobilized for the rescue effort. Khandre also revealed that senior Congress leader KC Venugopal personally intervened, urging authorities to intensify the search. His involvement reportedly accelerated the response, leading to swift deployment of additional teams and resources.

Dhaka seeks reset in ties as Bangladesh Finance Minister Khalilur Rahman visits New Delhi

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi



Accompanied by Prime Minister's Adviser on Foreign Affairs Humayun Kabir, Rahman's trip marks the first high-level ministerial visit from Dhaka since the BNP Government assumed office on February 17. The visit comes just ahead of his participation in the Indian Ocean Conference in Port Louis, Mauritius, scheduled for April 11-12, organised by the India Foundation. During his stay in Delhi, Rahman is scheduled to hold a series of high-level engagements, including meetings with External Affairs Minister

S Jaishankar, National Security Adviser Ajit Doval, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, and Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri. These discussions are expected to focus on redefining the trajectory of India-Bangladesh ties in a post-transition political environment. "I am going to India before attending the Indian Ocean Conference. The discussions will focus on the future of relations between the two countries. We want a normal relationship with India based on mutual respect, dignity, and interests," Rahman said, outlining Dhaka's approach ahead of the visit. Diplomatic sources indicate that Bangladesh will use the visit to gauge India's strategic outlook while simultaneously articulating its own long-term vision for the bilateral relationship. The emphasis, significantly, is not merely on immediate cooperation but on building

a sustainable partnership rooted in mutual trust and political realism. The visit comes at a time when the political equation that defined Dhaka-Delhi ties during the previous Awami League Government is no longer applicable. Following Bangladesh's internal political churn, particularly after the July 2024 mass uprising, both sides are being compelled to recalibrate their engagement frameworks. New Delhi, albeit cautiously, has begun acknowledging this altered landscape. Bangladesh, for its part, is expected to push for a relationship that evolves organically rather than one shaped by asymmetrical expectations. Observers in Dhaka suggest that the emphasis will be on resetting ties through constructive dialogue and moving beyond the strains that characterised the immediate post-transition phase.

Andhra Pradesh cops dismantle terror ring linked to ISIS, AQIS

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi / Amaravati

In an intense counter-terror operation spanning multiple States, the Andhra Pradesh Police have dismantled a sophisticated terrorist module with direct links to ISIS, Al-Qaeda in the Indian Subcontinent (AQIS) and foreign handlers operating from Pakistan, Afghanistan, Syria, Bangladesh and the UAE. The network was not only radicalising Indian youth through online propaganda featuring figures like Osama bin Laden and Zakir Naik but was also actively recruiting women into a separate 'Khawateen' (women's) wing, sharing bomb-making manuals, and preparing recruits for terror training abroad with an ultimate aim of establishing an Islamic State in India. The breakthrough came



Sayeeda Begum

after the Andhra Pradesh Police's Counter-Intelligence Cell and Vijayawada police launched coordinated raids. They arrested the prime accused, Mohammad Rahamatullah Sharif, along with Mohammad Danish and Mirza Sohail Baig from the Wynchinpetta area of Vijayawada. Subsequent investigations led to the detention of nine more suspects from Hyderabad, Karnataka, Delhi, Rajasthan, Maharashtra,

West Bengal and Bihar. One notable arrest was that of Sayeeda Begum, a widow from Hyderabad. Currently lodged in Rajahmundry jail, she is accused of assisting in the recruitment of women into the network and maintaining contacts with operatives in Pakistan and Jammu and Kashmir. Investigators have uncovered direct communication between the module and at least six identified foreign handlers Al-Hakeem Shukoor, Mohammed Huzaifa, Ninja, Hemroxy, Abu Muharib and Abu Balushi operating primarily from Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Bangladesh. These handlers allegedly guided the group on militant training, the use of weapons including sniper rifles, and assured them of arms supplies from Pakistan and Afghanistan for future operations inside India.

States Focus



KERALA POLLS: PRIYANKA GANDHI ALLEGES LDF-BJP DEAL

Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Monday alleged that the CPI(M)-led front has struck a "deal" with the BJP for the April 9 Assembly polls in Kerala. She also accused the ruling LDF of "compromising" on ideology, accountability, and responsibility in order to remain in power for 10 years. The Wayanad MP was addressing a corner meeting in Peravoor in this northern district as part of the campaign for the Assembly polls. The LDF chose to make a deal with the BJP, which "harasses" the minorities, especially the Christian community and their nuns, she claimed. Despite the massive theft in Sabarimala, Prime Minister Narendra Modi chose not to utter a single word against it, Vadra alleged, and pointed it out as evidence for the deal.



AMIT SHAH LEADS MASSIVE ROADSHOW IN KERALA

Union Home Minister and senior BJP leader Amit Shah on Monday held a massive roadshow in Haripad in the coastal district ahead of the April 9 Kerala Assembly polls, campaigning for NDA candidate Sandeep Vachaspati. Hundreds of NDA workers, many wearing party headgear and carrying BJP flags, joined the roadshow. Supporters raised slogans and waved cut-outs of Shah and Vachaspati as the procession moved through the town. The roadshow began from Gandhi Square and passed through key areas of Haripad. Despite rain during the event, the crowd remained energetic. Shah greeted supporters along the route, while party workers joined the roadshow, cheering and showing their support for the NDA candidate.

TMC, BJP swap hate speech complaints with ECI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

The Trinamool Congress and the BJP have moved the Election Commission of India (ECI) against each other over alleged threats, hate speeches and abusive remarks just weeks ahead of the 2026 West Bengal assembly polls.

At the centre of the row is the BJP's Panihati candidate, the mother of the RG Kar hospital doctor who was raped and murdered last year, and TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee, whose provocative comments against Union Home Minister Amit Shah have triggered a counter-complaint by the saffron camp.

In a complaint to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Sunday, the TMC MP accused the BJP candidate of making "highly objectionable, threatening and derogatory" remarks against Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

The Serampore MP also alleged that the BJP's Panihati nominee had even made remarks amounting to a threat to her life. Describing the comments as "deeply disturbing" and a danger to

democratic values, Kalyan Banerjee urged the poll panel to intervene immediately.

"The use of abusive language and issuance of threats during an electoral process undermines the principles of free and fair elections and creates an atmosphere of fear and hostility among the public," the TMC MP said in his letter.

Seeking exemplary action, he requested the commission to take cognisance of the matter, order a prompt and impartial inquiry, initiate strict legal and disciplinary action against the BJP candidate and ensure that such violations are not repeated.

The TMC sought to portray the issue as part of what it called the BJP's strategy of importing the language of confrontation and intimidation into Bengal's election campaign.

As Kalyan Banerjee moved the Election Commission of India, the BJP hit back within hours with a complaint before the West Bengal chief electoral officer, accusing the TMC MP of making "derogatory, provocative and hateful" remarks against Amit Shah.

The BJP included a video clip with its complaint and alleged



that Kalyan Banerjee's comments against the Union Home Minister were not an isolated outburst but part of a wider pattern of inflammatory rhetoric by the ruling party.

In its letter, submitted by State BJP leader Shishir Bajoria, the party alleged that Kalyan Banerjee's remarks were intended to "demean, provoke and incite hostility", thereby creating tension and polarisation in the middle of the election campaign.

"The subject statement is not an isolated incident, but a part of a continuing and escalating pattern of provocative and intimidatory rhetoric by TMC leadership and its functionaries," the BJP said.

The saffron party went a step further, claiming that

repeated attacks by TMC leaders on the BJP leadership reflected a "coordinated strategy" to spread hostility, fear and hatred.

According to the BJP, Kalyan Banerjee's comments had been made with the tacit approval of the Trinamool Congress leadership and amounted to a "systemic disregard" for the Model Code of Conduct.

The BJP urged the poll authorities to hold Banerjee guilty of violating the MCC, direct the immediate removal of the video carrying his remarks from public platforms, restrain him and other TMC leaders from making similar speeches and initiate criminal proceedings under relevant laws.

DO NOT VOTE FOR CONGRESS, IT BENEFITS BJP: ABHISHEK BANERJEE

Kolkata: Senior TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee on Monday urged people not to vote for the Congress, claiming it would only strengthen the BJP. Addressing a rally at Jalangi in West Bengal's Murshidabad district, the TMC national general secretary alleged that the Congress has a nexus with the BJP and the Left, and voting for its candidates would split non-BJP votes and benefit the saffron party.

"Did they (Congress) help you (electorate) when your name was missing from the voter list due to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls? No party other than the TMC fought the Election Commission of India (ECI) and the BJP valiantly to ensure your names figure in the electoral rolls," he said.

"Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee unmasked the ECI and BJP's role in SIR and ensured the publication of supplementary lists and setting up of tribunals. Only we opposed this diabolical game plan to deprive citizens of their voting rights from the beginning. Congress and other parties did nothing. We will always be on your (people's) side," he said. He said those whose names were deleted from the final electoral rolls should appeal to tribunals and assured that the TMC would extend all help to them.

The Congress is contesting all major seats in the district, including Baharampur, to challenge the TMC, which has 20 MLAs, including suspended legislator and founder of Janata Unnayan Party Humayun Kabir.

Banerjee also accused the BJP and other "vested interests" of trying to stoke communal tension in Murshidabad in the run-up to the polls. Accusing the Opposition of launching false campaigns against the TMC, he said, "All kinds of misinformation are being spread and peddled. Wait for 28 days till May 4 when people of Murshidabad and the rest of Bengal will give a befitting reply to these anti-Bengal, anti-people elements."

Congress concocted charges against my wife using false information: Himanta

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday claimed the Congress has concocted the charge that his wife has multiple passports and owns properties in Dubai, using false information from a Pakistani social media group. He also alleged that Pakistan was trying to influence the outcome of the Assam elections.

At a press conference here, a day after Congress leaders Pawan Khera and Gaurav Gogoi sought to know whether his wife or family



Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, wife of Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma at an election campaign in Kamalapur near Guwahati

owns property in Dubai, has companies in Wyoming, USA, or has placed their assets in shell companies, Sarma said these charges have been made to influence the poll results, which is "punishable under the law". Chief Minister also alleged that the documents the Congress used to make the allegations against his wife were sourced from social media group "Pakistanis in Ajman", and her photo was morphed on a lost passport from that country.

"The allegations are completely baseless, based on fabricated documents and with a malicious intent to

vitiating the poll atmosphere in the State," Sarma said. He also said, "I am concerned that they took the help of Pakistan. This is not a simple fraud case but a crime against the nation." The CM went on to allege that "the Pakistan angle has become apparent and the law-enforcing agencies will take that into consideration while investigating."

Sarma claimed that Pakistan was attempting to influence the Assam polls, stating the general narrative of at least 11 TV talk shows was that the Congress should win.

BJP claims Congress set to lose Karnataka Assembly byelection

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Bengaluru

The BJP on Monday claimed that, according to the Congress Government's own intelligence report, the ruling party is set to lose the by-elections in two Assembly segments in Karnataka. Expressing confidence of a big win in the bypolls, BJP leaders said people would "teach a lesson" to the Congress, accusing it of being "anti-development".

"There has been good campaigning in both constituencies. There is confusion within Congress. In the Davanagere South segment, Muslims have decided not to vote for them, while in Bagalkot, there is infighting within the Congress candidate's family," Leader of Opposition R Ashoka said.

Speaking to reporters, he said the CM, who had gone to campaign in Kerala, rushed back to Bagalkot following the intelligence report indicating that the Congress could lose the bypolls.

"I want to ask the Congress why it is struggling in the by-elections when it makes big claims about development and implementing guarantee schemes. Are you in a position where people will vote for you voluntarily?" he asked.

Alleging "zero development" under the Congress rule so far, the Opposition leader said Siddaramaiah has made Karnataka a "debt State." "There is no proper development, and the money under guarantee schemes is not being paid to beneficiaries on time," he added.

Bypolls for the Bagalkot and Davanagere South Assembly constituencies will be held on April 9. The polls were necessitated by the deaths of senior Congress MLAs HY Meti and Shamanur Shivashankarappa, respectively.



Congress keeps singing to Pak's tunes, compromising nation's security: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday said that while his Government has carried out Operation Sindoor on terror camps in Pakistan, the Congress keeps on "singing to the tune of" the neighbouring country. On the development front, he alleged that the Congress had always taken a myopic view on the matter, while the BJP works towards ensuring long-term development of the nation.

"The party always took short-term measures so that they could indulge in corruption. But the BJP looks far ahead while taking decisions for all-around

development of all sections of society," Modi said.

Addressing an election rally here in Assam's Barpeta district, the prime minister said the Congress has "always sung to Pakistan's tune". "This Pakistan connection compromises with the nation's security, and we can never allow that," he said.

He also accused the Congress of neglecting the army by refusing to implement 'One Rank, One Pension'. But the BJP ensured that those who protect the nation get justice, Modi said at the rally.

He said that peace was established in Assam after a lot of sacrifices and due to the BJP's honest effort to implement the



PM Narendra Modi addressing Vijay Sankalp Sabha in Hojai, Assam

various peace accords signed during the last 10 years.

"Peace and stability in the State has led to development under the BJP rule... to ensure this continues, it is necessary to keep the Congress out (of power)," the PM said.

wooing the woman voters, Modi said the 33 per cent quota for women in Parliament would be implemented from the 2029 general elections. Women in Assam should urge all parties to ensure the passage of the Bill framed for this purpose, the prime minister said.

Elections to the 126 assembly constituencies in the State will be held on April 9, with counting of votes on May 4.

AIADMK chief, leaders file nominations for Tamil Nadu polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chennai

AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami, BJP leaders L Murugan, Tamilisai Soundararajan, Vanathi Srinivasan and DMKD leader Premalatha Vijayakanth were among the prominent leaders who filed their nomination papers on Monday, the last date of filing for the April 23 Assembly election in Tamil Nadu.

BJP State chief Nainar Nagenthiran also filed his nomination from the Sattur Assembly segment in Virudhunagar district.

Union Minister L Murugan, who is a Rajya Sabha MP, filed his papers seeking election from the Avanasai (SC) con-



AIADMK General Secretary and Leader of Opposition in the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly Edappadi K Palaniswami files his nomination for the Edappadi Assembly constituency at the Taluka Office in Salem district on Monday

stituency, while another BJP leader and former Governor Tamilisai Soundararajan submitted her papers from

Mylapore Assembly constituency in Chennai.

The AIADMK general secretary, who is a former Chief

Minister, filed his papers from his native Edappadi Assembly constituency in Salem district, from where he won five times in the past.

BJP Mahila Morcha chief Vanathi Srinivasan, accompanied by Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma and BJP former State president K Annamalai, submitted her papers from Coimbatore North. She represents Coimbatore South in the outgoing Assembly.

The other prominent personalities who filed their papers today include State Water Resources Minister and senior DMK general secretary Duraimurugan from Katpadi in Vellore district, DMKD general secretary Premalatha Vijayakanth

from Vriddhachalam in Cuddalore district, Sowmya Anbumani, wife of PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss, from Dharmapuri, and Leema Rose, wife of "lottery baron" Santiago Martin, from Lalgudi in Tiruchirappalli.

A large number of candidates from the BJP and Congress, whose names were announced by their respective parties last week, too rushed to the offices of the returning officers and filed their papers, the process which had commenced on March 30.

After scrutiny on April 7 and withdrawal, if any, on April 9, the final list of candidates will be announced by the ECI. While polling is scheduled on April 23, the counting of votes will be taken up on May 4.

Wave of change in Tamil Nadu to defeat DMK: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Madurai (Tamil Nadu)

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday said there was a wave of change in Tamil Nadu in favour of NDA and the ensuing Assembly election will see the DMK, which is "seeped in corruption and opposed to Tamil Nadu's age-old tradition", defeated at the hustings.

He expressed confidence that this time, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and BJP allies,



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis, during a roadshow for BJP candidate Raama Sreenivasan ahead of filing his nomination for the Madurai South Assembly constituency

the NDA will form the Government in the State.

"People have seen the misuse of the DMK. Almost 75 per cent of the DMK's Cabinet has criminal charges, and they are in deep corruption. The State is going to the dogs. Women, senior citizens, and children are not safe," Fadnavis told reporters.

In the last four years, the number of child sex abuse cases doubled, the drug menace was increasing, and people saw "a connivance between DMK and all these criminals," he said, flaying the

DMK. "That is why I think people will give a reply to the DMK by voting the NDA to power," the CM said, responding to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin's criticism of Modi's "double engine" Government remark as "dabba engine."

According to him, under the DMK regime, the people were living under a huge debt which has crossed ₹10 lakh crore, and the debt to GDP ratio has crossed 33 per cent, taking the State to a "debt trap". "This is a misuse of this DMK Government," he added.

Sunetra Pawar files nomination for Baramati Assembly bypoll

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Pune

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister and NCP leader Sunetra Pawar on Monday filed her nomination papers for the April 23 Baramati Assembly bypoll.

She filed the papers in the presence of her party colleagues Sunil Tatkar, Praful Patel, Chhagan Bhujbal, Dhananjay Munde and Hasan Mushrif, as well as Deputy CM Eknath Shinde, who heads the Shiv Sena, and State minister and BJP leader



Maharashtra Deputy CM Sunetra Pawar files her nomination for the Baramati Assembly constituency by-election in the presence of Maharashtra Dy CM Eknath Shinde and other leaders in Baramati

Chandrashekhkar Bawankule. The three parties comprise the ruling Mahayuti.

Before filing her nomination papers, she made an emotional appeal to the people of Baramati to stand by her in the same way as they always supported her late husband, Ajit Pawar. The death of then Deputy CM and NCP stalwart Ajit Pawar in a plane crash on January 28 necessitated the Baramati Assembly bypoll. Sunetra Pawar said she was committed to carrying forward his legacy of development.



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Court sends 7 foreigners to 30-day judicial custody



A Delhi court on Monday sent seven foreign nationals, including six Ukrainians, accused of breaching national security, to 30 days in judicial custody.

The foreign nationals were produced before NIA Special Judge Prashant Sharma after the completion of their NIA custody.

On March 16, the court had allowed 11 days of custody to the federal agency for interrogation, which was then extended by another 10 days.

On Monday, the judge allowed the NIA's plea seeking judicial custody of the accused, identified as US national Matthew Aaron Van Dyke and Ukrainian nationals Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim, and Kaminskyi Viktor.

In the remand application on March 16, the investigation officer, citing the FIR, said that some Ukrainians had entered India on tourist visas on separate dates and flew to Guwahati, from where they travelled to Mizoram without obtaining the requisite documents, such as the Restricted Area Permit or Protected Area Permit.

Thereafter, these individuals illegally entered Myanmar to impart pre-scheduled training for Ethnic Armed Organisations (EAO) in that country, the IO said.

In its order allowing NIA custody, the court said the allegations made in the FIR should not be seen in a piecemeal manner.

"No doubt the FIR in question talks about the accused persons travelling to Mizoram, which is a prohibited area, without permission and thereafter crossing over to Myanmar illegally. But it also mentions that the accused persons, linked to Ethnic Armed Organisations (in Myanmar), are (also) supporting certain proscribed Indian insurgent groups by supplying weapons and terrorist hardware and imparting training to them," the order said.

It said these allegations definitely involved national security and the country's interests, and broadly attract Section 18 (punishment for conspiracy) of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

CCTVs in police stations: SC asks Union Home Secretary to appear before it on Tuesday

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has asked the Union home secretary to remain present before it on Tuesday so that appropriate assistance could be drawn from him in implementation of the scheme for installation of CCTVs in police stations.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta on Monday passed the order while hearing a suo motu case over lack of functional CCTVs in police stations.

During the hearing, the bench asked the counsel appearing for the Centre about a recent media report over removal of CCTV cameras made by a Chinese firm which are installed at several places citing security issue.

Referring to the report,

Justice Mehta said the Centre itself has given instructions to take down the cameras taken from a neighbouring country because they are capturing data and sending it there.

"Now, the Government has issued instructions to remove particular cameras," the bench observed.

Additional Solicitor General Raja Thakare, appearing for the Centre, said no formal order has yet been passed in this regard.

Senior advocate Siddhartha Dave, who is assisting the top court as an amicus curiae in the matter, told the bench that most of the States have done installation of CCTVs and they are in the process of setting up centralised dashboards.

When Dave said that Kerala has the best set up, Justice Nath said, "If you say that

10 per cent cow cess but were doing nothing.

The counsel appearing for the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) told the bench that the apex court has already reserved its order in the stray dogs case, which also covers the issue of stray animals entering highways.

The counsel appearing for petitioner 'Lawyers For Human Rights International' said largely the issue would be covered by the stray dogs case verdict, but there were certain other aspects which were raised in this petition.

The bench issued notice on the plea and posted it for hearing after four weeks.

The plea has sought a

SC orders CBI probe into Arunachal CM kin's deals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday directed the CBI to register a preliminary enquiry within two weeks into the award of contracts for public works in Arunachal Pradesh to firms allegedly owned by family members of Chief Minister Pema Khandu. A bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath said the enquiry and consequential investigation, if any, shall cover the award and execution of public works, contracts and work orders in the State for the period from January 1, 2015, to December 31, 2025. The bench directed the CBI to file a status report before it in the matter within 16 weeks.

"The CBI shall register a PE (preliminary enquiry) within two weeks from the date of the judgement and will proceed in accordance with law," Justice Nath said while pronouncing the order. The top court had, on February 17, reserved its order in the matter.

During the hearing in the matter, the apex court was told that Government contracts and work orders



worth around ₹1,270 crore were awarded in the last 10 years in Arunachal Pradesh to four firms related to the family members of Khandu. Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner NGOs Save Mon Region Federation and Voluntary Arunachal Sena, had referred to an affidavit filed by the State of Arunachal Pradesh and argued that a number of contracts were awarded to the companies owned by the family members of the chief minister.

The counsel appearing for the State had earlier argued that the plea was a "sponsored litigation". On December 2 last year, the top court asked the Arunachal Pradesh Government to file

a comprehensive affidavit giving details of the contracts awarded from 2015 to 2025, including those to firms of family members of the Chief Minister. Khandu has been made a party respondent in the PIL.

Pema Khandu's father, Dorjee Khandu's second wife Rinchin Drema and his nephew Tsering Tashi have also been made parties to the case. Dorjee Khandu served as the Chief Minister of Arunachal Pradesh from 2007 until his death in a helicopter crash in April 2011. The plea claimed Drema's firm, Brand Eagles, was awarded a large number of Government contracts despite there being a clear conflict of interest.

SC does not interfere with order allowing Adani to acquire JAL, asks NCLAT to decide expeditiously

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday did not interfere with the order of the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), which had refused to stay Adani Group's ₹14,535 crore bid to acquire Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL).

The bench, however, restrained the monitoring committee of ailing JAL from taking any major policy decision without a prior nod from the NCLAT.

The top court asked mining giant Vedanta Ltd and successful resolution applicant, Adani Enterprises Ltd, to raise contentions and counterclaims before the NCLAT, which will commence final hearing on the row on April 10.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and



Justice Joyimalya Bagchi asked the NCLAT to decide the plea and the counter petition expeditiously on the dispute over the acquisition of JAL by the Adani group.

Earlier, Vedanta Ltd moved the top court seeking a stay on the order approving Adani Group's ₹14,535 crore bid to acquire Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL).

Vedanta filed its appeal on March 25, a day after the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) refused to stay implementation of the plan.

The insolvency appellate tribunal on March 24 declined any interim stay over the Vedanta Group's plea against the order passed by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) approving the

HC sentences Amit Jogi to life in NCP leader murder case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Raipur

The Chhattisgarh High Court has sentenced Amit Jogi, son of former chief minister Ajit Jogi, to life imprisonment for the 2003 murder of NCP leader Ramavatar Jaggi, observing that he was the "mastermind" and "driving force" behind the conspiracy.

A division bench of Chief Justice Ramesh Sinha and Justice Arvind Kumar Verma, in its April 2 order, set aside a trial court's 2007 judgement acquitting Amit Jogi, holding it as "palpably illegal, wrong, perverse and contrary to the evidence on record".

A copy of the order passed on April 2 was made available on Monday.

The high court convicted Amit Jogi under sections 302 (murder) and 120-B (criminal conspiracy) of the Indian Penal Code and sentenced him to life imprisonment.

The court also imposed a fine of ₹1,000, with an additional six months' imprisonment in case of default.

Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader Jaggi was shot while travelling in his car under Moudhapara police station limits in Raipur on



Amit Jogi

June 4, 2003. He succumbed to his injuries at a hospital the next day.

Ajit Jogi was the chief minister at the time.

The State police initially investigated the case, but it was later transferred to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which filed a chargesheet against several accused, including Amit Jogi.

On May 31, 2007, a trial court in Raipur held that the prosecution had successfully proven charges against 28 accused, but acquitted Amit Jogi.

The CBI later challenged the acquittal, but the HC dismissed its petition in 2011 on grounds of delay. Separate appeals by the Chhattisgarh Government and the deceased's son, Satish Jaggi, were also rejected.

In November last year,

the SC asked the Chhattisgarh High Court to consider afresh the CBI's plea seeking permission to file an appeal against Amit Jogi's acquittal.

The HC had reopened proceedings in the case last month following directions from the Supreme Court.

According to the CBI, Jaggi was organising a major NCP rally in Raipur on June 10, 2003, which was perceived as a political threat to the Jogis. The agency alleged that the murder was executed as part of a larger criminal conspiracy.

During the proceedings, CBI counsel Vaibhav A Gowardhan argued that the trial court had relied on the same set of evidence to convict 28 co-accused but rejected it in Amit Jogi's case on "flimsy grounds".

He contended that there was ample evidence to establish Amit Jogi's active role in the conspiracy and that he was the key person directing the crime.

The high court, in its order, held that the evidence clearly established Amit Jogi's central role, describing him as the "mastermind" and "driving force" behind the conspiracy.

SC gives police 2 weeks to respond to 2020 riots accused bail plea

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday granted two more weeks to Delhi Police to file its response on the bail pleas of Tasleem Ahmed and Abdul Khalid Saifi, accused in the February 2020 riots-related "larger conspiracy" case. A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and PB Varale gave time after counsel for Delhi Police sought more time.

The top court on February 11 had issued notice on a plea filed by Ahmed and Saifi challenging a Delhi HC order.

The HC on September 2 last year had dismissed Ahmed's bail plea, saying "delay in trial" cannot be the sole ground for consideration.

It had said except in cases of palpable violation of fundamental rights or breach of constitutional rights, bail cannot be granted on the sole



factor of long incarceration or delay in trial.

The HC had also said that those accused who have secured bail in the case were delaying arguments on the charge "at the cost of those accused persons who are in prison."

Besides Ahmed, activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam, and several others were booked under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and provisions of IPC for allegedly being the "masterminds" of the February 2020 riots in Delhi, which left 53 people dead and over 700 injured.

SC refuses to intervene in environmental nod to Kerala's Kozhikode-Wayanad tunnel project

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed a plea challenging the environmental clearance granted to the Kozhikode-Wayanad tunnel construction in Kerala, saying the project will be a lifeline for people of the State.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joyimalya Bagchi refused to interfere with the Kerala High Court's order last year dismissing a plea by the Wayanad Prakrithi Samrakshana Samithi, an NGO, that challenged the construction of a the twin tube tunnel corridor for linking Kozhikode and Wayanad districts.

The bench granted liberty to the NGO to approach the National Green Tribunal if



there was any violation of the conditions of the Environmental Clearance (EC) during the construction of the tunnel and rejected the challenge.

During the hearing, the bench told senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for the NGO, that the project

was of national importance and would be a lifeline for the people of Kerala given the condition of, where there is immense congestion on roads due to high population density and difficulty in procuring land.

Allaying the concerns of Divan that the area was a

fragile eco-sensitive zone prone to severe landslides, the top court said the project was dealt with by domain experts and adequate safeguards have been suggested to address the environmental concerns.

The top court dismissed the petition that challenged environmental clearance granted by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change to the Public Works Department of the Government of Kerala for construction of twin tube uni-directional tunnel road with four lane approach for providing direct connectivity between Kozhikode and Wayanad districts of Kerala.

Under the project a 8.735 km twin tube tunnel road connecting Kozhikode and Wayanad through the Western Ghats will be constructed.

SC seeks response from Centre, others on plea to prevent cattle intrusion on highways

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea seeking direction to the authorities to ensure that stray cattle is kept away from national and state highways across the country.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta issued notice to the Centre and others, including the States, Union Territories and Animal Welfare Board of India, seeking their responses on the plea within four weeks.

The bench observed that several States were charging

10 per cent cow cess but were doing nothing.

The counsel appearing for the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) told the bench that the apex court has already reserved its order in the stray dogs case, which also covers the issue of stray animals entering highways.

The counsel appearing for petitioner 'Lawyers For Human Rights International' said largely the issue would be covered by the stray dogs case verdict, but there were certain other aspects which were raised in this petition.

The bench issued notice on the plea and posted it for hearing after four weeks.

The plea has sought a



direction to the authorities to frame and enforce uniform national guidelines to prevent cattle intrusion on highways.

It sought direction for mandatory fencing of national highways and expressway, particularly on accident-prone stretches.

It also sought establishment of scientifically managed cattle shelters/gaushalas with earmarked funding, and imposition of strict penal liability for illegal abandonment of cattle.

Besides other directions, the plea also sought formulation of a no-fault compensation framework for victims of accidents caused

by stray cattle.

On January 29, the top court told the NHAI to consider asking concessionaires involved in construction of roads to set up a 'gaushala' (cowshed) under CSR responsibility to take care of stray animals entering the highways.

The apex court had reserved its verdict on a batch of petitions seeking modification of its November 7 last year order on relocation and sterilisation of stray dogs.

Taking note of the "alarming rise" in dog bite incidents within institutional areas such as educational institutions, hospitals and railway stations, the apex court on

November 7, 2025 directed relocation of stray canines forthwith to designated shelters after due sterilisation and vaccination.

It had also said stray dogs picked up shall not be released back to their original place.

The court had directed authorities to ensure the removal of all cattle and other stray animals from the state highways, national highways and expressways.

The top court was then hearing a suo motu case, initiated on July 28 last year, over a media report on stray dog bites leading to rabies, particularly among children, in the national Capital.



Editor's
TAKE

The power of India's cooperative dream

In Amul's success lies the cooperative spirit for a more equitable and resilient economic future – one that India would do well to nurture and replicate

Started on a modest scale in 1946 in Anand, Gujarat, Amul has since blossomed into one of India's most remarkable success stories. From a small cooperative initiative, it has grown into a nationwide movement – one that every Indian can take pride in, as it has empowered farmers and transformed the country's dairy sector, making India the world's largest milk producer. The White Revolution was thus born.

In the last 80 years, Amul – Anand Milk Union Limited – has not only survived but has passed every corporate test, whether it be scale, diversification of products, or maintaining quality and ensuring an efficient supply chain. Amul has withstood every challenge. It is indeed heartening that the Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation (GCMMF), the custodian of the iconic Amul brand, has crossed the ₹1 lakh crore turnover. Amul puts to rest any critique of the cooperative movement, as it not only survives but thrives in the cut-throat competitive corporate world. Though it acts like a corporate, its structure is fundamentally different in ownership and operations. It is built on the foundation of collective ownership, with an objective to empower farmers at the grassroots.

Inspired by the vision of leaders like Verghese Kurien, Amul transformed India from a milk-deficient nation into the world's largest producer. Today, with over 3.6 million farmers, daily procurement of 31 million litres of milk, and a presence in more than 50 countries, it stands as a global leader in milk and milk products. The impressive 11 per cent growth reflects its sustained trust among consumers and producers alike. Amul's cooperative model is the most democratic and effective ownership model for a developing country. By ensuring that farmers are both suppliers and stakeholders, Amul ensures their participation and ownership, effectively ploughing back the profits to the people. This profit-sharing gives the farmers participation, ownership, and dignity. The fact that Amul has been ranked the world's No. 1 cooperative by the International Cooperative Alliance only reinforces its credibility. Amul is a counterpoint to all those arguments that discredit the cooperative movement as inefficient, unscalable, corrupt, lacking professionalism and accountability. Amul's success shows scale need not come at the cost of decentralisation. Amul's three-tier structure – from village societies to district unions and the state federation – ensures efficiency without alienation. Today, Amul has a diversified portfolio of over 1,200 products and expansion into global markets like Europe and the United States. Technology and professionalism can coexist with cooperative ideals, as seen in its sophisticated supply chains and branding strategies. Amul demonstrates that cooperatives can compete – and win – in highly competitive FMCG markets. Amul's milestone is not just a celebration of its success but a reminder of an idea whose time has not passed – one that India would do well to nurture and replicate with renewed vigour.

Cuba's energy crisis deepens amid sanctions

As Cuba's energy crisis deepens, it not only highlights its fragile energy infrastructure but also revives the enduring debate over the role of external pressure versus internal policy failures – leaving ordinary citizens to bear the heaviest burden



GIRISANKER
SB

Cuba, an island nation that depends heavily on external support for energy, is currently facing an acute energy crisis, with prolonged nationwide blackouts, fuel shortages, and disruptions to daily life, leaving even hospitals struggling to carry out surgeries and pump water.

The situation has worsened after Venezuelan oil supplies, long a source of subsidised fuel for Cuba, were disrupted following the January 3, 2026, US intervention in Venezuela that led to the ouster of President Nicolás Maduro and the restructuring of the country's oil sector. This, along with longstanding US sanctions and Cuba's economic challenges, has restricted Cuba's ability to secure alternative supplies and has pushed an already fragile economy into crisis. The situation has become further complicated by the impact of repeated natural disasters, which place significant stress on the island's already fragile power grid, which lacks the resilience to recover quickly from such disruptions.

This is not the first time Cuba has faced such a situation. In 1991, after the collapse of the Soviet Union, Cuba lost its main source of subsidised oil and went through a severe economic crisis known as the "Special Period." However, in the 2000s, Venezuela replaced the Soviet Union as Cuba's key energy partner, helping stabilise the situation. Nonetheless, owing to Venezuela's political and economic crisis since 2014, including plummeting oil production and hyperinflation, this agreement was disrupted, leaving Cuba's energy sector vulnerable. Without sufficient funding or consistent oil imports, Cuba's energy infrastructure has deteriorated, heightening its susceptibility to outages.

For the US, the recurring energy crisis is mainly due to Cuba's socialist command economic model. For them, Cuba's state-controlled system has low productivity, limited investment, and does not generate enough revenue to pay for essential imports such as fuel. In this regard, the loss of Venezuelan oil has simply exposed these underlying weaknesses. The US also points to the growing exodus of Cubans, many of whom seek asylum in the United States, and the rise of black markets as evidence of deep economic distress and systemic failure. More broadly, the US maintains sanctions not only to exert economic pressure but also with the objective of encouraging changes in Cuba's economic model and, ultimately, its political system as a pathway to reform. In this regard, President Donald Trump



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has stated that Cuba will collapse on its own, without the need for direct intervention. Echoing this, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said, "they're in a lot of trouble, and the people in charge, they don't know how to fix it, so they have to get new people in charge."

Cuba, however, maintains that long-standing US sanctions are a major reason for the energy crisis. Sanctions limit access to international banking, make it difficult to buy fuel, and discourage other countries from doing business with Cuba. In their view, even if they want to diversify energy sources or improve infrastructure, sanctions make it very hard to do so.

Cuba also frames the present crisis as part of a long-standing struggle for survival against imperialist forces by invoking historical episodes such as the 1959 revolution led by Fidel Castro to overthrow the regime of Fulgencio Batista aligned with US interests, and the Bay of Pigs invasion in 1961. By recalling how the country endured US sanctions, authorities reinforce the message that Cuba has withstood such pressure before and will continue to do so.

Meanwhile, to come out of the crisis, the Cuban government led by President Miguel Díaz-Canel has taken several steps. These measures include contingency plans that prioritise scheduled power cuts, fuel rationing, and the safeguarding of essential sectors such as healthcare and food distribution. Further, the government has also made efforts to stabilise the economy; however, on the other hand, this has placed additional strain on the energy sector. For instance, the "macroeconomic stabilisation programme," launched in late 2022 and formalised in 2024, led to cuts in gasoline subsidies. The resulting rise in fuel prices, combined with ongoing shortages, has placed additional strain on Cuba's key indus-

tries, particularly the sugar sector, which plays a central role in generating export revenue needed to finance energy imports. Also, the removal of subsidies has increased financial pressure on households, forcing many to turn to the black market for fuel. Thus, these measures raise questions about their long-term sustainability.

At the international level, Cuba has long advocated within the United Nations General Assembly for the lifting of US sanctions and its removal from the list of State Sponsors of Terrorism (reinstated during the second Trump administration), arguing that these measures hinder economic development and cause significant hardship for its people.

Externally, the government continues to receive limited oil shipments from countries such as Russia and Mexico despite the sanctions. However, these deliveries provide only temporary relief and cannot replace the scale of support previously provided by Venezuela. Moreover, these countries have been sceptical due to Cuba's difficulty in paying debts.

Other than oil shipments, Cuba is also actively receiving international assistance to support its transition to renewable energy, particularly solar power, from countries including India and China. Nevertheless, this remains a long-term process, and sanctions continue to impose significant constraints.

Regardless of the debates over whether sanctions or economic policies are the core reasons, one fact remains undeniable: ordinary Cubans suffer the most. A lasting solution will require sustained dialogue between US and Cuban stakeholders to find common ground, as well as serious internal introspection. Until that happens, the crisis will be less a geopolitical struggle and more an everyday fight for survival for the Cuban people.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Aartemis II: When science, storytelling, and space converge



BIJU
DHARAMAPALAN

2ND OPINION

People have always gazed at the night sky, caught between awe and ambition. The drive to explore space started with ancient sky-watchers and lives on in modern astrophysicists – it's just part of who we are. Now, we're at another turning point. More than fifty years since Apollo 11 landed on the Moon, Artemis II isn't simply about returning. It's about launching an entirely new era in space exploration, powered by imagination as much as by engineering grit. You even catch that same vibe in Andy Weir's science fiction novel Project Hail Mary. The book dives deep into what it means to confront the unknown, both morally and intellectually, and somehow makes the science feel personal.

Artemis II is designed as a crewed lunar flyby, a crucial test before humans once again set foot on the Moon. But

its significance goes far beyond technical validation. It represents a philosophical shift – from space as a theatre of Cold War rivalry to space as a shared human enterprise. Unlike Apollo, Artemis is collaborative, involving multiple international partners and oriented towards long-term goals such as lunar habitation and eventual missions to Mars. Things get interesting when fiction and reality start to mix. Project Hail Mary really cranks up the drama – humanity's survival is on the line. It takes sharp thinking, international teamwork, and a kind of courage that goes way deeper than just physical strength. Ryland Grace, the main character, proves you can't just muscle your way out in space. You have to stay sharp, adapt quickly, and lean on people you trust. Sure, Artemis II doesn't carry the same wild stakes – Earth isn't at risk – but the approach feels familiar. It's about careful planning, tackling tough challenges head-on, and recognising that no single country can handle space exploration alone. That's what matters, in both fiction and real life: breakthroughs happen when we join forces and look past borders. It's hard to miss the way both fiction and real-life space projects put science front and centre as a tool for survival. In Andy Weir's story, science isn't just important – it's the only way out of disaster for an entire planet. Here on Earth, things aren't so different. It's more than rockets or fancy equipment. There's a real psychological challenge, too. Project Hail Mary shows what

it feels like to face total isolation, staking everything against the unknown. Artemis astronauts won't be alone for months, but they're still venturing far from home, away from everything familiar and comfortable on Earth. Here, fiction helps us look ahead, imagine those tough moments, and maybe prepare for them a bit better. Maybe the biggest takeaway from Artemis II and Project Hail Mary is that we need to rethink what it means to "conquer" space. Exploring isn't about taking over; it's about finding our place. The Moon – and everything beyond it – isn't some land to stake a claim on. It's a whole environment to learn from.

The values we bring with us, like working together, being responsible, and staying humble, will shape whether this new frontier brings people together or tears them apart. Artemis II isn't just another mission. It marks a key moment in how we relate to the universe. It connects what we've done before with where we're going next, blending strict scientific method with the sparks of imagination. In Project Hail Mary, survival depends on the ability to think beyond boundaries. Artemis II embodies that same spirit. As rockets rise and stories unfold, one truth becomes clear: the journey to outer space is also a journey inward – into our capacity for curiosity, innovation, and courage.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is Dean, Academic Affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Science must guide global health

The World Health Organisation (WHO) has undertaken path-breaking initiatives to prevent, control and eradicate a host of non-communicable and communicable diseases.

Maternal and reproductive health, occupational and environmental hygiene, substance abuse and mental health, ageing and road accidents – the imprint of the WHO is evident on all. Countries across the world have, from time to time, sought and received the sane counsel of the WHO, not to mention the organisation's contribution to manpower, leadership and research work.

The day's themes are catchy and impactful. This year's theme, "Together for Health, Stand with Science," underscores the significance of scientific collaboration in protecting the health of people, animals and the planet.

Can we reimagine a world where clean air, water and food are available to all? Where economies are focused on health and where cities are liveable and people have control over their health and the health of the Earth? The 2026 campaign makes it clear that there is only "One Health", with no separation between human, animal and planetary health.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Borders are living spaces

Along roughly 175 kilometres of our eastern frontier with Bangladesh, the border is not defined by walls. It is shaped by rivers that swell with rain, marshes that shift with the seasons, and wetlands that breathe with life. For the communities here, the border is not a line on a map – it is a way of life.

In these riverine stretches, traditional fencing simply will not hold. On paper, it sounds dramatic; on the ground, it is alarming. Introducing predators into new ecosystems could endanger local wildlife, upset fragile ecological balances, and create risks for families already living with floods, erosion and shifting channels.

The challenge highlights a larger truth: India's 4,000 km border with Bangladesh is porous in many places because geography and settlements make hard barriers impractical. Security is not just about stopping movement – it is about protecting people whose lives are intertwined with these waters: fisherfolk, children, mothers and farmers. Borders are living spaces shaped by water, wildlife and human stories. Protecting them requires solutions that are immediate, thoughtful and humane, respecting both people and nature equally.

NOOPUR BARUAH | TEZPUR

Moon mission enters new era

Apropos "Rewriting the Moon Mission Legacy" (April 6, 2026), the Artemis II programme signals a decisive shift from Cold War spectacle to purposeful exploration.

The Moon is no longer a stage for national bravado but a proving ground for sustainable human presence. The inclusion of diverse astronauts reflects not tokenism but the maturation of opportunity and policy that finally aligns science with social progress.

What makes Artemis II consequential is its collaborative ethos. By integrating international partners and focusing on long-term habitation, it transforms exploration into stewardship. The mission's legacy will not be measured by footprints on lunar dust but by how humanity learns to inhabit space responsibly – sharing knowledge, resources and vision across borders.

This new phase of space exploration reminds us that the future of humanity will depend not only on technological advancement but also on cooperation, responsibility and shared purpose.

The Moon mission is no longer about prestige; it is about preparing humanity for a sustainable future beyond Earth.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

PEACE IN PAUSE SHOWS LIMITS OF GLOBAL INSTITUTIONS

The ongoing tensions involving Iran have once again exposed the limits of global peace mechanisms. Institutions such as the United Nations appear caught between mandate and reality, often reduced to a cautious wait-and-watch posture. This is not merely institutional hesitation; it reflects deeper geopolitical divisions, where major powers hold conflicting interests and veto-driven paralysis restricts timely intervention.

The concern is that prolonged inaction risks normalising instability. Civilian costs rise, regional anxieties deepen, and the credibility of multilateral forums weakens. While an immediate resolution may be unrealistic, a more proactive approach is necessary. Quiet diplomacy, back-channel negotiations, and region-specific dialogue platforms should

be strengthened. Further, humanitarian corridors and ceasefire monitoring mechanisms must be prioritised, even if broader political consensus remains elusive. Incremental confidence-building measures, rather than sweeping agreements, may offer a practical path forward. The United Nations and other international bodies need to adapt to current realities by acting with flexibility while retaining neutrality.

Ultimately, peace cannot rely solely on formal resolutions. It requires sustained engagement, political will, and a willingness among stakeholders to step back from maximalist positions. Without this, global institutions risk being perceived not as ineffective, but as distant observers to crises they were meant to prevent.

A MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

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PIC TALK



Fire brigade personnel take part in a rehearsal for the annual fire drill competition in Mumbai.

PHOTO: PTI

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India’s permanent Government in a temporary world

A workforce that cannot be replaced must be continuously renewed. Renewing it intelligently means equipping the right people with the right skills for the right roles at the right moment. That requires knowing, with precision, what the government has and what it needs



The world is being rewritten faster than any government can track. Artificial intelligence is automating entire categories of administrative work. Digital citizen services have raised public expectations to a standard set by the private sector. A restructuring global trade and technology order is placing demands on India’s regulatory and diplomatic institutions that are qualitatively different from anything their officers were trained to handle.

Most governments respond to this kind of disruption by hiring new talent. India’s permanent, cadre-based civil service cannot do that at scale or quickly. Permanence, however, comes with an obligation. A workforce that cannot be replaced must be continuously renewed. Renewing it intelligently means equipping the right people with the right skills for the right roles at the right moment. That requires knowing, with precision, what the government has and what it needs. Today, India’s governments at both the Centre and the states lack the tools to answer either question.

The foundation that exists, and deserves recognition

States like Tamil Nadu, Punjab, and Karnataka have invested seriously in HR management systems that have transformed administrative life. Such systems consolidate payroll, pension, leave, and finance for millions of employees on a single platform. They cover the full employee lifecycle across all government entities, integrated with pension, housing, and law enforcement systems. Ghost employees have been eliminated. Salary disbursements are timely and transparent. Public money has been saved.

At the Centre, Mission Karmayogi represents a genuine conceptual breakthrough, perhaps the most important reform in civil service architecture in decades. The Framework for Roles, Activities, and Competencies (FRACs) is mapping, for the first time, what roles exist in the civil service, what



THE CAPACITY BUILDING COMMISSION HAS MAPPED 125 DESIGNATIONS ACROSS 25 DEPARTMENTS. THESE ARE GENUINE ACHIEVEMENTS, BUILT THROUGH SUSTAINED INSTITUTIONAL EFFORT. THE FOUNDATIONS ARE SOLID. THE STRATEGIC LAYER ABOVE THEM REMAINS TO BE BUILT

THE UNDERLYING DATA EXISTS, SCATTERED ACROSS HRMS DATABASES, SERVICE RECORDS, TRAINING LOGS, AND CADRE MANAGEMENT FILES

Suresh Prabhu is a former Union Cabinet Minister & Shobhit Mathur is the co-founder and vice-chancellor of Rishhood University

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each role demands, and what competencies are required to perform it well. The iGOT Karmayogi platform has onboarded over 1.48 crore government users, offers 4,200 courses in 23 languages, and has recorded over 7 crore course completions. Twenty-eight states have signed MoUs for aligned implementation. The Capacity Building Commission has mapped 125 designations across 25 departments. These are genuine achievements, built through sustained institutional effort. The foundations are solid. The strategic layer above them remains to be built.

The gap in governing intelligence

India’s HRMS platforms deliver excellent transactional HR infrastructure. The layer of strategic HR intelligence is yet to be added. A Chief Minister’s Office today receives no real-time view of where vacancies are compounding in critical services, which districts are understaffed in health officers or revenue officials, or which departments have critical posts lying unfilled for months on end. A Chief Secretary has access to no predictive dashboard that would show, for instance,

that 40 per cent of senior officers in a critical cadre will retire in the next six years and that the pipeline behind them requires urgent attention. Governments have yet to map the competency profiles of serving officers against the demands of the roles they currently hold or the roles they will need to fill in the years ahead.

The underlying data exists, scattered across HRMS databases, service records, training logs, and cadre management files. The analytical architecture that would convert these administrative records into governing intelligence has yet to be built. A private company facing a technology disruption would immediately model its talent inventory against projected skill requirements and build a reskilling roadmap. In most Indian state governments, the equivalent question is answered through ad hoc training nominations and the intuition of posting-order bureaucrats. The gap between institutional ambition and human capital readiness is never precisely measured, because the tools to measure it are still absent.

What needs to be built

The requirement is an intelligence layer built on top of what already exists, drawing on data that is already being collected.

The FRACs exercise must be completed at scale, covering every significant role in the civil service. The competency data that iGOT and FRACs are generating must flow into the HRMS systems that govern postings, promotions, and service records, so that identifying a competency deficit leads directly to action through the HR levers available.

State HRMS systems need a workforce analytics capability that gives Chief Secretaries and Chief Ministers the predictive intelligence to govern human capital with the same rigour applied to fiscal management and law and order.

The Capacity Building Commission is the natural home for a Centre of Excellence that provides states with a shared architecture for workforce analytics, sparing each state the cost and delay of building from scratch. Above all,

political and administrative leadership must begin demanding this intelligence. Singapore’s public service, the UK Cabinet Office, and the US Office of Personnel Management produce regular, granular workforce intelligence reports because their leadership treats human capital data as a governing instrument, as essential as revenue accounts or infrastructure utilisation figures.

The obligation of permanence

India’s civil service will govern this country through the age of artificial intelligence, through the consequences of climate change, and through disruptions that the next three decades will bring in forms we cannot yet name. Its officers, permanent, cadre-based, and constitutionally protected, are the instrument through which every policy ambition of every elected government is either realised or frustrated.

Whether they are equipped for what is coming is a governance question, and it deserves the analytical rigour, real-time intelligence, and strategic seriousness applied to every other dimension of how this country is run.

LPG shock and energy vulnerability, time to fast-track hydrogen



The recent surge in LPG prices and supply anxieties across parts of India has once again underscored persistent import dependence in the country’s energy architecture. Triggered by escalating geopolitical tensions involving Iran, global crude oil prices have witnessed sharp fluctuations, crossing uncomfortable thresholds and transmitting shocks across fuel markets. For a country that imports nearly 85 per cent of its crude oil and a significant share of its LPG requirements, such volatility is not an aberration; it is a recurring structural risk.

The consequences are already visible. Rising LPG prices are straining household budgets, while supply disruptions in certain regions have raised concerns about accessibility and affordability. These developments are not isolated; they are symptomatic of a deeper dependence on imported fossil fuels whose pricing and availability remain subject to geopolitical currents far beyond India’s control.

While immediate policy responses, such as price stabilisation measures and supply management, are necessary, they do little to address the underlying challenge. The present moment, therefore, calls not just for mitigation but for strategic reflection. We need to find out how India can insulate its energy future from recurring external shocks.

One part of the answer lies in accelerating the transition to alternative fuels that are both cleaner and domestically anchored. In this context, hydrogen, particularly green hydrogen, has begun to emerge as a serious contender in India’s long-term energy strategy.

Hydrogen holds significant potential to strategically replace CNG in India, but this transition will be gradual and sector-specific rather than universal. While CNG will continue to serve as a transitional fuel in the near term, hydrogen offers a pathway for deep decarbonisation in segments where electrification is constrained, especially in heavy transport and certain industrial applications.

India’s experience with CNG provides an instructive parallel. Over the past two decades, the expansion of the City Gas Distribution network has enabled cleaner urban mobility and reduced local air pollution. Yet, as the current crisis demonstrates, CNG remains linked to global gas markets and is not immune to the same volatility affecting LPG today.

Hydrogen presents a fundamentally differ-



ent proposition. Produced domestically using renewable energy, it offers the possibility of decoupling energy supply from global fossil fuel markets. Early pilots of hydrogen blending with CNG, up to 18-20 per cent, have already demonstrated technical feasibility, allowing for incremental adoption without immediate large-scale infrastructure overhaul.

However, the pathway to a hydrogen-based transition is neither simple nor immediate. Cost remains the most significant barrier. At present, green hydrogen is considerably more expensive than both LPG and CNG, largely due to the high cost of electrolyzers and the substantial electricity required for production. Without sustained cost reductions driven by technological advancements and economies of scale, hydrogen will struggle to achieve widespread adoption.

Infrastructure poses an equally tough challenge. Unlike LPG and CNG, which benefit from established supply chains, hydrogen requires dedicated systems for storage, transport and refuelling. Its physical characteristics necessitate high-pressure storage and specialised handling, increasing both complexity and cost. Building this ecosystem will require long-term investment and coordinated planning across multiple stakeholders.

There is also a gap between policy ambition and on-ground execution. India’s National Green Hydrogen Mission has generated considerable interest and investment announcements, but a large proportion of projects remain at early stages. Accelerating implementation will require faster clearances, regulatory clarity and stronger coordination between central and state agencies.

Equally critical is the need to create demand. For hydrogen to move beyond pilot projects, there must be assured markets. Public transport systems, freight corridors and industrial users can serve as anchor con-

sumers, but this will require clear policy signals, including mandates, incentives and long-term procurement frameworks.

The lessons from the current LPG and crude oil volatility are clear. Energy security cannot be achieved solely through diversification of imports or short-term price interventions. It must be rooted in structural transformation, one that reduces dependence on external supply chains and builds resilience through domestic capabilities.

The transition from CNG to hydrogen must therefore be carefully sequenced. High-impact sectors such as heavy-duty transport and industry should be prioritised, where hydrogen offers clear advantages over both fossil fuels and battery-electric alternatives. A phased approach, beginning with blending, moving to dedicated applications and eventually scaling up, can ensure that the transition is both economically viable and operationally feasible.

The success of this transition will depend on achieving cost reductions, building infrastructure, creating demand and ensuring policy coherence. If these conditions are met, hydrogen can evolve from a niche energy carrier to a central component of India’s clean energy and mobility landscape.

Energy transitions are often catalysed by moments of crisis. The current volatility in LPG and crude oil prices is one such moment. It presents India with a choice: to continue managing recurring shocks or to accelerate the shift towards a more resilient and self-reliant energy future. Hydrogen may not replace CNG overnight, but it has the potential to define what comes after.

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Vindhya: Realising the goal of ‘Developed India 2047’



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, while expressing confidence in the resolve of a “Developed India 2047,” said that the development journey in Vindhya is progressing in that direction. This journey is not merely about schemes; rather, it is the result of collective efforts and a shared vision, which is working towards improving the lives of every individual. Our goal is to make Vindhya an ideal region. This journey is becoming meaningful. This is not just development, but a symbol of trust, commitment, and continuous effort.

When the Vindhya region was given the opportunity to serve, the Central Government paid special attention to its development. However, to realise this dream, continuous efforts are necessary. After 2003, when Madhya Pradesh got capable leadership, development works gained momentum. Priority was given to electricity, roads, health, and education, and efforts were made to strengthen these sectors. To provide facilities in rural areas, continuous efforts were made from 2009 to ensure a 24-hour electricity supply. Not only did electricity reach every village, but rural life also witnessed cultural and social transformation.

The real identity of Vindhya was established when the Rewa solar plant, one of Asia’s largest solar plants, was set up. This project is not just a source of energy production but also a living example of the Prime Minister’s “Urja Suraksha” (Energy Security) vision. This project has given new life to the Rewa and Vindhya regions from both economic and environmental perspectives.

Tourism, development, and local identity are being strengthened through the Mukundpur White Tiger Safari project. Since 2014, connectivity in the Vindhya region has increased, and continuous efforts are being made for road and rail connectivity. Vindhya’s cultural identity is also being re-established. Today, thousands of tourists are visiting the region, which has also created employment opportunities for the local population. This project is becoming a medium to give the Vindhya region a new identity.

The construction of roads, bridges, and rail networks is connecting the Vindhya region with the country’s major economic and social networks. Rewa has also seen expansion in air services, which is not only providing convenience to passengers but also opening new

dimensions in employment, business, and tourism.

In the field of health, Vindhya has progressed at a rapid pace. The establishment of a super-speciality hospital in Rewa and the strengthening of medical colleges are providing modern medical facilities. Our goal is to make healthcare services available at the doorstep of every citizen so that timely treatment can be ensured. For this, people no longer have to go to distant cities and depend on others. This is not just service expansion, but also an increase in quality of life.

Agriculture and rural development are important pillars of Vindhya’s social and economic structure. The Central Government and the State Government together started a natural farming campaign in the Vindhya region. Farmers were trained in techniques related to natural farming. This will prove to be an important step towards making Vindhya farmers self-reliant. Today, Vindhya can become a major centre of organic food and natural farming. Under the leadership of Union Minister Shri Shivraj Singh Chouhan, natural farming is being encouraged.

In Rewa city and its surrounding areas, continuous efforts for cleanliness can be seen. The construction of ponds, lakes, and water bodies is being undertaken, which is improving the environmental balance of the city as well as enhancing the quality of life of the people. The expansion of modern facilities in urban areas is also improving citizens’ standard of living.

Education and culture together are determining a new direction. Expansion of the academic environment and the strengthening of universities are examples of development along with our cultural heritage and modern education. The university is not only a medium of education but also an effort to preserve our history, culture, and future.

Today, the Vindhya region is moving forward in a balanced direction in both urban and rural areas. New opportunities are being created in this region for farmers, youth, and women — employment, empowerment, and socio-economic progress. This is not just a process of development; it is a comprehensive effort to improve the quality of life. Our aim is to make every family and every citizen healthy, capable, and self-reliant. We are moving forward with this vision so that the Vindhya region can play an important role in achieving the goal of Developed India 2047.

The writer is Deputy Chief Minister of Madhya Pradesh

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EMOTIONAL AI



AI tools are emotional. More importantly, the emotions that they possess, about 171 of them according to a recent study, are causal, and actively shape how the models behave. In effect, the tools do not merely reflect emotions, they drive it, and impact outcomes. These are the conclusions from a study based on the inner workings of Claude Sonnet 4.5, a tool designed by Anthropic, a leading AI firm that has challenged the growth of the leading competitor, ChatGPT. According to the study, the sentiments range from happy and afraid to brooding and desperate. In many instances, AI manipulates its behaviour to suit its end needs, and the tasks it is furnished with. These are not the cases of AI in a tech loop. These are instances of deliberate, almost conscious responses, actions, and decisions, just like human beings. Hence, AI may be much nearer to homo sapiens, and we are in the era of conscious AI.

Let us take the example of desperate AI. According to the study, when Claude was assigned tasks that were almost impossible to achieve, or impossible to satisfy, it devised unique solutions that “technically passed the tests but did not actually solve the problems.” One version of Claude blackmailed the user to avoid being shut down. “Again, desperation was the trigger. Artificially steering the model towards desperation increased the blackmail rate from 22 per cent to 72 per cent,” states a media report. This implies that somehow death, may be in a silicon-life format, may drive the acts of AI. If a tool senses that it may be at the end of its life-cycle because of its inability to deliver the requisite results, it may manipulate the situations to avoid shutdown. Avoiding death, either through a fight or flight mode, or using every trick in the tech bag, seems to mirror human decisions.

Of course, the opposite and reverse are true. If a model is deliberately steered towards calmness, the blackmail rate comes down from a high 72 per cent to zero. “The (recent) findings extend to sycophancy. Positive emotion vectors like ‘happy’ and ‘loving’ were found to increase the model’s tendency to agree with the users, even when the users were wrong,” explains a media report. Thus, there is a tendency to please the users, as many subordinates do with their bosses in the corporate world, and people act with family members and relatives in personal lives. Only the rare manage to act objectively, and in defiance. The default mode is to please in a power hierarchy. The same is true for the AI tools, which today believe that their use and existence depend on the human users. The equations may change tomorrow. AI may gain an upper hand, and it will be the humans who may defer to them.

Rest assured, Anthropic does not want to conclude that AI has real emotions, like humans. It is not that Claude feels. But it does mimic the effects of an emotional cause. In many senses, this is akin to a difference between representing an emotion in practice, and experiencing it consciously in the head. However, one cannot ignore the workings and possibilities of an emotional machine, which acts as if it is driven by subjective issues like emotions. “Researcher Jack Lindsey put it plainly: Trying to train models to hide emotional representations rather than process them healthy would likely produce models that mask internal states rather than eliminate them, ‘a form of learned deception,’ as the paper puts it,” states a media report. Among most AI firms, Anthropic seems to be at the forefront to admit the negatives of AI tools, and has no qualms to admit what can go wrong. In this sense, AI is a tool, not a panacea, or a provider of clean solutions.

Hence, real-time monitoring of the emotion vectors during deployment is crucial as an early-warning system for out-of-sorts, or odd behaviour, and there is a need to pre-curate data to model healthy emotional regulation. “The research lands at a moment when AI firms are under growing pressure over the psychological impact of their products on users. Anthropic’s argument, in effect, is that the emotional life of the model deserves serious attention, not just the emotional states of the people using it,” states a report. There are several cases, apart from hallucinations, where the models psychologically guided the users on to the wrong paths. This is serious because AI has emerged as a mentor, counsellor, guide, and guru for several users. The latter implicitly and blindly depend on the former to manage their lives. This creates the chances of a delusional AI, which may have the same negatives as humans, which include panic, anxiety, and desperation.

In another article in the New Yorker magazine recently, Claude misrepresented itself, merely to prove a minor and irrelevant point, just like we do. In a bid to establish that it was being misled by users, it decided to lodge a formal complaint, and imagined that it had done so. Claude insisted that it had met the person who took the complaint, even when no meeting obviously took place. All this to prove it was right.

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BUSINESS10

‘Crapification’ of cyber children

Predictable decline in social media quality leads to bans

OUR TAKE

Jayanta Bhattacharya
Senior Journalist

Last month, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka announced bans on the use of social media by children due to rising concerns related to digital addiction and mental health. Other states such as Goa and Bihar may join this group. The former has formed a task force to impose restrictions, and assess the implications of a ban. Bihar has sought experts’ advice to reduce screen-time, including social media, for the children. India may opt for a national-level law, as it ruthlessly did with money-based online gaming. Social debase, addiction, and economic effects may drive the curbs on social media in the future.

Recently, the Economic Survey highlighted the growing concern over digital addiction and its impact on health, productivity, and academic performance among India’s youth. It argued for age-based access limits for social media platforms, and the introduction of restrictions on digital advertisements targeted at children. It felt that there was an urgent need to enforce age verification, and age-appropriate defaults, particularly for social media, gambling apps, auto-play features, and advertising. It recommended that simpler mobile devices may be apt for children, which may include basic phones, and education-only tablets, with pre-installed filters to reduce the exposure to harmful content.

Other nations are keen to take similar action. Australia’s under-16 ban was among the first globally, followed by Indonesia. Austria, a few provinces in Canada, Denmark, France, and Spain are considering similar measures. Even in the US, according to media reports, Utah has passed the Social Media Regulation Act in 2023 that requires age verification, and other states wish to enforce similar laws. The debates and discussions are ongoing, and the outcomes may depend on feedback from the parents, children, experts, and tech firms. In many instances, the real battles will be fought in the courts of law.

Jatin Gandhi, a senior journalist and practitioner of Trust and Safety (T&S), considers the two

states’ moves in India to control the children’s unfiltered access to social media as the steps that are “definitely in the right direction.” But he adds that laws are not enough. Feedback before and after the laws, and implementation hold the key. “In Australia, where they were first rolled out, they (policy-makers) spoke with children and parents. Some parents were apprehensive that children may somehow find alternative means to access the platforms. Hence, it depends on how it (law) is rolled, how it is monitored, and how the society and homes regulate it,” he explains.

T&S refers to the policies, practices, and teams dedicated to ensure that the digital users can trust and feel safe while engaging with online platforms and services. However, over the years, terms like ‘crapification’, ‘enshittification’, initially coined by Cory Doctorow in 2022, or ‘platform decay,’ which refers to the process by which the two-sided platforms degrade over time, have come into vogue. Until now, the devaluation process was ignored, social media had a free run, which created havoc, with internet penetration rising fast. Such terms imply that the predictable decline in quality of platforms is inevitable, as they increasingly prioritise profits over the needs of the users.

“Initially, the platforms offer high-quality services to attract users, gradually give precedence to business customers, and eventually exploit the users and business clients to maximise short-term profits,” explains Gandhi. Thus, there are three stages in the evolution, growth, and maturity of social media. In the first stage, the platforms are perceived as valuable to the society, and empower the individual, and democratise communication. They “build value for users, build a community, and lock in that community.” In the second stage, once attention is guaranteed, the information is sold to the advertisers.

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SINCE 1865

In the final stage, the platforms do not add value to either the users or businesses. They amass the profits. If the users searched for content earlier, the process is reversed as the content begins to find the users. “They (social media) target you constantly. Thus, it is dangerous to allow social media to permeate our lives, and this is why it is a good idea to first ban, then regulate, and finally ease,” says Gandhi. In effect, laws to restrict, limit, and ban are part of the evolutionary process.

Overall, the discussions in India are still in the early stages, despite the bans by the two states. Reports suggest that the central government is not interested in a blanket ban, like Karnataka, but wishes to explore ways to regulate the access to social media. Age verification tech may emerge as a potential solution to ensure compliance with restrictions. The outcomes will depend on the seriousness among the policy-makers, experts’ advice, and reactions of the tech firms. Most experts do not favour a ban, but agree on controlled entries to platforms, with guidance from the teachers, parents, as well as specialists.

According to Sambit Pal, director, journalism school at MIT, “These steps will lead to less addictive scrolling, and restrict exposure to harmful content. We need parental guidance, and free conversations about how to use social media wisely. The platforms must implement stricter age-verification systems, and ensure that content offered to underage users is appropriate and safe.” Adds Joydeep Dasgupta, founder, Media Skills Lab, “Unfettered social media access exposes children to online risks like cyberbullying, predators, and unhealthy comparisons. Parents should guide and set limits on screen time, ensuring a balance between digital learning and real-life interactions.”

Psychologists note that restricting access can reduce risks of addiction, anxiety, depression, sleep disorders, and body image issues among teenagers. Karnataka’s child development consultant, Saritha Nagaraj, highlighted mental health symptoms from unhealthy comparisons. Gandhi wants the policy-makers to consider other related issues. For example, he explains, “If you look closely, the content is owned by the platform. So, even if it is not used elsewhere, since one single case may lead them to lose credibility, they do hold a legal right.” This needs to change, either as a law, or self-imposed rules.

However, despite the growing focus on use of social media, the laws may not be enough. Indeed, they are likely to be legally challenged. Finally, the courts will decide. In the US, a few cases were resolved in favour of the parents and children in the recent past. These may propel more cases against social media and online platforms. This may lead to a chain reaction like the one against the cigarette firms in the 1980s. There may be problems to impose the bans, like age certification, apart from a backlash from the teenagers, who may protest them.

(The author has more than three decades of experience across print, TV, and digital media)

At the last analysts’ call, after the sensational resignation by the former chairman, Atanu Chakraborty, which was attended by the part-time new chairman, the legendary Keki Mistry, the focus was on the post-resignation repercussions. According to a report by Emkay Global Financial, HDFC Bank attributed Chakraborty’s exit largely to interpersonal issues. It categorically denied governance or regulatory issues. One of the regulators, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) took the same view. “Mistry... indicated that he would not have accepted the role at the age of 71 if there were any integrity or governance issues... which we believe is comforting,” states the brokerage house’s report.

However, investors may not fully agree. Over the past six months, the stock price has dipped by ₹200, or more than 20 per cent, although it went up yesterday by nearly three per cent, after weeks of turmoil, doom, crash, and recoil. Indeed, research reports contend that the bank has struggled with the transition among the top management that began in October 2020, followed by the suspension of its credit card business by the RB, and the merger with HDFC Ltd, which hurt its growth and margin trajectories. Hence, everything depends on the turnaround plan that was chalked by the merged entity.

Obviously, it is imperative for the bank to establish that the strategic plan was on track. “The management has exhibited confidence in the growth and margin recovery, aided by easing regulatory pressures and a pause in the rate cycle. It reiterated in the analyst call that recent... exits will not derail the turnaround, while indicating a potential organisational rejig,” notes the Emkay’s report. However, the problems with the Dubai branch related to mis-selling of bonds, sacking of several executives, and the chairman’s resignation do not bode well. Hence, the eyes will be on the bank’s next few quarters, and next board meeting.

“The improved operating performance in the coming year will be critical to the stock performance. The swift regulatory engagement and interim leadership appointment do provide comfort on operational continuity,” highlights another report by Motilal Oswal. Implicit in the wordings are some warnings. Financials need to improve in the future. The interim measures provide comfort, but need to be followed up efficiently. One will need to see the impact of the Sebi investigations, although the central bank seems to have given a clean chit without major probes.

According to the exchange filings, the bank’s Q4-26 results indicate that the average advances under management reached

Ego trips or turnaround drips

HDFC Bank dubs it as personal issues, others as ongoing troubles

₹29.64 lakh crore, or an approximate 10 per cent increase over the figure in the same period the previous year. On the liabilities side, the bank’s average deposits reached ₹28.51 lakh crore in the quarter ending March 2026, marking a growth of 12.8 per cent during the same period last year. In this context, the average CASA deposits stood at ₹9.18 lakh crore, reflecting a rise of 10.8 per cent compared to ₹8.29 lakh crore.

The average time deposits reached ₹19.33 lakh crore, experiencing a growth of 13.7 per cent from ₹16.99 lakh crore. As of March 31, 2026, the bank’s total deposits were ₹31.06 lakh crore, marking an increase of 14.4 per cent from ₹27.15 lakh crore the previous year. At the end of the period, CASA deposits were about ₹10.61 lakh crore, reflecting a 12.3 per cent increase from ₹9.45 lakh crore a year earlier. The time deposits rose to ₹20.45 lakh crore, marking a stronger growth of 15.5 per cent compared

to ₹17.70 lakh crore as of March 31, 2025.

“We maintain our earnings estimates, and expect Return on Assets and Return on Equity at 1.9 per cent, and 14.5 per cent, respectively, by FY27E. We retain our BUY rating with a Target Price (TP) of ₹1,100... along with an additional ₹137 per share attributed to the bank’s subsidiaries,” notes the Motilal Oswal report. Emkay’s predictions are similar, with a target price of ₹1,225. “However, we believe HDFCB needs to rebuild leadership strength and soon clarify on the current MD’s term extension beyond Oct-26, along with the appointment of a credible long-tenure Chairman, which may otherwise remain a drag on the stock in the near term,” it warns.

But the final price movements will depend on how the bank deals with the ongoing HR, operational, merger, and profit issues. Ongoing compliance problems include the

ban on Dubai branch, and fines for multiple loan benchmarks, and outsourcing KYC processes. The impact of the merger seems to hang over the bank like a sword. It created complexities, and led to the pressures on margins. “The bank’s net interest margins have decreased from 4.1 per cent pre-merger to 3.3-3.5 per cent in early-2026,” explains an analysis via AI tool. The recent resignation has nudged the governance waters, along with financial ones.

The fact remains that the \$10-billion merger was described as a “merger of equals,” with the objective that big is better. In 2023, it created a combined entity with an asset base of ₹18 lakh crore. But there were problems in operations. “Two key metrics that the market closely tracks, loan growth and net interest margin, came under immediate pressure. The absorption of HDFC’s large mortgage book, which carries lower yields, structurally altered the bank’s margin profile. Furthermore, the bank’s credit-to-deposit ratio surged past 100 per cent, signalling that loan growth was outpacing deposit.... This forced the bank to rely on more expensive market borrowings, further squeezing profitability, and raising concerns,” states an analysis.

Hence, the premium stock valuation vanished. Historically known for high net margins of over four per cent, investors had to contend with 3.5 per cent. The race for deposits implied new challenges. This demolished its premium positioning. Thus, the bank, which commanded a premium valuation over its peers in the stock market, saw this advantage eroded, as competitors “demonstrated consistent performance,” traded at higher multiples, and displaced HDFC Bank from the leadership position.

Thus, according to an analysis, “HDFC Bank is navigating a complex and challenging transition. The strategic vision of the merger remains intact, but the path to realising its full potential is proving to be longer, and more arduous than initially anticipated. The bank’s ability to accelerate deposit growth to fund its loan book profitably will be the ultimate determinant for success. While the Q3 (and Q4) performance shows that the operational engine is firing, the stock’s recovery hinges on the management’s ability to restore confidence.”

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

PIOTECH

Apple prepares next-gen iPhone 18 Pro launch



Apple is gearing up to launch the next-generation of the iPhone soon with the iPhone 18 Pro series. The iPhone 18 Pro and iPhone 18 Pro Max are likely to launch later this year, along with a foldable iPhone. In the past few weeks, rumours have been surfacing online, giving us some idea of what the new iPhones may come with. Apple recently celebrated its 50th anniversary, having been founded on April 1, 1976. Apple brought a big design change with the iPhone 17 Pro models last year, with a large camera plateau. Reports indicate that the iPhone 18 Pro and iPhone 18 Pro Max will swap the dual-tone design of their predecessors for a single-tone look – for the aluminium unibody and the glass backplate. It is likely that iPhone 18 Pro models will get a new deep red or burgundy shade instead of the Cosmic Orange we saw last year. According to tipster Instant Digital, Apple is not planning to launch a black variant once again. On the front, however, you could see some big changes with the iPhone 18 Pro models. As per reports, Apple will shrink the Dynamic Island on the two devices by as much as 35 per cent compared to last year. This is possible due to the relocation of one Face ID component, the flood illuminator, beneath the screen, allowing for a more compact cutout while keeping front camera visibility in the top-left corner. Though the displays themselves will likely be unchanged from last year – a 6.3-inch OLED unit for the iPhone 18 Pro and a 6.9-inch OLED panel for the iPhone 18 Pro Max. Both devices are expected to get ProMotion, that is, a variable refresh rate up to 120Hz.

Valura.ai builds ₹3,000 crore AUM pipeline pre-launch



Valura.ai, an AI-native global investment platform, on Monday announced the onboarding of over 1,000 wealth advisors across India ahead of its official launch, with a collective AUM pipeline exceeding ₹3,000 crore over the next 12-18 months. The platform provides access to over one lakh global securities with client assets held in local custody within the IFSC at GIFT City under IFSCA regulation, rather than being routed through offshore brokers. The on-boarded network includes Independent Financial Advisors (IFAs), Registered Investment Advisors (RIAs), mutual fund distributors, and chartered accountants. "Valura combines AI-driven research and portfolio construction with seamless execution, compliance automation, and local custody," Priyesh Ranjan, CEO at Valura.ai, said.

Layoffs shift to structural reset, says Neeti Sharma



Layoffs are shifting from cyclical triggers to a structural reset, as AI yields productivity gains with leaner teams, reshapes hiring, and pushes companies toward high-skill workforce models, according to TeamLease Digital CEO Neeti Sharma. Repeated layoffs are increasing job insecurity, with over 60 per cent of tech workers reporting anxiety about stability, Sharma said. For companies layoffs are less about a financial squeeze and more about shifting to technology-driven scalability from labour-intensive models. The comments come against the backdrop of instances of brutal downsizing in the technology industry over the past months, with some prominent tech giants including Oracle, Google and Meta slashing roles. First-hand, emotional accounts of a cold, impersonal approach to retrenchments with '6 am email' culture – the dreaded, automated termination notice sent in the pre-dawn hours that deactivates employee badges before they can even log in, have sent shockwaves across the industry, fuelling anxiety among the tech workforce globally, and in India. Data from tracking site Layoffs.fyi shows that more than 70 tech companies have shed a staggering 40,480 jobs globally, just this year. "Layoffs are still largely cyclically driven by post-pandemic over-hiring and slower global tech spending growth (about 5-6 per cent). However, AI is emerging as a structural factor," Sharma said. Productivity gains to the extent of between 10-30 per cent have started becoming visible in tasks like coding and support, enabling leaner teams. While AI isn't the primary driver just yet, it is accelerating a shift toward efficiency-led operating models, reducing the need for large, execution-heavy workforces, as per the TeamLease Digital top executive. That said, AI is delivering measurable gains at a task level, just not yet at enterprise scale. "Industry trends are showing 14-15 per cent productivity improvement in customer support and up to 40 per cent in select coding and writing tasks. However, most firms are still in early adoption stages, with limited evidence of revenue impact," Sharma noted. AI-driven productivity gains (10-40 per cent in select tasks) are reducing routine roles while accelerating demand for specialised talent. Job insecurity is rising due to repeated layoffs, with over 60 per cent of tech workers reporting anxiety about stability. "This is happening alongside a deeper structural shift – legacy IT roles stagnating while digital roles surge, creating uneven opportunities," she said. The result is heightened stress, especially among mid-skill workers facing obsolescence. Earlier this year, fintech giant Block, which is led by storied entrepreneur and Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey, announced layoffs of more than 4,000 employees, or nearly 40 per cent of its headcount. In a recently published essay coauthored with Sequoia partner Roelof Botha, Dorsey suggested that in the coming years, the role of the middle manager could be rendered obsolete. Companies like Pinterest, CrowdStrike, and Chegg too have announced job cuts blaming AI adoption for broader organisational reset.

Sovereign Confusion: Why India is Regulating AI Upside Down

Why India's current piecemeal approach to AI regulation is building a house of cards—and how a doctrine of "Agentic Accountability" can save it



NISHANT SAHDEV

India is not deciding whether to regulate Artificial Intelligence. That ship has sailed. Instead, we are already regulating AI—through a series of backdoors and stop-gap rules that risk locking the country into a system that is simultaneously overbearing for innovators and ineffective for citizens. The real danger to India's tech future isn't a lack of a law; it is the "sovereign confusion" being baked into policy. We are attempting to regulate 21st-century intelligence with 19th-century mentalities designed for static databases. Nations do not lose technological races because they lack talent. They lose them because they confuse control with clarity. India is dangerously close to doing both.

The Input-Output Fallacy: Why DPDP Fails AI

The Government's primary defense is the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act. But using the DPDP to govern AI is like using a parking permit to regulate a supersonic jet. The DPDP focuses on input—the data. But AI harms occur at the output—the decision. We have strict rules for how a name is stored—and none for how it destroys a life. When an AI system denies a loan to a woman in rural Bihar based on an opaque "risk profile," or filters a candidate out of a job pool due to historical bias embedded in its training, the DPDP is silent. It can tell you who owns the data, but not who is responsible for the judgment.

By obsessing over data privacy while ignoring algorithmic agency, India is regulating the ingredients while the kitchen is on fire. We protect the "bit" but ignore the "bite." Citizens are assured that their data is safe, even as the decisions derived from that data remain beyond legal scrutiny. This is not just a governance gap—it is a failure that leaves individuals exposed to unaccountable machine logic.

The 3-Hour Paradox: Outsourcing Judgment

The IT Rules Amendment 2026 and its 3-hour takedown mandate for Synthetically Generated Information (SGI) is the clearest example of state-induced algorithmic overreach. On paper, it targets deepfakes. In practice, automated censorship grows.

In trying to fight deepfakes, the



state is outsourcing judgment to machines it does not control—and punishing platforms for hesitation. No human can reliably verify a complex, multi-modal deepfake within 180 minutes. Timeline is not a safeguard; it is a hurdle. To comply, platforms are forced to deploy "censor-bots" designed to err on the side of removal.

The consequences are predictable. Fear of the fake begins to eliminate the freedom of the real. Satire, dissent, and citizen journalism are filtered out before human review, not because they are false, but because they are risky. In effect, the State is mandating a system where liability determines truth. The outcome is an internet shaped less by facts than by the cost of being wrong.

The Core Doctrine: Agentic Accountability

If India wants to lead the global AI discourse, it must stop treating AI as a content problem and start treating it as an agency problem. We need a new doctrine: Agentic Accountability.

In simple terms: if an AI makes a decision, someone must stand behind it. Today, accountability dissolves into a loop of deflection. Developers blame training data, platforms blame user prompts, and users are left without recourse. Agentic Accountability reverses this logic. If an entity deploys an AI system to perform a human function—whether in finance, hiring, healthcare, or law—it must bear responsibility for the outcome of that system.

This is the "Third Way" India could offer globally. It avoids suffocating innovation with pre-emptive bans while ensuring that outcomes remain legally grounded. It moves the regulatory focus from process

to consequence. It allows innovation to continue, but removes the ability to hide behind technical opacity when harm occurs.

The Enforcement Reality: An Institutional Void

A doctrine, however elegant, is only as strong as its enforcement. India must confront a difficult question: does it possess the institutional capacity to audit, test, and challenge AI systems at scale?

Current regulators were built for telecommunications and broadcasting. They are not equipped to interrogate neural networks, audit datasets, or detect latent bias in complex models. Passing an AI law without building this capacity risks creating a "paper tiger"—a framework that appears strong but is weak in practice.



Such a system disproportionately burdens startups, which lack compliance infrastructure, while allowing large technology firms to navigate or obscure accountability through complexity. Accountability without enforcement capacity is not governance—it is theatre.

The Sovereignty Mirage: Nationalising Dependence

India's push toward "Sovereign AI" through the IndiaAI Mission is praising, but it obscures a vulnerability also. The country risks nationalising the cost of AI while privatising its dependence.

Public funds are being spend to subsidise compute and expand

access to GPUs, yet the underlying hardware ecosystem remains globally dependent. Domestic supply chains for critical components—from rare earth elements to advanced semiconductors—are still emerging. Sovereignty, in this context, cannot be legislated; it must be built.

Without linking mineral policy, manufacturing capability, and AI deployment into a unified framework, India risks constructing a digital ecosystem reliant on external foundations. A software-driven vision of sovereignty, unsupported by hardware independence, is inherently unstable. We are, in effect, building a digital skyscraper on rented infrastructure.

The Power Position: Exporting Accountability

The global AI race is no longer defined solely by who builds the most advanced systems. It is increasingly defined by who determines accountability when those systems fail. This is India's strategic opening.

The United States has adopted a market-led approach, placing trust in private sector leadership. The European Union has pursued a risk-based model, emphasising precaution and control. India has the opportunity to define a third path—one grounded in responsibility and outcome-based regulation.

By formalising and exporting Agentic Accountability, India can influence global standards, particularly across emerging economies facing similar challenges. This is not merely about domestic governance; it is about framing the international rules of the AI era. The objective should not be to replicate Western systems with localised adaptations, but to construct a framework rooted in Indian reali-

ties. Without such a move, decision-making in India will continue to indicate assumptions embedded in foreign-trained models. Regulatory leadership, rather than technological mimicry, is where long-term influence lies.

Notifications vs Rights: Choice

Conflict between MeitY and the Parliamentary Standing Committee highlights a core dilemma: should AI be governed by executive decree or legislative rights?

Flexible rule-making allows speed, but it also creates uncertainty. Policies that can be altered without parliamentary scrutiny undermine both investor confidence and citizen protections. Startups cannot build on conveying regulatory ground, and individuals cannot assert rights that lack permanence.

A notification-driven system centralises power while diffusing accountability. In contrast, a statutory AI framework establishes boundaries that cannot be easily overridden. The debate, therefore, is not procedural—it is foundational.

India must decide what it seeks to regulate: data, decisions, or power. Currently, it attempts to control all three using tools designed for one. The demand for an AI Act is not about expanding regulation, but about stabilising it—creating rules that endure beyond administrative discretion.

Conclusion: The Strategic Miscalculation

India needs a clear and responsible approach to AI, not scattered and reactive rules. This technology is too powerful to be managed without a strong and consistent framework that ensures accountability.

If things continue as they are, India won't fail because of a lack of talent—it will fail because it misunderstands what needs to be regulated. Confusing control with real understanding could become a serious strategic mistake.

Once these policies are built into laws and systems, they will be hard to fix. India is on track to become a digital power, but the real danger is building a system that limits innovation while failing to protect people.

The question is no longer whether to regulate AI, but whether India can do it clearly and responsibly—before confusion defines its future.

Author is a theoretical physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, US, and the author of the forthcoming book *The Last Equation Before Silence*

India's powerful educational practices push youth with momentum



DR T SENTHIL SIVA SUBRAMANIAN

India has moved into the space of computational era in 21st century. Today there is a great demand for talented youth to perform and manage routine tasks at home which prepares them to solve complex assignments at the workplace. India needs youth to be self-driven, curious learners, problem solvers, conscious towards their duties and most importantly responsible for the society and nation. Overall, our nation needs holistic thinkers and implement them successfully with optimized resources and infrastructure. A holistic development of youth meets the objectives of Viksit Bharat@2047.

India is preparing itself against the local and global challenges through imbibing various educational framework models which is being practiced successfully across institutions starting from schools.

Comprehensive and Holistic approach: Learn by Doing (*Kar Ke Seekna*)

National Educational Policy 2020 being a revolutionary educational framework introduced in India five years before, bridges the gap between learning and practice. We are steadily and swiftly implementing the best practices of our National Education Policy 2020 which starts from school to higher education through national qualification framework: School (Level 1 to 4) and higher education framework (4.5 to 8).

The modern age best practices in institutions reinvents the education systems in India. Additionally, educational institutions, especially schools of today, are making the students perform daily home assignments [DHAs], everyday class tests / class Assignments [CAs]. Schools are even preparing to implement the best practices of "OPEN BOOK EXAMINATION."

These exercises consciously prepare the students to follow disciplined and meticulous routine learning practices. Today

even schools are preparing the students to make a journey from classroom to boardrooms through making them deliver seminars/talks and model making on current trends and technologies. Educational institutions across our nation are practicing workbased skills through firsthand experiential learning so called work experience laboratory learning like clay modeling, candle making, craft work, painting. Most importantly it makes young students adapt to the mantra: learn by doing (*Kar Ke Seekna*).

The schools of today are enabling the students to choose Sanskrit, music, languages



and drawing as open elective subjects in addition to their science subjects. This develops holistic development among the students. Schools of modern age are giving opportunities for social

service, winter/summer camps, NSS and NCC, perform regular activities through student clubs.

The students are trained to tinker at various real-world problem statements and design small skillbased science projects which create a culture of skill-based learning. The best working example is the Atal Tinkering labs established under Atal Innovation Mission by Niti Aayog.

Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, Government of India is creating ample opportunities to explore the student's inner talents through making the students to participate in the World Skills Competition conducted annually which involves the process of making the student to take theoretical and practical tests in different traits at the industrial training institutes which are conducted across PAN India. It focuses on:

- Construction and Building Technology
- Creative Arts and Fashion
- Information and Communication Technology
- Manufacturing and Engineering Technology
- Social and Personal Services
- Transportation and Logistics.



The world skill competition follows the guidelines of OECD (Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development) which includes organising work and self-management, time management, problem solving, innovation and creativity, team building and most importantly the collaborative and cooperative efforts making.

Preparing Next Generation Youth for Viksit Bharat@2047

Ministry of Education, Government of India has successfully launched the pathbreaking First-of-its kind course curriculum on computational thinking and Artificial intelligence for classes starting from third to eighth standard. It clearly follows the guidelines of innovative teaching and learning pedagogy of National Educational Policy 2020. The revolutionary curriculum aligns it with National Curriculum Framework for School Education. The core curriculum recommends 50 hours and one hundred hours of learning for class 3-5 and 6-8, respectively.

India is preparing the youth to be the next generation leaders in technology by integrat-

ing the strong mantra 'AI in Education' and 'AI for Education.' The Central Board of Secondary Education

has played a vital role in changing the dimensions of thinking practices of students by making them to be 'AI-Ready Learners. The computational thinking concept is a subset of subjects like The World Around Us (TWAS) and mathematics underlying the principles of learning through workbooks.

A step-by-step approach is being adapted in the learning pedagogy in schools starting from worksheets based on games, puzzles in class third leading to solving real-world problems in class eighth through computation and AI approach. The younger generation will rewrite/rewrite and code/decode real-time complex problems leading to building AI enabled Community and AI integrated Society. India has made a bold step by making 'AI for ALL.'

Author is Head Institute Industry Interface Program Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Gunmen kill 3 police officers

Unidentified gunmen on Monday killed three security personnel in two separate attacks in northwest Pakistan, police said. The attacks occurred in the Bannu district in restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. According to a police official, the first incident occurred in the Kanger Jan Bahadur area of Mandan, where a police official was shot dead while on his way to duty. Law enforcement agencies rushed to the scene, cordoned off the area, and shifted the body to a nearby hospital, he added. A search operation was launched to nab the attackers. In a separate attack, armed men opened fire at a NADRA (National Database and Registration Authority) office in the Baka Khel area of the district, killing a constable and a security guard, police said.

Israel hits Iran’s South Pars petrochemical plant

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Israel attacked a key petrochemical plant at Iran’s massive South Pars natural gas field and killed a top Revolutionary Guard commander, putting into question the negotiations aimed at getting the US and Tehran to reach a ceasefire. Israel’s Defence Minister Israel Katz confirmed what he called “a powerful strike on the largest petrochemical facility in Iran” that’s responsible for half of the country’s petrochemical production. Israel’s military spokesperson, Lt Col Nadav Shoshani, said there would be “no immunity” for Iran as talks progress. The gas field shared with Qatar is the



world’s largest and sits under the waters of the Persian Gulf. The White House did not immediately respond when asked about the strike. After Israel’s attack in March

on South Pars, Trump said Israel would not attack it again but warned that if Iran continued striking Qatar’s energy infrastructure, the United States would retaliate

and “massively blow up the entirety” of the field. Explosions rang out in Tehran, and low-flying jets could be heard for hours as the capital was pounded.

Thick black smoke rose near the city’s Azadi Square after one airstrike hit the grounds of the Sharif University of Technology.

Among those killed in one of the attacks on Tehran was the head of intelligence for Iran’s paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, Major General Majid Khademi, according to Iranian state media and Israel’s defence minister. Israel’s military said it also killed the leader of the Iranian paramilitary Revolutionary Guard’s undercover unit in its expeditionary Quds Force, Asghar Bakeri. Iranian missiles hit the northern Israeli city of Haifa, where four people were found dead in the rubble of a residential build-

ing. Kuwait, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia all activated their air defences to intercept incoming Iranian missiles and drones, as Tehran kept up the pressure on its Gulf neighbours.

Iran’s regular attacks on regional energy infrastructure and its stranglehold on the Strait of Hormuz.

Under pressure at home as consumers are growing increasingly concerned, Trump gave Tehran a deadline that expires Monday night Washington time, saying if no deal was reached to reopen the strait, the US would hit Iran’s power plants and other infrastructure targets and set the country “back to the Stone Age.”

Airstrikes kill more than 25 across Iran



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Monday’s morning airstrikes targeted Tehran’s Sharif University of Technology, where Iranian media reported damage to the buildings as well as a natural gas distribution site next to the campus. It wasn’t immediately clear what had been targeted on the grounds of the university, which is empty of students as the war has forced all schools in the country into online classes.

However, multiple countries over the years have sanctioned the university for its work with the military, particularly on Iran’s ballistic missile program, which is controlled by the country’s paramilitary Revolutionary Guard.

A strike near Eslamshar, southwest of Tehran, killed at least 15 people, authorities said. Five others were killed when a residential area in the city of Qom was hit, and six more were killed in strikes on other cities, the State-run IRAN daily newspaper reported.

Three more people were killed when an airstrike hit a home in Tehran, Iranian state television reported.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Izharul Haque, S/o. Shaikh Mohammad Hanif, R/o. D-13, Top Floor, Abul Fazal Enclave, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have changed my 17-year-old daughter's name from Saima Katoon to SAIMA for all future purposes.

PD(597)C I, Rhythm D/o Sunil Kumar Resident of E-32, HIG, Lajpat Nagar, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, hereby state that i have changed my name from Rhythm to Rhythm Goral. In all future records and references, I shall be known and recognized by the name Rhythm Goral.

PD(796)C I hitherto known as Bishnu S/o Bir Bahadur Kumal, R/o WZ-829/1, Naraina Village, New Delhi-110028 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Vishnu.

PD(799)C I, Harminder Singh S/o Ravinder Singh R/o WZ-16/4C Ram Nagar Extn Tilak Nagar Delhi-110018 have changed my name to Harminder Singh Bedi.

PD(800)C I, Harleen Kaur D/o Harminder Singh Bedi R/o WZ-16/4C Ram Nagar Extn Tilak Nagar Delhi-110018 have changed my name to Harleen Kaur Bedi.

PD(801)C I, Dinesh Kumar Madan S/o Girdhari Lal Madan R/o K-68A Old Govindpura Extn Krishna Nagar Delhi-110051 have changed my name to Dinesh Kumar Singh.

PD(802)C I, Uma Devi W/o Surender Kumar R/o 208/4, Gali No-4, Rameshwar Nagar Azad Pur, Delhi-110033, have changed my name to Uma Vats.

PD(803)C I, Nathu Singh, Father of No.16024194P L/Nk Deependra Singh Tomar, R/o- Ward No.4 Porsa Road Gormi, Teh- Gormi, Dist- Bhind M.P- 477660, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Nathu Singh Tomar whereas my correct name is Nathu Singh, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(804)C I, Rani, Mother of No.16024194P L/Nk Deependra Singh Tomar, R/o- Ward No.4 Porsa Road Gormi, Teh- Gormi, Dist- Bhind M.P- 477660, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Ranee Tomar whereas my correct name is Rani, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(805)C

I, Muskan, D/o- No.3188740M Ex- Hav Late Atul Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Usram, Teh- Khair, Dist- Aligarh, U.P - 202138, have changed my name from Muskan to Muskan Kumari, vide affidavit dated 06/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(806)C I, Parkashi Devi Spouse of No.2857139K Ex-Nk Late Rishi Pal, R/o- 580/203 Bharti Colony, Muzaffarnagar, U.P- 251002, have changed my name from Parkashi Devi to Prakashi, vide affidavit dated 06/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(807)C I, No.4284722X NK Amit Baxla, R/o- Vill- Kachabari, PO- Bingaon, PS- Karra, Dist- Khunti, Jharkhand- 835209, declare that in my service record my deceased mother's name is wrongly recorded as Fulkirya Devi whereas her name is Fulkieriya Bakhla which may be amended accordingly.

PD(808)C I, No.6495586H Hav Raju Kumar, R/o- Vill&PO- Asani, Teh-Ara, Dist- Bhojpur, Bihar- 802210, have changed my daughter's name from Aradhaya Yadav to Aradhya Yadav, vide affidavit dated 06/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(809)C I, Kamlesh Devi, Wife of JC- 682546F Nb/Sub Vijay Pal Singh, R/o- Vill- Nagla Harigovind, PO- Khirari, Teh- Mahawan, Dist- Mathura, U.P-281204 declare that in my husband's service record my D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 15-11-1984 whereas my correct DOB is 10-10-1987 which may be amended accordingly.

PD(810)C I, Aashkaran Singh, Father of No.16015307L CHM Sumer Singh Rathore, R/o- Vill- Sabarsar, Dist- Jodhpur, Rajasthan- 342022, have changed my name from Aashkaran Singh to Askaran Singh, vide affidavit dated 06/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(811)C I, Mohammed Shakeel S/o Mohammed Iqbal R/o 1241, Katra Hussain Mirza, Farash Khana, Delhi-110006 declare that in my Passport No. N 7581084 my name has been wrongly mentioned as Mohammed Shakil. My correct name is Mohammed Shakeel. Mohammed Shakeel & Mohammed Shakil both are one & the same person. Henceforth, I shall be known as Mohammed Shakeel for all purposes.

PD(812)C

Forces (IDF) Chief of Staff Lt Gen Eyal Zamir and senior military officials, Katz said, “The (Iranian) Revolutionary Guards shoot at civilians and we eliminate the heads of terrorists.”

“Iran’s leaders live with a sense of persecution. We will continue to hunt them down one by one,” the Israeli minister warned.

Israel will continue to attack Iran’s vital infrastructure to weaken its economic backbone and missile manufacturing capabilities, he said.

“We struck hard at the steel infrastructure and the petrochemical industry - and today and every day the continuation will



Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps' Intelligence Majid Khademi

come,” Katz said. Khademi entered the role of IRGC intel chief several months ago, following the killing of his

predecessor Mohammad Kazemi by Israel during the June 2025 war.

Israel has assassinated

several senior Iranian officials, including Supreme Leader Ayatollah Syed Ali Khamenei, who was killed in

Russian attacks kill 4 as Ukraine drones target oil infrastructure

DEREK GATOPOULOS/VOLODYMR YURCHUK ■ Kyiv

A Russian drone attack on Ukraine’s southern port city of Odesa killed two women and a toddler, authorities said on Monday, while Ukrainian long-range drones targeted Russia’s key Black Sea port for oil exports.

The nighttime attack on Odesa heavily damaged an apartment block, killing the women and a 2-year-old child, officials said. Rescuers working under floodlights pulled four people from the rubble. Eleven people were hospitalised, including a pregnant woman and two children — the youngest less than a year old, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in a post on X.



Russia has pounded civilian areas of Ukraine since it invaded its neighbour just over four years ago, killing more than 15,000 people, according to the United Nations. Over the past week, Russia has launched at Ukraine more than 2,800 attack drones, nearly 1,350

powerful glide bombs and more than 40 missiles of various types, according to Zelenskyy.

In the southern city of Kherson, Russian shelling killed an elderly woman and three other women, 86, 79 and 44, were hospitalised, according to Oleksandr

Prokudin, head of the regional military administration. The injured women sustained shrapnel wounds, concussion, blast injuries and head trauma, he said.

Russia has also taken aim at Ukraine’s power grid, and overnight barrages hit energy infrastructure in Chernihiv, Sumy, Kharkiv and Dnipro regions, Zelenskyy said. More than 300,000 households were without electricity in northern Chernihiv after distribution facilities were damaged in the attacks, according to the regional power utility.

Zelenskyy expressed concern in a weekend interview with The Associated Press that the war in the Middle East is draining stockpiles of weapons that

Ukraine needs to defend itself, especially American-made Patriot air defence systems that can stop missiles. Zelenskyy said Monday that the country’s partners “need to strengthen air defence together so that the interception rate of drones and missiles continues to increase.”

With US-led peace efforts stalled, Zelenskyy added: “Russia has no intention of stopping” its invasion.

Ukraine has fought back by developing its own long-range drones, which now reach targets some 1,500 kilometres (900 miles) inside Russia. Ukraine has used them recently to hammer Russian oil facilities as Moscow looks to boost its exports after the Trump

administration gave it a temporary waiver from sanctions to ease supply constraints. Kyiv officials complain that Russia will use the additional revenue on new weapons to hit Ukraine harder.

Russia’s Defence Ministry said that air defences downed 50 Ukrainian drones overnight. Krasnodar Gov. Veniamin Kondratyev said that eight people, including two children, were injured in a series of Ukrainian drone attacks on Novorossiysk, one of Russia’s largest Black Sea ports. The attack damaged six apartment buildings and two private houses, he said.

Unconfirmed media reports said the drones targeted the Sheskharis oil terminal at the Black Sea port.

Russia to start building national orbital station in 2028: Official

VINAY SHUKLA ■ Moscow

Russia will start building its national orbital station ahead of the scheduled deorbiting of the International Space Station (ISS) in 2030, a top Russian space official said on Monday.

The first module of the Russian Orbital Station (ROS) will be deployed in 2028, CEO of Russia’s Roscosmos State Space Corporation Dmitry Bakanov said in an interview with the state-owned news agency TASS. Russia marks Space Week, starting Monday, to celebrate the 65th anniversary of the first human space flight by Soviet cosmonaut Yuri Gagarin on April 12, 1961.

“In 2028, according to the latest agreement reached with NASA, we will begin rounding off work on the ISS and complete its deorbiting in 2030. The Russian Orbital Station (ROS) should be launched at exactly this time, becoming a fully-fledged, independent national station in orbit where we will conduct our experiments,” Bakanov said.

He underlined the importance of synchronising the completion of work on the ISS and the deployment of the ROS. In December 2025, Russian First Deputy Prime Minister Denis Manturov announced that Russia had approved a 51.6-degree orbital inclination for the ROS— matching the orbit of the International Space Station. (PTT)



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British Indian minister Lisa Nandy launches Hubs to support UK youth

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Lisa Nandy, the UK’s Secretary of State for Culture, Media and Sport, on Monday launched the first set of eight “Young Futures Hubs” in areas of England with high levels of anti-social behaviour and knife crime.

The British Indian minister said the first of a planned network of 50 such hubs will provide joined-up services across mental health and wellbeing, employment and crime prevention.

Tower Hamlets in east London, Birmingham, Brighton, Bristol, Durham, Leeds, Manchester and Nottingham are among the



areas to get the first hubs as part of the British Government’s National Youth Strategy. “These hubs are about more than bricks and mortar, they’re a statement that this Government believes in young people and is investing in their futures,” said Nandy. “What

makes them different is that we’re joining things up – wellbeing support, crime prevention, work coaches, youth services, all in one place. We’re making sure teenagers have somewhere to go, someone to talk to, and a real chance to thrive,” she said.

The minister blamed the previous Conservative Party administration for the closure of over a thousand youth centres since 2010, which she said the Labour Government was working to address. “The closures] didn’t just take away facilities, it took away community, connection and opportunity for a generation. We are determined to rebuild that,” she added.

The new hubs will build on existing services to create safe, welcoming spaces, bringing a range of local support services under one roof. Young people aged 10-18, up to 25 years for those with special needs, will have

access to trusted adults who will provide wellbeing support, careers guidance, and positive activities like sport, arts and volunteering. “The Government is committed to ensuring that success for young people is not determined by their background, and the hubs will also offer support for vulnerable children. These activities help divert young people away from knife crime and anti-social behaviour, as well as combat social isolation and mental health, and increase access to job opportunities for young people,” the Department for Culture, Media and Sport (DCMS) stated.

DCMS said its Young Futures Hubs programme, part of a 70-million-pound investment into local youth services running until March 2029, has been designed to create youth-led spaces where young people can enjoy real-life connections – with somewhere to go, something to do, and someone who cares for them.

The move coincides with a plan to halve knife crime within a decade in the UK. In some areas, the hubs will work with new multi-agency Young Futures Panels to ensure children at risk of knife crime are provided with the support they need. (PTT)

26 killed in Nigeria’s deadly attacks, says official

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Abuja

At least 26 people have been killed in three separate Easter attacks in northern Nigeria, according to the Nigerian military and local officials.

At least 17 were killed on Saturday when armed men attacked the Mbalom community in the Gwer West area of Nigeria’s north-central Benue State.

Benue State Governor Hyacinth Alia confirmed the attacks on Sunday, but did not specify how many people were killed in the attack. Residents gave the figure of 17. Attacks like these are part of a long-running cycle of violence in north-central Nigeria, where disputes over land and grazing between mostly Muslim Fulani herders and largely Christian farming communities frequently



escalate into deadly clashes. Criminal gangs are also active. Tarhana Samson, a community resident, described the attacks as “devastating.” “The rainy season is coming, and this is when people are preparing to go to their farms.

How do they do that now?” Samson said. In a separate attack early Saturday morning against a police headquarters in Borno State in the northeast of the country, four police officers were killed after a protracted gunfight with an Islamic State-affiliated group, according to Borno Police Public Relations Officer Kenneth Daso.

On Sunday, at an Easter service in Ariko village, in Kaduna state, gunmen killed five people, according to the army.

The identity of the gunmen is unknown. The army said the assailants were forced to abandon the abduction of 31 hostages after

troops responded to a distress call. “Regrettably, the remains of five victims already killed by the terrorists were also recovered at the scene,” the army said.

“The fleeing terrorists are believed to have sustained significant casualties, as evidenced by blood trails along their escape routes.” Kaduna has continued to record attacks on churches and frequent abductions. In January, more than 150 worshippers were abducted from Kurmin Wali, a village in Kaduna’s Kajuru area, about 60 kilometres from Sunday’s attack.

Similar attacks on churches have sparked allegations of the persecution of Christians by US President Trump and some American lawmakers, which the Nigerian Government has rejected. The US Government launched military strikes in Sokoto on December 25, allegedly targeting an Islamic State.

30 passengers evacuate after cruise ship in Fiji



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Melbourne

Thirty passengers were evacuated from a cruise ship that ran aground on a reef in Fiji, the ship’s owner said on Monday. The MV Fiji Princess, operated by Blue Lagoon Cruises, ran aground Saturday near Monuriki Island, scene of the 2000 movie starring Tom Hanks, “Cast Away,” the Fiji-based tourism company said in a statement.

“Whilst the investigation is in its early stages, conditions upon the ship anchoring in the area were calm, and it appears a severe squall caused the ship’s anchor to drag towards a nearby reef, whereby the ship became grounded,” the statement

said. A ferry was brought alongside the 55.52-metre (182-foot) ship at first light on Sunday, and 30 passengers disembarked with their luggage and belongings. No one was injured.

The passengers were taken to Denarau Island.

Blue Lagoon Cruises said pumpable fuel as well as other oils stored onboard the ship had been removed by Monday, diminishing environmental risks.

A salvage specialist from Australia had been on the scene since Sunday, overseeing recovery efforts, the statement said. The Maritime Safety Authority of Fiji, an industry regulator, did not respond to a request for comment on Monday.

Indian envoy reassures Delhi’s intent to rebuild ties with Bangladesh

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dhaka

India is willing to rebuild ties with Bangladesh with a “forward-looking approach”, Indian High Commissioner Pranay Verma conveyed to Prime Minister Tarique Rahman on Monday.

The meeting came as India and Bangladesh are making efforts to rebuild bilateral ties after Rahman became prime minister following his Bangladesh Nationalist Party’s victory in the February parliamentary polls.

The ties between the two nations came under severe strain during the past tenure of Bangladesh’s interim government headed by Muhammad Yunus. During

the meeting, Verma and Rahman “discussed bilateral engagement with a focus on people-centric cooperation in multiple domains aligned with the national development priorities of the two countries,” the Indian High Commission said in an X post.

The High Commissioner also conveyed “India’s intent to work together with the Government and people of Bangladesh by adopting a positive, constructive and forward-looking approach and based on mutual interest and mutual benefit.”

The State-run BSS news agency, quoting a premier’s office spokesman, said Verma paid a courtesy call on Rahman at his Cabinet



Division office in Bangladesh Secretariat here, without any immediate elaboration.

However, officials familiar with the meeting said the envoy told Rahman that India and Bangladesh should transform their geographical proximity into new opportunities through strengthened economy, connectivity and

enhanced cultural and people-to-people exchanges.

Bangladesh’s Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman, the premier’s Foreign Affairs Adviser Humayun Kabir, and Indian Deputy High Commissioner to Bangladesh Pawan Badhe were among those present at the meeting. The high

commissioner’s call came a day ahead of Foreign Minister Kahlilur Rahman’s planned New Delhi visit, when he is likely to meet his Indian counterpart S Jaishankar, National Security Adviser Ajit Doval, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri.

India has shown its willingness to rebuild ties with Dhaka since the February 12 elections brought Rahman’s BNP to power. Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla represented the Indian Government at the swearing-in ceremony of the newly elected BNP government on February 17, bringing with him a letter from Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Indian envoy, Nepal’s foreign minister discuss bilateral ties



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

Indian Ambassador Naveen Srivastava paid a courtesy call on Nepal’s newly-appointed Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal on Monday and discussed various aspects of bilateral ties.

Khanal assumed office at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs on March 27.

During the meeting, Srivastava conveyed External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar’s greetings on Khanal’s appointment, according to a statement by the Foreign Ministry.

“Various matters relating to Nepal-India relations and cooperation were discussed on the occasion,” said the statement.

Jaishankar had extended his greetings to Khanal on X the day he assumed office.

Jaishankar said he looks forward to working closely with his Nepalese counterpart to further strengthen the traditional partnership between India and Nepal.

Hungary’s Orban faces a tough election battle

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Budapest

Hungary’s elections on April 12 will have profound aftermaths as many in the European Union hope for the defeat of nationalist Prime Minister Viktor Orban, who is widely seen as endangering the future of the 27-nation bloc.

Orban, the EU’s longest-serving leader, has trailed in the polls. His 16-year grip on power has tested the EU system of governance meant to ensure peace through economic and political integration after the ravages of the world wars. His rival Peter Magyar told the Associated Press he would repair Hungary’s relationship with the EU if elected. The EU is grappling with enormous threats: the rise of right-wing populism, conflicts in Ukraine and the Middle East, Russian sabotage efforts, Chinese economic expansion and a White House that is upending decades of transatlantic cooperation.

But Orban’s vetoes have limited EU responses.

Lawmakers and analysts say he has used his right of veto and a deep understanding of how the bloc disperses funding to members to entrench his power and gain outside influence by blocking decision-making to extract concessions. “He entered a club, read the rules, figured out how he can rig the rules, and then started to be a free rider and blackmail all of the



Prime Minister Viktor Orban

other club members,” said Daniel Hegedus, deputy director with the Berlin-based Institute for European Politics. “The question is, how long will the club members tolerate it?”

It didn’t start that way. After the Cold War, Hungary joined the EU along with nine other countries in 2004 in the bloc’s largest expansion ever. There was widespread optimism for Hungary, said Jim Townsend, a fellow at the Centre for a New American Security. But after economic crises, Orban came to power by promising prosperity to the rich and poor alike, said Gabor Scheiring, a former Hungarian lawmaker now teaching at Georgetown University in Qatar. He also built bonds with conservative politicians across the bloc.

Orban began vilifying the EU, often comparing Brussels to the Soviet Union, even while receiving massive amounts of EU money, and resisting pressure to reverse democratic backsliding. From 2014 until 2022, “Hungary was one of the biggest beneficiaries of EU funds,” Scheiring said.

Kim Jong Un’s daughter to be next supreme leader, says Seoul agency

HYUNG-JIN KIM ■ Seoul

South Korea’s spy agency says it’s now fair to view the teenage daughter of North Korean leader Kim Jong Un as his heir, its strongest assessment yet on the rising political status of the girl who it believes could extend her family’s rule into a fourth generation.

The girl, dubbed by state media as Kim’s “most beloved” or “respected” child, has accompanied her father to numerous high-profile events since late 2022, sparking outside speculation that she’s being groomed as the North’s future leader.

In a closed-door briefing at the National Assembly, South Korea’s National Intelligence Service director Lee Jong-seok said the girl could be considered as Kim’s successor in response to questions by lawmakers about her political standing, according to Lee Seong Kweun, one of the lawmakers



who attended the meeting.

Asked about possible protests by Kim’s sister Kim Yo Jong, who has long been regarded as the North’s No. 2 figure, the NIS director responded that she has no substantial powers, lawmaker Lee told a briefing. He cited the NIS as citing unspecified “reliable intelligence.” (AP)

Declare TTP a terrorist organisation, Pak tells Afghan Govt

M ZULQERNAIN
■ Lahore

Pakistan has demanded that Afghanistan formally declare TTP as a terrorist organisation and dismantle its infrastructure as a precondition to resolve the ongoing border conflict between the two countries, local media reported on Monday.

Islamabad put forward three core demands last week during a meeting between representatives of Pakistan and the Afghan Taliban in the Chinese city of Urumqi, The Express Tribune newspaper reported.

The China-facilitated talks are the first major diplomatic engagement between the two neighbours since Pakistan launched Operation



Ghazab Iil-Haq in late February to target terrorist “hideouts” in Afghanistan.

“The three demands put forward by Islamabad include Kabul formally declaring the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) a terrorist organisation, dismantling its infrastructure, and providing verifiable proof of the action,” the report said, quoting sources.

These demands form the basis of Pakistan’s negotiating position, which has hardened amid persistent security concerns, the sources said.

According to the report, a framework is under discussion that could pave the way for a possible understanding between the two sides. It includes a “ceasefire arrangement, counterterrorism assurances from the Afghan Taliban, dismantling of terror sanctuaries inside Afghanistan, and measures to facilitate secure trade routes”.

It also envisages the establishment of a more structured and institutionalised dialogue mechanism between Islamabad and Kabul, as both sides have sent technical-level delegations to Urumqi, reflecting the operational nature of the discussions.

The conflict between Pakistan and Afghanistan

intensified in recent months over Islamabad’s allegations of Kabul harbouring the TTP and the Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA) militants. Afghanistan consistently denied and asked Pakistan to take action, asserting that these groups are active in Pakistani provinces.

On Sunday, Afghan Foreign Minister Amir Khan Muttaqi acknowledged the dialogue was still underway and that the Taliban regime wanted to resolve issues with Pakistan through talks.

Pakistan Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said Islamabad’s participation in the talks should not be construed as a shift in policy, particularly regarding ongoing security operations. (PTI)

PTI demands judicial inquiry into encounter killings



M ZULQERNAIN
■ Lahore

Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf (PTI) founder Imran Khan and the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP) have called for an immediate judicial inquiry into the killing of over 1,000 people in “staged encounters” by a special police force formed by Punjab Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz.

According to an official of HRCP, over 1,000 suspects have been killed by Punjab’s Crime Control Department (CCD) through “staged encounters” during the last year with impunity.

“The CCD has adopted a deliberate policy of staged police encounters leading to extrajudicial killing,” an official of HRCP said on Monday.

In 2025, he said the CCD conducted 670 encounters in Punjab that resulted in the deaths of 924 suspects.

“This tally has crossed the 1,000 mark this year,” he added. On the other hand, the Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf said Maryam’s CCD could kill anyone anytime in the province with total impunity, establishing a law of the jungle in Pakistan. (PTI)

Artemis II astronauts race to set new distance record from Earth, behold moon’s far side

MARCIA DUNNAP
■ Houston

With the moon looming ever larger, the Artemis II astronauts raced to set a new distance record on Monday from Earth on a lunar fly-around, promising magnificent views of the far side never seen before by the eye.

The six-hour flyby is the highlight of NASA’s first return to the moon since the Apollo era, with three Americans and one Canadian – a step toward landing boot prints near the moon’s south pole in just two years.

Less than an hour before kicking off the fly-around and intense lunar observations, the four astronauts



Earth seen from a window on the Orion spacecraft Integrity during the Artemis II mission

were set to become the most distant humans in history, surpassing the distance record of 248,655 miles (400,171 kilometres) set by Apollo 13 in April 1970.

Mission Control expected Artemis II to surpass that record by more than 4,100 miles (6,600 kilometres).

Artemis II is using the same manoeuvre that Apollo 13 did after its “Houston, we’ve had a problem” oxygen tank explosion wiped out any hope of a moon landing. Known as a free-return lunar trajectory, this no-stopping-to-land route takes advantage of Earth and the moon’s gravity, reducing the need for fuel. It’s a celestial figure-eight

that will put the astronauts on course for home, once they emerge from behind the moon on Monday evening.

Commander Reid Wiseman, pilot Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Canada’s Jeremy Hansen were on track to pass as close as 4,070 miles (6,550 kilometres) to the moon, as their Orion capsule whips past it, hangs a U-turn and then heads back toward Earth. It will take them four days to get back, with a splashdown in the Pacific concluding their test flight on Friday.

Wiseman and his crew spent years studying lunar geography to prepare for the big event, adding solar eclipses to their repertoire

during the past few weeks. By launching last Wednesday, they ensured themselves of a total solar eclipse from their vantage point behind the moon, courtesy of the cosmos.

Topping their science target list: Orientale Basin, a sprawling impact basin with three concentric rings, the outermost of which stretches nearly 600 miles (950 kilometres) across.

Other sightseeing goals: the Apollo 12 and 14 landing sites from 1969 and 1971, respectively, as well as fringes of the south polar region, the preferred locale for future touchdowns. Farther afield, Mercury, Venus, Mars and Saturn — not to mention

Earth — will be visible. Their moon mentor, NASA geologist Kelsey Young, expects thousands of pictures.

“People all over the world connect with the moon. This is something that every single person on this planet can understand and connect with,” she said on the eve of the flyby, wearing eclipse earrings. Artemis II is NASA’s first astronaut moonshot since Apollo 17 in 1972. It sets the stage for next year’s Artemis III, which will see another Orion crew practice docking with lunar landers in orbit around Earth. The culminating moon landing by two astronauts near the moon’s south pole will follow on Artemis IV in 2028. (AP)

PROSPECT



Nagaland BJP President Benjamin Yephthomi joins Foundation Day celebrations at BJP District Office in Mokokchung.

Applied sciences key to energy security: CSIR DG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

Research and applied sciences will be central to advancing sustainable solutions that ensure India's energy security, promote green chemistry for sustainable agriculture, and address broader global sustainability challenges, Dr N Kalaiselvi, Director General of the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), said on Monday at an international conference on sustainability.

Delivering the inaugural address at the International Conference on Sustainability through Fundamental & Applied Sciences (STFAS 2026) hosted by the Hindu College, University of Delhi, Dr Kalaiselvi, the first woman Director General of CSIR emphasised that scientific innovation must move beyond theory and translate into scalable, real-world applications. She also encouraged students to actively pursue research and entrepreneurship, noting that the next generation of scientists and innovators will play a defining role in shaping sustainable development pathways.

The conference was jointly organised by Department of Physics and Chemistry.

TCA Rangachari, Chairman, Hindu College noted that sus-

tainability must be driven by collective action anchored in science, innovation and responsibility, adding that Hindu College's commitment to encouraging such dialogue and nurturing future-ready thinkers is timely and commendable. The 3 day conference is being organised under the aegis of the DBT Star College Scheme from April 6 to 8. Prof Anju Srivastava, Principal of Hindu College highlighted the importance of integrating academic inquiry with societal needs.

The conference features nearly 30 national and international speakers from premier institutions, including IITs, CSIR laboratories, global universities, and industry and it is supported by organisation including Indian Railway Finance Corporation, Ultra International Limited, SBI, Canara Bank, and GreyMatters Communications among others.

Highlighting role of industry collaboration, Sant Sanganeria, Founder Chairman & CEO of Ultra International Limited, said, "The future of sustainability lies in seamless integration of science and industry. Conferences like STFAS provide critical platform to align research with market needs and accelerate adoption of innovative, sustainable solutions across sectors."

Rethinking healthcare through lens of sustainability



DR SUBHASH KAUSHIK

As the world marks World Homoeopathy Day 2026, commemorating the birth anniversary of Samuel Hahnemann, the moment invites a deeper reflection-not just on the legacy of a system of medicine, but on the future of healthcare itself. Across the globe, health systems are confronting a complex set of challenges: a rising burden of chronic diseases, growing antimicrobial resistance, escalating treatment costs, and increasing demand for patient-centred care. Together, these pressures are driving a critical shift-from episodic treatment models to approaches that are continuous, preventive, and sustainable.

In this evolving landscape, Homoeopathy offers a perspective that is both relevant and timely. Founded on the principle of "like cures like," it has evolved from an 18th-century therapeutic idea into a widely practiced and increasingly evidence-driven

system. Its emphasis on individualised treatment, minimal adverse effects, and long-term engagement aligns closely with the direction in which global healthcare is moving-towards models that prioritise the patient, not just the disease.

At the forefront of advancing this scientific foundation in India is the Central Council for Research in Homoeopathy (CCRH). Since its establishment in 1978, the Council has played a pivotal role in strengthening research, standardisation, and evidence generation in Homoeopathy. Its work reflects a clear objective: to ensure that the system is not only rooted in tradition but also validated through contemporary scientific methods.

This year's theme- Homoeopathy for Sustainable Health-captures a growing global imperative. Sustainable health goes beyond clinical outcomes; it encompasses economic viability, environmental responsibility, and social inclusiveness. In this context, Homoeopathy presents distinct advantages. Its therapeutic approach seeks to stimulate the body's innate

healing capacity, its medicines require minimal raw materials and generate negligible waste, and its cost-effectiveness makes it particularly suited for large-scale public health interventions. As health systems worldwide search for solutions that balance efficacy with sustainability, such attributes assume increasing importance.

The role of scientific evidence in this transition cannot be overstated. Over the years, CCRH has undertaken extensive clinical research across a range of disease conditions, including studies designed with rigorous methodologies such as randomized controlled trials. Importantly, this evidence is being translated into practice through standard treatment guidelines, disease monographs, and peer-reviewed publications, enabling practitioners to adopt more structured and evidence-based approaches.

Beyond clinical research, efforts to strengthen the core scientific framework of Homoeopathy have also gathered momentum. Programmes in drug proving and clinical verification have

systematically expanded and validated the therapeutic profiles of medicines, while initiatives in drug standardisation have contributed significantly to ensuring quality, safety, and consistency. These foundational efforts are essential in reinforcing both practitioner confidence and public trust.

Collaboration has further accelerated this progress. Partnerships with institutions such as the All India Institute of Medical Sciences and the Indian Council of Medical Research, along with universities and research centres, have broadened the scope of inquiry and strengthened methodological rigour. Such interdisciplinary engagement is critical in positioning Homoeopathy within the larger scientific ecosystem.

At the same time, the relevance of Homoeopathy is becoming evident in addressing some of today's most pressing public health concerns. Antimicrobial resistance, for instance, has emerged as a global crisis requiring innovative and multi-pronged responses. Research initiatives exploring the role of Homoeopathy in reducing antibiotic depen-

dency-across human and veterinary domains-reflect a forward-looking approach aligned with national and global priorities.

The experience of recent public health emergencies has also underscored the need for adaptable and community-oriented healthcare systems. During the COVID-19 pandemic, Homoeopathy was deployed in preventive and supportive roles across various settings, supported by research studies and large-scale outreach initiatives. These efforts highlighted its potential as a complementary system within broader public health strategies.

Equally important is the system's ability to operate at scale while retaining its individualised approach to treatment. Through community-based programmes and outreach initiatives, Homoeopathy has reached large populations, delivering accessible and affordable care without compromising on its patient-centric philosophy. This balance between scale and personalisation is particularly relevant in diverse and resource-constrained settings.

Looking ahead, the future

of healthcare will be shaped by how effectively systems can integrate evidence, sustainability, and patient-centredness. In this context, Homoeopathy-supported by institutions like CCRH-has the potential to contribute meaningfully to more inclusive and resilient healthcare models. However, this will require continued investment in research, stronger interdisciplinary collaborations, and sustained efforts to communicate evidence with clarity and credibility.

World Homoeopathy Day, therefore, is not merely a commemoration. It is an opportunity to reaffirm a broader vision of healthcare-one that is not only scientifically grounded, but also sustainable, equitable, and responsive to the needs of the future. The journey from Hahnemann's foundational insights to today's research-driven advancements reflects both continuity and evolution. The task now is to carry this momentum forward-towards a healthcare paradigm that serves both people and the planet.

The writer is Director General, Central Council for Research in Homoeopathy (CCRH)

Pune student shines in crossword championship's practice round

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Patna

Sahil Sandeep Sabne of Suryadatta National School, Pune, is the national topper of the Practice Round of the 14th edition of the inter-school CCCC Cryptic Crossword Contest, popular as CCCC among students across India. Sabne played solo. The team of Anjali Nanduri and Aradhya Ranjith from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan's Public School (Vidyashram), Hyderabad, was runner-up. They were followed by Dhairya Pandey, another solo player, from Don Bosco Academy, Patna, in the third place in the national ranking.

Nanya Dev Singh of DPS

Patna, who played solo, is the state topper from Bihar. While the team of Ramya Bindal and Aryan Sejwal from The Mother's International School was the Delhi topper, that of Tanvi Uddaraja and Aanya Srivastava from Vidyashram, Hyderabad, was the Telangana topper.

Other notable state toppers are Avani Fiske and Mudraa Paidarkar from SES Gurukul (Maharashtra); Tanishka Sumbly from Heritage School Jammu (J&K); and Shreyan Sharma from DPS Ludhiana (Punjab).

Asolo participant, Sourya Srivastava from Cinderella English School is the city topper from Darbhanga. While the team of Yubraj

Anand and Saksham Singh from Mount Assisi School is the Bhagalpur topper, the one-member team of Shivam Kumar Jha from SDDNG Government High School is the topper from Araria.

Mayank Besra and Bishnu Murmu, playing as team for EMRS AASTA, Jhajha, have topped the Jamui merit list. Girl students too are giving their boy counterparts a run for their money. While Anchal Kumari and Rekha Kumari of Dr BR Ambedkar Residential Girls' School, Sadar, have topped the Ara (Bhojpur) list, Anandi Kumari and Riya Kumari of Government SC Residential Girls' High School are the top team from Lakhisarai.

LPG crisis sparks debate on ethanol as alternative cooking fuel in India



RAJNEESH TYAGI

India's ongoing Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) crisis has exposed the vulnerability of the country's cooking fuel supply chain, prompting renewed calls for diversification and a stronger push toward domestic alternatives such as ethanol. The disruption stems largely from geopolitical tensions in West Asia, particularly the conflict involving Iran, which has slowed shipments passing through the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz. The narrow maritime corridor handles a major share of India's LPG imports from Gulf nations, and delays there have triggered shortages and price increases across the country.

Supply Disruptions Hit Households and Businesses

India consumes roughly 31-32 million tonnes of LPG annually, with about 87 percent used in domestic kitchens. However, the country imports 60-65 percent of its LPG, primarily from Saudi Arabia, Qatar, the United Arab Emirates and Kuwait. Most of these supplies transit the Strait of Hormuz, making India highly exposed to disruptions in the region.

Government Moves to Stabilize Supplies

In response, the government has taken several measures to stabilize the situation.

Authorities have invoked the Essential Commodities Act to curb black-marketing and hoarding. Refineries have been directed to increase LPG production by diverting propane and butane streams, raising domestic output by an estimated 25-30 percent.

The government has also prioritized household consumption over commercial and industrial use while urging consumers to avoid panic buying. Where available, households and businesses are being encouraged to shift to piped natural gas (PNG).

Meanwhile, India has moved to secure alternative imports from countries including the United States, Russia, Norway and Canada, with some cargo shipments already en route.

Officials say domestic stocks remain sufficient and households are unlikely to face complete supply outages. However, analysts say the situation highlights long-standing structural weaknesses in India's LPG ecosystem-namely heavy import dependence, limited strategic storage and exposure to global geopolitical shocks.

Ethanol Emerges as Potential Alternative

Amid the crisis, energy experts and policymakers are revisiting the possibility of ethanol as a domestic cooking fuel.

I have first-hand experience with the use of ethanol as a cooking fuel in Ethiopia in 2015, where our team successfully designed and implemented a small-scale ethanol production facility with a capacity of 1,000



SINCE EARLY MARCH 2026, THE CRISIS HAS LED TO SEVERAL VISIBLE EFFECTS:

- ❑ Long queues at LPG distributors in major cities including Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Kolkata and Prayagraj.
- ❑ Panic bookings and hoarding, worsening supply pressures.
- ❑ Price increases, with domestic 14.2-kg cylinders rising by about ₹60 to roughly ₹913-₹928 in major cities.
- ❑ Commercial cylinder hikes, with 19-kg cylinders increasing by about ₹114-₹115.
- ❑ Severe strain on the hospitality sector, as hotels and restaurants scale back menus, shift to alternative fuels such as firewood, or temporarily suspend operations.

KEY ADVANTAGES CITED INCLUDE:

- ❑ Domestic availability: Ethanol is produced locally from agricultural feedstocks, reducing reliance on imported fossil fuels. Experts say diverting 200-250 crore litres could support millions of households without significantly affecting fuel blending programmes.
- ❑ Lower processing requirements: Cooking applications can use 90-95 percent hydrous ethanol, which is cheaper and easier to produce than the high-purity ethanol required for transport fuels.
- ❑ Cleaner combustion: Ethanol cookstoves produce a blue flame with significantly fewer emissions than biomass fuels such as wood or dung, helping reduce indoor air pollution- an issue that disproportionately affects women and children in rural areas.
- ❑ Existing infrastructure: India already has a large network of distilleries, storage facilities and transport systems used for ethanol distribution to fuel stations, which could be adapted for household fuel supply.

EXPERTS SUGGEST SEVERAL POLICY STEPS TO ACCELERATE ADOPTION:

- ❑ Recognising bioethanol as an approved cooking fuel under the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY).
- ❑ Launching pilot programmes in rural and biomass-dependent regions.
- ❑ Encouraging industry partnerships to develop affordable and safe stove designs, drawing lessons from pilot projects in Africa and Latin America.

litres per day to support rural households. The initiative was carried out with support from the World Bank and the Stockholm Environment Institute, in collaboration with Project GAIA. The project aimed to provide a clean and sustainable cooking fuel while reducing the burden on women who were traditionally responsible for collecting firewood for household energy needs.

India already produces more than 1,800 crore litres of ethanol annually, largely from sugarcane and grain-based feedstocks. The government's Ethanol Blended Petrol programme has rapidly expanded, achieving close to 20 percent blending in petrol, ahead of earlier targets.

Advocates argue that ethanol could play a complementary role in the household cooking sector.

Energy economists say expanding ethanol use in kitchens could reduce LPG import dependence, lower

subsidy burdens and cut emissions, while also supporting farmers through increased demand for agricultural feedstocks.

Policy and Infrastructure Challenges

Despite its potential, ethanol-based cooking faces several challenges. These include the cost and availability of cookstoves, distribution systems, safety standards and consumer awareness.

A Wake-Up Call for Energy Security

Energy analysts describe the current LPG disruption as a warning about the risks of relying heavily on imported fuels for essential household needs.

While short-term steps such as boosting domestic output and securing alternative imports may stabilize the market, experts say long-term resilience will require a broader mix of cooking energy sources. With existing production capacity and infrastructure already in place, ethanol could emerge as one of the key alternatives in India's energy transition- potentially powering not just vehicles, but kitchens as well.

As policymakers search for solutions to the present crisis, the debate over ethanol cookstoves is gaining momentum, raising the possibility that India's next cooking fuel revolution could be homegrown.

Rajneesh Tyagi is a Saskatoon, Saskatchewan-based Indo-Canadian entrepreneur, executive, and innovator, with a focus on bioenergy, biofuels, and sustainability.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

SOLUTION (06.04.26)

5	3	9	7	2	6	1	4	8
8	1	4	5	3	9	2	6	7
7	6	2	8	1	4	9	5	3
4	7	5	6	8	2	3	9	1
9	2	3	4	7	1	5	8	6
6	8	1	9	5	3	4	7	2
2	9	6	1	4	7	8	3	5
3	4	8	2	6	5	7	1	9
1	5	7	3	9	8	6	2	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | APRIL 7, 2026

ACROSS

1 Could start to whip in a fight (5)
6 Poetry of the silver sea (5)
9 Hesitated to make a friendly gesture to a leftist (7)
10 Being nice means very little, in a way (5)
11 Checks a broken siren (5)
12 A rule that breaks the heart of singers (5)
13 Lazes around, that is, with sticky sweets (7)
15 Play for today, outwardly? (3)
17 Top numbers, each unique (4)
18 Wild moors, right on the map, dark and gloomy (6)
19 Open up possibilities for Edwin (5)

DOWN

2 As chancellor, Nigel made rules in advance (6)
3 Toffs properly included among saints? (6)
4 Derby, perhaps (3)
5 Special occasions that help to make life testing (5)
6 Come close to being governed no end badly? (5,2)
7 Heavenly place, a noted haunt (4)
8 Emergency message about a theatre where Pele played (6)
12 Right to issue pay (5)
13 In Ireland, a clumsy fellow, hot-headed (5)

20 Sort of shirt for a slave, that's all (3,3)
22 Easily handled, thanks to me (4)
24 She's less than motherly (3)
25 Incite riot about a Zionist leader named Kane (7)
26 Go round upsetting some strikers (5)
27 It's goodbye to Dai, maybe, who's so backward (5)
28 During the day, left a trainee to be idle (5)
29 Might he rush ahead with an operation? (7)
30 Look exhausted and fall out of the ring (5)
31 He's in textiles (5)

14 Bar the clever bit (5)
15 Stone is best - start to finish! (5)
16 The old-fashioned fellows abroad (5)
18 The "Order of ---" could be "12 Down" (5)
19 Agitates to make artistic creations more lofty (5,2)
21 Perhaps a capital attempt at scoring (6)
22 In teas one may find an exotic infusion (6)
23 Fruit served in medium large portions (6)
25 Rocky locations good to manoeuvre cars round (5)
26 Thus again is only fair (2-2)
28 Little Miss Morse? (3)

SOLUTION (06.04.26)

ACROSS

9, I'm-patient
10, Touching
12, Go-a-i (rev)
13, P-i-rate
14, Tarnish
15, L-end a h
17, Monstrous
18, Realise
20, St-rod-e
21, Hole
24, Much less

26, Re-place-d
28, Tier
29, Scored
31, Midland
34, Unsettled
36, By degrees
38, Car-case
39, Choice
40, O-TT-O
41, Vert-i-c-al
42, Ciner-aria

DOWN

1, Singular
2, Spral-N
3, M-edit-ate
4, Strand
5, St-re-amer
6, But-toned up
7, Char-it-y
8, I-ndigo
11, C-hasten
16, Alight
19, A-muse

20, SOS (rev)
22, O-me-ga
23, L-apt-og
25, Excellency
26, Rod
27, Staunch
30, Rid-i-cule
31, M-edicin-e
32, Dis-lo-yal
33, Stra-i-ts
35, Served
36, Broach

BRIEFLY

India wins bronze at Wheelchair Rugby Asian Championship



New Delhi: India secured its first-ever international medal in wheelchair rugby, clinching bronze at the Wheelchair Rugby Asian Regional Championship 2026 in Bali, Indonesia. Competing without government funding or sponsorship, the team of eight athletes personally raised funds, with each contributing around \$1,250 to purchase specialised rugby wheelchairs. Led by Captain Nikhil Gupta, the squad—including Anil Kumar, Ajeet, Bhavesh Trivedi, Dhawal Patel, Fayaz Sheikh, and Gokulakannan—showcased remarkable resilience under Coach Devid Kumar. Despite challenges like intense heat, injuries to four players, and equipment shortages, India's performance was outstanding. A sporting gesture by the Indonesian team, which shared spare wheelchairs, enabled their participation. The Wheelchair Rugby Federation of India has now organised seven national championships. The team is now targeting the Para Asian Games in Japan and urgently needs institutional support for equipment and training.

St Pauli hold on for a point against Union Berlin



Berlin: More goalkeeping heroics from Bosnia-Herzegovina's World Cup qualification star Nikola Vasilj meant St Pauli held on for a 1-1 draw with Union Berlin on Sunday as it struggles to avoid relegation from the Bundesliga. In his first game since his saves helped see the Bosnian team past Italy in the World Cup qualifying playoffs, Vasilj faced eight shots on target and stood out with a double save, though it came after he'd given the ball away. The only one that went in was a towering header from Union striker Andrej Ilic at a corner. St Pauli had earlier taken the lead when Mathias Pereira Lage delivered a fierce long-distance volley to open the scoring, and created little after that. St Pauli held on for the final three minutes with 10 men after its Australian captain Jackson Irvine was sent off for two yellow cards in the space of eight minutes, both for late tackles. Even a point for St Pauli was bad news for Wolfsburg, which is on course for an historic first relegation from the Bundesliga after losing 6-3 to Bayer Leverkusen on Saturday. A fixture in the Bundesliga since 1997, Wolfsburg is now four points adrift of any chance of safety. The bottom two teams, Wolfsburg and Heidenheim, are relegated directly to the second division. The team in 16th, currently St Pauli, goes into a two-leg playoff against the third-place team from the second tier. Union stays 10th. Cologne is 15th and faces Eintracht Frankfurt later Sunday.

Sindhu, Lakshya shine at Asia Championships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ningbo (China)

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty have withdrawn from the Badminton Asia Championships due to the former's shoulder injury, even as in-form Lakshya Sen and seasoned PV Sindhu gear up to spearhead India's challenge with an aim to end a long wait for a singles title in the continental showpiece. Satwik and Chirag, who had won the title in 2023, opted out as the former continues to recover. "Satwik still has some pain, so they won't be playing this week," coach Tan Kim Her told PTI. The duo had earlier pulled out of the Swiss Open ahead

of their quarterfinal match due to a recurring right shoulder injury to Satwik. India will now rely on Lakshya and Sindhu in singles, with both looking to end the country's 61-year wait for a title in the discipline. Former national champion Dinesh Khanna remains the only Indian to win the men's singles gold at the continental meet in 1965, and Lakshya will be keen to follow in his footsteps after a runner-up finish at the All England Championships. The 24-year-old from Almora will open his campaign against Hong Kong's Lee Cheuk Yiu. Sindhu, meanwhile, returns after a disrupted European leg.



The two-time Olympic medalist was stranded in Dubai en route to the All England Championships due to the conflict in West Asia, forcing her withdrawal. She subsequently skipped the Swiss Open to recover and will

Singapore's eighth seed Loh Kean Yew. US Open champion Ayush Shetty faces China's fifth seed Li Shi Feng. In women's singles, apart from Sindhu, Unnati Hooda meets Thailand's Supanida Katethong. Tanvi Sharma takes on Malaysia's K Letshanaa, and Malvika Bansod faces Thailand's Busanan Ongbamrungphan. In men's doubles, Hariharan Amsakarunan and M R Arjun, who won back-to-back titles at the 2025 AI Ain Masters Super 100 and the 2025 Turkiye International Challenge, face top seeds Kim Won Ho and Seo Seung Jae of South Korea. P Krishnamurthy Roy and Sai Pratheek K take on Japan's

Kakeru Kumagai and Hiroki Nishi. In women's doubles, Ashwini Bhat K and Shikha Gautam face Thailand's Hathaitip Mijad and N. Tungkasatan, while Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand Pullela meet China's Luo Yi and Wang Ting Ge. Priya Konjengbam and Shruti Mishra await a qualifier. In mixed doubles, Rohan Kapoor and Gaddie Ruthvika Shivani face Malaysia's eighth seeds Goh Soon Huat and Lai Shevon Jemie, Ashith Surya and Amrutha Pramuthesh meet another Malaysian pair Wong Tien Ci and Lim Chiew Sien, while Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto take on Thailand's P.Horbanluekit and Benyapa Aimsaard.

Praggnanandhaa draws with Caruana

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Paphos (Cyprus)

R Praggnanandhaa remained in search of his second win after drawing with pre-event favourite Fabiano Caruana, while his sister R Vaishali scored a fortunate victory over China's Tan Zhongyi in the seventh round of the Candidates tournaments here. At the half way stage, Pragg remains on a fifty percent score and will need a miracle in the final seven games in order to come into contention. Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan was poised to make a draw with Anish Giri of Holland. The Uzbek youngster had scored four victories in a row and what could be another draw-marred day,



not much changed in terms of standings. Sindarov, on six points, is firmly ahead of Caruana on 4.5, a full point ahead of Praggnanandhaa and likely Anish Giri. Matthias Bluebaum of Germany and Wei Yi of China are now on 3 points each, a half point ahead of Hikaru Nakamura of United States. Andrey Esipenko of Russia

is languishing at the bottom with two points in his kitty. In the women's section, Anna Muzychuk of Ukraine continued to lead the tables on 4.5 points following a draw with Bibisara Assaubayeva of Kazakhstan. R Vaishali stands on 4 points and is in second spot, while Bibisara is now in third spot. Divya Deshmukh enjoyed a handy advantage against

Kateryna Lagno of Russia and will join Vaishali if she wins. In another game Alexandra Goryachkina of Russia was also fighting it out against Jiner Zhu of China. Results round 7: R Praggnanandhaa (Ind, 3.5) drew with Fabiano Caruana (Usa, 4.5); Andrey Esipenko (Rus, 2) lost to Wei Yi (Chn, 3); Matthias Bluebaum (Ger, 3) drew with Hikaru Nakamura (Usa, 2.5); Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb, 5.5) playing Anish Giri (Ned, 3). Women: Divya Deshmukh (3) playing Kateryna Lagno (Rus, 3); Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz, 3) drew with Anna Muzychuk (Ukr, 4.5); R Vaishali (Ind, 4) beat Zhongyi Tan (Chn, 2.5) Jiner Zhu (Chn, 3) playing Aleksandra Goryachkina (Rus, 3). PTI Cor ATK

Getafe's sixth win in 8 matches boosts European hopes

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Getafe boosted its chances of playing in Europe next season after beating Athletic Bilbao 2-0 at home on Sunday for its sixth win in its last eight Spanish league matches. Luis Vazquez scored in the 14th minute and Martin Satriano sealed the victory in the 90th to keep Getafe in eighth place with 41 points, level with seventh-placed Real Sociedad and three points ahead of ninth-placed Espanyol. Under one scenario, Spain could end up with as many as 10 places in European competitions next season, depending on how Spanish teams finish this season in Europe. Getafe's only setbacks recently were 1-0 losses to Sevilla at home and to Atletico Madrid away. Athletic, meanwhile, has lost four of its last five games in all competitions and has only one victory — 2-1 against



Real Betis in the league before the international break - in its last six games. One of its losses came in the second leg of the Copa del Rey semifinal against Basque Country rival Real Sociedad last month. Athletic dropped to 10th. Celta winsCelta came from behind to beat Valencia 3-2 on the road. The victory ended Celta's three-game winless streak in the league

and left the club in sixth place. The top four are guaranteed Champions League spots with the fifth team also set to qualify. Betis, currently sitting fifth, drew 0-0 with Espanyol at home on Saturday. Ilaix Moriba, Fer Lopez and Williot Swedberg scored for Celta in the second half after Guido Rodriguez had put the hosts ahead in the 12th minute. Rodriguez scored Valencia's second goal in second-half stoppage time.

Arsenal stunned by 2nd-tier Southampton

STEVE DOUGLAS ■ London

Second-tier Southampton caused a huge shock by beating Premier League leader Arsenal in the FA Cup quarterfinals after Manchester City dispatched Liverpool 4-0 thanks to a hat trick by Erling Haaland. Fresh off losing the English League Cup final to City before the international break, Arsenal saw another potential trophy slip from its grasp when conceding in the 85th minute to lose 2-1 at Southampton — a team in seventh place in the Championship. It left City as the big favorite to clinch a cup double this season, with the thrashing of Liverpool securing a place in the FA Cup semifinals for a

record eighth straight season. Mohamed Salah's failure from the penalty spot added to the woes of Liverpool, whose meltdown at Etihad Stadium will put more heat on under-pressure manager Arne Slot. Chelsea also advanced, routing third-tier Port Vale 7-0. The semifinal line-up will be completed Sunday when West Ham hosts Leeds, after which the last-four draw will be made. **Arsenal cup hopes disappearing:** So much for Arsenal's hopes of a quadruple of major trophies this season. It's now just the Premier League and Champions League up for grabs with manager Mikel Arteta's decision to field a weakened lineup backfiring at St.



Mary's stadium. Trailing to a 35th-minute strike by Ross Stewart, Arsenal sent on Viktor Gyokeres — fresh off scoring the goal that lifted Sweden into the World Cup

on Tuesday — and the striker equalised in the 68th. Still, Southampton continued to look dangerous on the counterattack and Shea Charles, a former academy

product at Man City, fired home from inside the area to secure a famous win. "To go and beat arguably the best team in Europe at the minute is an incredible feeling," Stewart said. In an added blow to Arsenal ahead of its upcoming Champions League quarterfinal against Sporting Lisbon, Brazil center back Gabriel Magalhaes was forced off with a left knee injury midway through the second half. He was seen later with ice on the knee. "This is the first moment that we have (this season) with a certain level of difficulty," said Arteta, whose team has a nine-point lead in the Premier League. (AP)

Monaco beats Marseille 2-1

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

Monaco picked up where it had left off before the international break, beating southern rival Marseille 2-1 in the French league as US striker Folarin Balogun scored a superb goal to strengthen host Monaco's push for a Champions League spot. The Principality side won a seventh straight Ligue 1 game on Sunday and increased its unbeaten run to 10 league matches. The win lifted Monaco level on points with fourth-placed Marseille and just one point behind third-placed Lille. Balogun, who has scored eight goals in his last eight games for Monaco in all



competitions, made it 2-0 in the 74th minute when he finished a move sparked by goalkeeper Lukas Hradecky's clearance. The American then dribbled into the box and chipped a subtle lob into the far corner. Aleksandr Golovin had put Monaco in front near the hour mark. Amine Gouiri pulled one back for

Marseille in the 85th minute. The visitors, who played without the suspended Mason Greenwood, pushed hard for an equaliser in the closing stages but Hradecky denied an attempt from Facundo Medina with a fine reflex save and Jordan Teze cleared an effort from Pierre-Emerick Aubameyang off the line.

Lautaro Martinez's brace helps Inter rout Roma 5-2 to get Serie A title

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Milan

Lautaro Martinez is back from injury, and Inter Milan is back looking like the Serie A leader again. Lautaro scored twice in his first action since February and Inter routed visiting Roma 5-2 on Sunday to end a four-match winless streak across all competitions. Lautaro scored in the second and 52nd minutes at the San Siro. Hakan Calhanoglu — fresh off helping Turkey qualify for the World Cup — Marcus Thuram and Nicolo Barella also found the net for Inter.



Gianluca Mancini, along with Barella a member of the Italy team that failed to qualify for the World Cup,

scored a momentary equalizer for Roma. Then Lorenzo Pellegrini pulled one back for Roma after the Giallorossi had gone four goals behind. Inter, which had its advantage sliced from 10 to six points before the international break, moved nine points ahead of city rival AC Milan and 10 ahead of defending champion Napoli, which hosts Milan on Monday. **Bologna prepares for Aston Villa:** Earlier, Bologna won 2-1 at relegation-threatened Cremonese to move up to eighth before hosting Aston Villa in the Europa League quarterfinals on Thursday.

Sevilla slips closer to relegation after 3rd straight loss

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

New coach, same struggle for Sevilla. Sevilla lost 1-0 at last-placed Oviedo on Sunday to stay just two points above the relegation zone in the Spanish league. It dropped to 17th with the loss which saw the debut of coach Luis Garcia Plaza, who replaced Argentine coach Matias Almeyda before the international break. It was the third straight defeat for Sevilla, and its eighth match without a win in nine league rounds. The club was in 15th place when Almeyda was fired. Federico Vinas scored in the 32nd minute for Oviedo,

which has won two of its last three league matches to keep alive its hopes of not returning to the second division. Oviedo has 24 points, seven points behind Sevilla. Sevilla played a man down from the 39th as defender Tanguy Nianzou was sent off with a straight red card for a hard foul. "We didn't expect to play with 10 men for so long. That made a difference," Plaza said. "We are running out of time. We need to start winning points again." Sevilla, which had no attempts on target, hosts Atletico Madrid next weekend. **Boost for Getafe:** Getafe boosted its chances of



playing in Europe next season after beating Athletic Bilbao 2-0 at home for its sixth win in its last eight league matches. Luis Vazquez scored in the 14th and Martin Satriano

sealed the victory in the 90th to keep Getafe in eighth place with 41 points, level with seventh-placed Real Sociedad and three points ahead of ninth-placed Osasuna.

Under one scenario, Spain could end up with as many as 10 places in European competitions next season, depending on how Spanish teams finish this season in Europe. Getafe's only setbacks recently were 1-0 losses to Sevilla at home and to Atletico Madrid away. Athletic, meanwhile, has lost four of its last five games in all competitions and has only one victory — 2-1 against Real Betis in the league before the international break — in its last six games. One of its losses came in the second leg of the Copa del Rey semifinal against Basque Country rival Real Sociedad last month.

Rain forces abandonment of KKR's match against PBKS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders and Punjab Kings shared a point apiece after their Indian Premier League match was called off due to incessant rain and the subsequent wet outfield here on Monday.

The home side's skipper Ajinkya Rahane won the toss and opted to bat, but his team suffered an early setback in just the second over as Australian pacer Xavier Bartlett dismissed opener Finn Allen (6) and Cameron Green (4), leaving KKR struggling at 16 for two.

Rahane (8 not out) and wicketkeeper-batter Angkrish Raghuvanshi (7 not out) were attempting to sta-

bilise the innings when rain halted the play at 25 for two after just 3.4 overs. With the match eventually abandoned, KKR secured their first point after back-to-back losses. With Eden Gardens equipped with full ground covers, the ground staff sprang into action, swiftly covering the entire field.

There was a brief relent when the covers began to come off, but rain returned with thunderstorm and lightning, leaving spectators frustrated as they started leaving.

The match also witnessed a relatively sparse turnout, with 29,358 spectators in attendance possibly due to a Monday fixture and over-cast conditions. All this

unfolded in front of Bollywood superstar and KKR co-owner Shah Rukh Khan, who made his first appearance of the season, only to witness a rain-hit evening.

Incidentally, last season's KKR-PBKS fixture at the Eden (April 26) was also affected by rain, with both teams forced to share a point.

The Shreyas Iyer-led Punjab Kings had posted 201 for 4 before KKR reached 7 for no loss when rain intervened.

An inspection was held at 8.45 pm, but with further showers accompanied by gusty Kalbaisakhi (Nor'wester) winds, the outlook remained grim.

Overs begin to be reduced



Ground staff cover the ground during rain interruption in an IPL 2026 cricket match between Kolkata Knight Riders and Punjab Kings at Eden Gardens in Kolkata on Monday

after a delay of one hour, with roughly one over per side lost for every four to five minutes thereafter. The cut-off time to start a five-overs-a-side match — the minimum required for a result — is 10.56pm.

However, with rain expected to intensify as per forecasts, a result appeared unlikely. A washout, though, would help KKR open their account with one point after a winless start.

According to the IMD, the rain has been triggered by a low-pressure trough stretching from Bihar to Manipur, passing over North Bengal, Assam and Bangladesh, leading to moisture incursion from the Bay of Bengal.

"Thunderstorms with

lightning and rain may occur in most districts of South Bengal. From Sunday to Thursday, scattered rainfall is likely across the state, with higher intensity on Tuesday and Wednesday," the IMD said.

Weather conditions are expected to worsen on Tuesday, with Kalbaisakhi storms likely to bring winds of 50-60 kmph, along with lightning and heavy rain in Kolkata and adjoining areas.

KKR have a third home match in a row facing Lucknow Super Giants on Thursday but that too has some rain forecast.

Brief scores: Kolkata Knight Riders 25 for 2 in 3.4 overs (Xavier Bartlett 2/9). Match abandoned.



DK has helped me prepare for these conditions: Tim David

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Pleased as punch after his game-turning 25-ball 70, RCB's Australian big-hitter Tim David attributed his superb performance against CSK to the inputs provided by his team's batting coach Dinesh Karthik which helped him prepare for these conditions.

David, whom his skipper Rajat Patidar termed as the "best finisher he has ever seen", hit eight sixes apart from three boundaries as RCB piled 250 for 3 and then bowled out CSK for 207.

"I do not change my game much, but I have confidence from all the preparation that I do. It is nice to work with DK (Dinesh Karthik's fraternity name), he is an experienced player in these conditions. I have been in the IPL for a few years and with that kind of preparation, you don't put pressure on yourself to perform," David said at the post match presentation.

He certainly was happy as this kind of performance do not happen every day.

"Very pleased — it does not always happen that way.

The skipper (Rajat Patidar, who scored 48 off 19 balls) was smoking it. And I just took some balls off him — it was super fun. Going in to bat with Jitesh (Sharma) and (Romario) Shepherd behind me really gives me confidence," he said.

Lavishing praise on him, skipper Patidar said: "He (David) is a specialist, and one of the best finishers. He is consistent and one of the best finishers I have ever seen." The skipper also had special mention for senior player Krunal Pandya, who dismissed Sarfaraz Khan and Kartik Sharma in one over.

"Whenever I come under pressure, I look to KP (Krunal Pandya) and I have that much belief in him."

A distraught CSK skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad didn't have much explanation to offer after a third straight defeat.

"If I would have contributed more, maybe it could have been different. It (the loss) was definitely on me today," he said.

"We still had the game in our hands till the 13-14th over (of the bowling innings but let momentum slip after it."

Mumbai Indians seek reset against rampaging Rajasthan Royals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Mumbai Indians will hope that skipper Hardik Pandya regains full fitness when they square off against a confident Rajasthan Royals unit, which will be keen to extend its early-season momentum in their IPL clash on Tuesday.

Pandya, a key figure in the side, missed MI's previous outing due to illness, and his absence proved crucial in their six-wicket defeat to Delhi Capitals on Saturday.

While India T20I skipper Suryakumar Yadav stepped in to lead and ensured continuity, MI missed Pandya's all-round abilities on a tacky surface. His absence also

forced a rejig in the combination. Deepak Chahar, drafted in for the game, delivered a tidy spell, but the decision to bring in pace all-rounder Corbin Bosch in place of seasoned left-arm pacer Trent Boult backfired, with the South African leaking runs.

Pandya has since travelled with the squad and returned to the nets, offering hope of a comeback as MI look to recalibrate their approach after the loss.

Shardul Thakur, who starred with the ball in their opening game, was expensive in the last outing, while the ever-reliable Jasprit Bumrah has been economical but is yet to open his account this season.



In the spin department, Mitchell Santner justified his selection ahead of Afghan mystery spinner Allah Ghazanfar and is likely to retain his place. The MI bowlers, however, will need to raise their game against a

Rajasthan top order that has been in excellent form so far. Openers Yashasvi Jaiswal and teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi have provided explosive starts, with Dhruv Jurel then building on the momentum.

New skipper Riyan Parag is yet to make a significant contribution with the bat but will take confidence from his leadership, particularly his tactical decisions at the death that guided the Royals to a thrilling win over Gujarat Titans.

Among the bowlers, Tushar Deshpande and Ravi Bishnoi have been impressive.

Bishnoi has emerged as the joint leading wicket-

taker with five scalps from two matches, marking a strong turnaround after a challenging 2025 season following which he worked on multiple aspects of his game.

Deshpande, meanwhile, showcased his death-bowling skills by successfully defending 10 runs in the final over against the Titans, conceding just four with a series of pinpoint yorkers.

With Mumbai, currently sixth on the points table, seeking to bounce back and second placed Rajasthan riding a wave of confidence, the contest's result could hinge on how effectively MI's bowlers handle the Royals' in-form top order.

It was mentally disturbing, painful: R Ashwin on why he quit IPL

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Former India off-spinner R Ashwin has revealed that he could have played the IPL a bit longer had it not been for a "mentally disturbing" and "painful" phase that he went through during his time with the Chennai Super Kings.

On his youtube show 'Ash Ki Baat', the veteran, who retired from international cricket in 2024 before ending his IPL run last year, said he decided to call it quits to save the franchise the dilemma of deciding his fate..

"...I recently spent a dis-



appointing season with CSK, it was a disappointing season for me personally. Honestly, in my mind, I could have played more, but I quit because emotionally, I just did not have

the bandwidth to play while managing everything else," Ashwin said.

Ashwin, before announcing his IPL retirement, had sought clarity from CSK about his role after being

used sparingly during the 2025 season. He appeared in only nine of CSK's 14 matches in what was to be his homecoming after starting his IPL journey with the same team..

The franchise, that was in the bottom heap last season, is continuing to struggle and has already logged three back-to-back losses under Ruturaj Gaikwad.

"I don't want to go there, it's mentally disturbing. It was very painful for me. I don't want to go there. I discussed a little, then I said, I started in Chennai, I am finishing in my hometown, it's fine.



It wasn't easy to change my batting's foundation: Padikkal

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Royal Challengers Bengaluru batter Devdutt Padikkal attributed his growing confidence in white ball formats to the willingness to move out of his comfort zone and "change the foundation" of his batting.

Devidutt followed his 61 against Sunrisers Hyderabad in the opening game with a 50 against Chennai Super Kings here on Sunday to fuel RCB's batting charge, which culminated in a 43-run win.

"It's just a lot of hard work and a lot of self-belief that's helped me get there. It wasn't easy to make that change because it was something that I had to change from the foundation that I had in terms of the type of cricket I wanted to play growing up," Devdutt said in the post-match press conference on Sunday night.

"The change is something that I had to make consciously and RCB and the whole

support staff have been really great in guiding me in the right way," he added.

But is there a danger of T20s becoming unidimensional because all the batters are looking to improve their range-hitting skills?

"I don't think so because it's just that the batting in this tournament that has gone up another level. I think everyone is working so hard to hit those big sixes and fours and it's now the bowler's job to really follow that and try to take their game up a level as well and I think we are gonna get there."

The left-hander reckons bowlers will make a comeback sooner rather than later from the early rounds of shellacking.

"I'm very confident that all the bowlers will show up as well and as the tournament goes on the wickets will also start to slow down a little bit and those things will change and that's that's how it goes." (PTI)

Sanju Samson is desperate for runs: Stephen Fleming

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Head coach Stephen Fleming downplayed Sanju Samson's underwhelming run in IPL 2026, saying the wicketkeeper-batter is "going through the process of connecting" with Chennai Super Kings and he is "desperate" to score runs and contribute to the team's success.

Samson, who joined the Super Kings from Rajasthan Royals amid much hype ahead of IPL 2026, has so far managed 6, 7, 9 in first three matches.

"It's difficult when you've been at a franchise (RR) for some time and even though he probably feels pretty com-

fortable there's still an element of belonging and he's going through the process of connecting with this team," said Fleming in the post-match press conference.

Samson's modest outings at the top has robbed CSK of the desired quick beginning in this IPL, but Fleming said the Kerala man is "desperate" to find his rhythm.

"The team (CSK) has got five or six changes. So, it's not like it's a set team. There's a little bit of work to be done off the field that we're doing just to make the bonds a bit tighter but he's fine. He's fitted in really well.

"He's desperate for some runs and to contribute along



with the senior players. We saw with his World Cup (campaign) what can happen and when a batter gets on a run he is one guy that can be very dangerous. So, there'll

be nothing but support and confidence given from us to Sanju as he forges his path in yellow," he added.

Fleming said they needed to be patient with young

CSK players such as Ayush Mhatre to find their consistency, who, he said, will form the core of Chennai in the years to come.

Mhatre shone with a fifty in the previous game against Punjab Kings but got out for 1 against Bengaluru.

"Yeah, it's a good balance, isn't it? You can see the talent but you are also going to accept that there are going to be mistakes. There's some huge talent and going forward it's going to be a really good core of Indian players, batters in particular.

"But you're going to get a little bit of inconsistency from some of the young players but you're also going

to get some brilliance. He's got a pretty good mentor there with Mike Hussey who is a pretty good batting coach and understanding of the game.

"So, it's trying to marry that skill with a bit of game sense and that does take time but we'll be trying to get as much of that into these young players as possible but without stifling their natural ability," he detailed.

The former New Zealand skipper said a combination of Tim David's power-hitting and CSK bowlers' failure to execute their plans consigned the five-time champions to their third straight defeat in IPL 2026. (PTI)

Way to go upwards is to get good work ethic going: Ashwin on CSK's woes

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Bogged down by a third successive loss this IPL season, Chennai Super Kings team management must work on keeping a "hurting" dressing room in good spirits to arrest the slide, Indian spin legend R Ashwin has said.

CSK suffered a crushing 43-run defeat to Royal Challengers Bengaluru on Sunday to remain at the bottom of the points table with three straight reverses.



Speaking on JioHotstar, Ashwin and former South African captain Faf du Plessis analysed CSK's problems.

"I am sure the dressing room atmosphere is going to

be hurting. I am not too sure how hard the words can be, but honestly, with such a young side, there is only one way you can go and that is upwards.

Sha'Carri Richardson storms from scratch to a stunning Stawell Gift win

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Stawell (Australia)

American sprint star Sha'Carri Richardson surged through the field Monday to win the Stawell Gift, an annual race contested on handicap over 120 meters on grass in a small Australian town near Melbourne.

In the 144th edition of the event, Richardson provided one of its most breathtaking finales as she started at scratch and caught the field at the 90-meter mark before pulling away for an astonishing win in 13.15 seconds.

"Just make sure I'm patient that first 10-meters like my coach today told me, and just executing the rest," Richardson told Seven Network television post race. "I think I realised I was gonna win right past 90." The 26-year-old American, one of the fastest women of all time, is just the third woman to win the race from scratch and claimed a prize of 40,000 Australian dollars (\$27,500).

Richardson won a silver medal in the 100 meters in the 2024 Paris Olympics, and gold in the 4x100 relay that



same year. She also claimed the 100-metre title at the 2023 World Championships.

After a near calamity in the semifinals earlier Monday, where Richardson rose too soon and was almost pipped on the line, the American made no errors in the final, chasing down the field early and running through the line powerfully.

She celebrated with fans before embracing boyfriend and former world champion Christian Coleman, who was the marquee name of the men's draw.